

WHILE YOU LIVE · BOOK 2

CQD

Andrew F. Young



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Contents

1	The Neighbor	5
2	The Warmer Coat	12
3	The Bellboy	19
4	The Wireless Room	27
5	Did You Know?	34
6	Full Speed	40
7	The Boats	48
8	The List	55
9	Monday	63
10	Two Car Doors	70
11	The Hands	76
12	The Foot of the Stairs	84
13	The Little Girl's Name	93
14	Spring Break	99
15	The Boot Room	105
16	The Governess	113
17	Fourteen Photographs	121
18	Pages in the Wake	127
19	Petworth	134
20	You Knew	140
21	Pier 54	144
22	The End of the Bed	151
23	Aristeas	157

24	The Letter	162
25	Spring Sale	168
26	The Second Part	174
	Facts	180

The Neighbor

The coat was at the back of the hall closet, behind Freda's old soccer bag and a vacuum cleaner that had not worked since the fall.

It was a good coat. Long, dark green wool, with a hood that folded away into the collar and pockets deep enough for two notebooks and a recorder. I had bought it the winter I started working on the Carrow House story, because I was going to be standing in a lot of parking lots, and I had worn it every day until the story ran. After that I had hung it up and not taken it down again. I had not been going anywhere that needed it.

Bring a warmer coat, he had said.

I took it off the hanger and held it up to the light in the hall. There was a moth hole in one sleeve and a button hanging by a thread, and it smelled of the closet. I put it on anyway, over my sweatshirt, and stood in front of the mirror on the bathroom door. A woman of forty-four in a coat she had bought at thirty-eight, looking about as surprised as you would expect.

It still fit. I was not sure how I felt about that.



If you do not know me, here is how I came to be standing in a hall closet on a Sunday night, thinking about the North Atlantic.

My name is Iola Barnett. I used to be a reporter. Six years ago I broke a story about forged letters being sold as genuine at Carrow House, the old auction house downtown, and three days after it ran, the man who had given me the story disappeared. Without him, nobody believed a word of it. The paper print-

ed a correction and let me go. Since then I have written whatever people pay me to write: gutter guards, dentists, houses that need to sound bigger than they are.

Last fall a law firm called Aldine, Mercer and Voss wrote to me on behalf of a client who would not give his name. The client wanted me to drive two hours north every Thursday and record the memories of an old man who lived alone in a small house full of books. He paid three thousand dollars a session, more than I had made in a month in years. The old man's name, as far as anybody knew, was Tom Hale. He was somewhere in his seventies. He told me, on the first day, that he remembered 1865.

He did not mean that he had read about it. He meant that he had been there. That he had woken up one July afternoon in 1864 in the body of a wounded Confederate soldier outside Washington, and had lived in that body for a year, and had been in the city the night Lincoln was shot. He said it had happened to him a great many times, in a great many places. He said he did not know why.

I did not believe him. I want to be clear about that. I spent eighteen Thursdays not believing him, and checking everything he said, and finding that everything he said checked out. In the end I went to the Library of Congress and found a letter in a box nobody had asked for in twenty-two years. It matched what he had told me, line for line, and he had never seen it. I had a copy of it in a folder in my bag. I had meant to show it to him last Thursday, and I had not, because of the card.

The card had come by courier on a Monday night, in the client's own hand. That hand had started to shake. There was one line on it.

Please ask him about the Carpathia.

The Carpathia was the ship that picked up the survivors of the Titanic, in April of 1912. In eighteen weeks he had never said a word about it to me, and I had the transcripts to prove it. When I read him the card he sat for forty seconds without moving, which I know because I counted. Then he said he had never told a living soul where he was in April of 1912. Then he said yes. He had been there.

And then he told me to bring a warmer coat.



Freda was at the kitchen table when I came back through, with her laptop open and a pair of big white headphones on, typing.

She was sixteen. She had her father's height and, lately, a habit of looking up at me as if I had walked into the wrong room. She had started typing my transcripts that week. It had been her idea. Ever since the night I told her about the letter in the archive, she had been asking about him, and on Friday she had heard me complain that it took me three hours to type up every hour of tape, and she had said, without looking up from her phone, that she could do it in two, and that she would do it for fifteen dollars an hour, and that I should think about it. I had thought about it for about a minute. It was the best deal anyone had offered me in six years, and it kept her at the kitchen table on a Sunday night, where I could see her.

She was doing last Thursday's tape. Her first one, the Carpathia tape. It was a short one. Most of it was snow.

I put the kettle on and watched her. She typed fast and very straight, with her shoulders up around her ears. Every so often she stopped, and pressed one finger to the headphones, and went back a few seconds, and listened again.

They were new, the headphones. I noticed it the way you notice a new picture on a friend's wall. Big and white and soft at the ears, the kind that closed out the world. The old ones had been a pair of my earbuds with one side that only worked if you held the wire at an angle.

"Those are nice," I said.

She took one side off. "What?"

"The headphones."

"Oh." She looked at them as if she had forgotten they were on her head.

"Maddie's sister was getting rid of them. She got new ones."

"That was nice of her."

"She's nice." Freda put the side back on, and then took it off again. "He sounds really different on this one."

"Who does?"

“Him. Mr. Hale.” She turned the laptop so I could see the screen, though there was nothing on it but the words. “On the bits you play me, he talks like he’s reading you a book. He’s never in a hurry. On this one he’s like...” She looked for it. “He’s like somebody who just found out his house got broken into.”

I had been in the room. I had not thought of it like that. I had thought he sounded frightened, and I had not let myself write the word down.

“He was surprised,” I said.

“He’s never surprised. That’s his whole thing.” She pulled the laptop back. “Who’s the client, really?”

“I don’t know.”

“You must have some idea.”

“I’ve got lots of ideas. None of them are any good.”

“Somebody who knows about the boat,” Freda said, “when nobody’s supposed to know about the boat.” She put the headphones back on. “So it’s either somebody he told and forgot he told, or somebody who was on the boat.”

“Nobody who was on that boat is still alive.”

Freda typed for a moment.

“Nobody who was at Ford’s Theatre is still alive either,” she said, without looking up. “And you’re still driving up there.”



That night, after she had gone to bed, I sat at the kitchen table with the coat on the back of my chair and did what I had been putting off all week.

I opened the transcript from the sixth week. Not the Lincoln parts. The lunch.

It was the day he had made the soup, back in the fall, and asked me about myself, and I had told him the whole Carrow House story, badly and out of order. I had typed it up that night the same as everything else, because the client wanted all of it. I had never read it back. I did not like reading my own voice telling that story. It sounded like every crank who had ever called a newsroom.

I read it back now, slowly, with a pencil.

The diner. The grilled cheese and the tomato soup he always ordered and never ate. The laundromat. The building where my source lived, a brick walk-up over a dry cleaner's. Petrakis, the landlord, who complained about everything. The steam that came up through the floor in the mornings, so the whole building smelled of hot cotton.

A woman on the second floor called Petrakis about noise so often that he had stopped answering her.

I put the pencil on that line and left it there.

All winter I had been going over the same few facts, the way you turn over a stone in your pocket until it is smooth. The cat shut in the bedroom, because somebody was at the door. The family photographs still on the wall. The two banker's boxes of papers gone from the closet by the door, and not a word about them in the police report. He had put it together for me, at his kitchen table, a few weeks ago. My source had not run. He had opened his door to somebody he knew. And somebody had left with his papers.

Who was at the door?

I had written that on the back of an envelope the night I drove home, and I had looked at it every day since, and I had not done one useful thing about it. I had decided it had been six years. That the dry cleaner's was a smoothie place now. That Petrakis had sold the building and moved in with his daughter in Silver Spring, and that the police had never cared, and that nobody remembered a knock on a door on a Wednesday morning six years ago. I had asked the police for the whole file, the officer's notes and the photographs and anything else behind those two thin pages, and that was all I had done, and the police had not answered.

But somebody might. A woman who called the landlord so often about noise that he stopped picking up was a woman who listened. She listened through her ceiling, every day, to a building full of other people's lives. She had lived one floor below him. If anyone in the world had heard that door, it was her.

And I had known she existed for six years. I had made a joke about her at lunch. I had never once asked her name.



Petrakis answered on the fourth ring, and I could hear a television behind him, very loud.

“The reporter,” he said, when I told him who it was. He did not sound pleased, but he did not sound displeased either. Petrakis sounded the same about everything. “You called about the cat.”

“In the fall. Yes. You were a big help.”

“The cat was a good cat.” He said something away from the phone, in Greek, and the television got quieter. “What now? I don’t own that building anymore. I told you. Smoothies.”

“I’m not calling about the building. I’m calling about one of your tenants. There was a woman on the second floor, when he lived there. She used to call you about the noise.”

There was a pause. Then Petrakis laughed, a short, unhappy bark.

“Dunleavy.”

“Is that her name?”

“Mrs. Dunleavy. Second floor, front. Thirty years she lived in that building, and for thirty years she called me.” He was warming up now. I could hear it. “The radiator. The pipes. The man upstairs walks too heavy. The dry cleaner’s machine starts too early. A dog barks on the street, she calls me, like I own the street. Every day. Some days twice. I had to get a second phone.”

“Is she still living?”

“Still living? She will outlive us all. Out of spite.” He paused. “She moved when I sold. Before, even. Went to live with her son, out in Frederick somewhere. I don’t have the address. I didn’t want the address.”

“Do you remember her first name?”

“Why do you want Mrs. Dunleavy?”

I thought about how to answer that. Petrakis had been kind to me, in the fall, in his way. He had remembered the cat’s name for me after six years, when I could not.

“Because she lived right under him,” I said. “And I think she heard everything.”

The line was quiet for long enough that I thought we had been cut off. Behind him the television murmured. Somebody on it was winning a car.

“Eileen,” Petrakis said. “Eileen Dunleavy. She was a widow. Her husband drove a bus.” Then, grudgingly, as if it cost him money to say it: “She heard everything. That is true. You could not cough in that building without Mrs. Dunleavy telling me what kind of cough it was.”



It was after midnight when I went to hang the coat back up, and that was when I found the receipt.

It was in the right-hand pocket, folded small, soft as cloth from six years of nothing. I almost threw it away without looking. Then I unfolded it under the hall light.

Grilled cheese 6.50. Tomato soup cup 3.25. Coffee 2.00.

It was from the diner. From one of the winter meetings, the long ones, when he talked and I wrote and the food went cold in front of him. He had ordered it the way he always did, and pushed it a little away from himself, and never touched it, and I had paid, the way I always did, because I was the one with the expense account and he was the one taking the risk.

I stood in the hall for a long time.

Then I took the coat off the hanger again and put it over the back of the kitchen chair, where I would not forget it on Thursday, and I put the receipt in my notebook, and on a clean page under it I wrote:

Eileen Dunleavy. Second floor, front. Son in Frederick.

She heard everything.

I did not underline anything. I did not have to. Down the hall, under Freda's door, there was still a line of light, and very faintly, through the door and the headphones both, I could hear my daughter laughing at something on her phone. It was the low, careful laugh she saved for friends, and I did not know which friend, and I went to bed.

The Warmer Coat

The snow had gone to rain by Thursday, and the gravel road up to his house had gone to mud.

I took it slowly, in second gear, with the wipers going and the coat on the passenger seat beside me, folded, like a passenger who had not decided yet whether to come in. The field beyond the house was brown again, with white still lying in the furrows where the sun did not reach. The old blue pickup was where it always was. Smoke came out of the chimney and lay down flat across the roof in the wet.

He was at the window. He was always at the window. By the time I had parked he was on the porch, with the big umbrella open, coming down the steps one at a time with his free hand on the rail.

I put the coat on in the car, which is harder than it sounds, and got out.

He stopped at the bottom of the steps and looked at me. It was a short look, and a thorough one. He took in the hood folded into the collar, and the button hanging by its thread, and the moth hole in the sleeve that I had tried to hide by holding my bag on that arm. Then he smiled, the smile that took ten years off him.

“Good,” he said. “That’s a working coat.”

“It’s an old coat.”

“It’s both.” He held the umbrella over me, though I was already wet. “You bought it for standing about outside in, and you stood about in it a great deal, and then one day you stopped. The pockets have gone out of shape from the notebooks, and the hem is worn on the right side where your bag hangs. You

haven't worn it in a long time. It smelled of the closet when you got out of the car. It still does, a little." He turned toward the house. "I'm glad you brought it. Come in. The kettle's on."



The house was warm, and smelled of woodsmoke and wet wool and something baking. There was a loaf on the kitchen counter in a paper bag from the town bakery, with a hand-lettered sign taped to the bag: *LAST WEEK. THANK YOU FOR 61 YEARS.*

"They're closing," I said.

"Saturday." He put the tea things on the tray. "The grandchildren didn't want it. I bought two loaves. I'll put one in the freezer and feel sorry for myself in June." He carried the tray through to the living room. "You'll have to tell me how your week was. Before we start."

He asked it every Thursday, and every Thursday I had given him the short answer, because I was being paid to listen and not to talk. This Thursday I sat down in the chair that did not eat people and gave him the long one.

I told him about the transcript from the sixth week, and the line I had put my pencil on. The woman on the second floor. I told him that I had called Petrakis, and that Petrakis had called her a name I would not write down, and then given me her real one. Eileen Dunleavy. A widow, whose husband had driven a bus. Thirty years in that building. Gone to her son's, out near Frederick.

"Frederick," he said. "You drove past it this morning."

"I know."

"Are you going to find her?"

"I'm going to try." I put my cup down. "I don't know what I expect her to tell me. It was six years ago. She heard everything in that building, every day, for thirty years. Why would she remember one Wednesday?"

He was quiet for a moment. He had the notepad on his knee and the pencil in his hand, but he was not drawing.

"Ms. Barnett," he said. "Petrakis stopped answering her."

"He got a second phone. He told me."

“So for some years, every time Mrs. Dunleavy heard something wrong through her ceiling, she picked up the phone and called the man whose job it was to fix it, and he didn’t pick up.” He tilted his head. “What does a woman do, when she knows something and nobody will listen to her?”

I did not answer at once, because I knew the answer, and I did not much like where it came from.

“She writes it down,” I said.

“With the date,” he said. “And the time. So that one day, when somebody finally asks, she can prove it.” He looked at me over his cup. “You did exactly that. You have a box at the top of a closet that says so. I would be very surprised if Mrs. Dunleavy hasn’t got one too.”

I sat back. Outside the rain had picked up, and it ran down the window in long uneven lines.

“There’s something else,” I said. “I didn’t tell you last week. There wasn’t time, after the card.”

I told him about the movers. The small outfit from across the river, still in business, with the woman on the phone who said they kept their job sheets for seven years. The job booked by phone eleven days before my source disappeared, with a cash deposit. And the line for the new address, left blank, with a note written beside it in somebody’s hand: *Customer to call with address.*

“He never called,” I said.

He did not say anything for a long moment. The pencil lay still on the pad.

“Eleven days,” he said at last. “He booked a truck to take everything he owned out of that apartment, eleven days before a Saturday. And he didn’t know where it was going.”

“He told me he was going to move after the story ran. Somewhere Carrow couldn’t find him.”

“Yes. But a man who is going somewhere knows where it is. He’s chosen it, he’s paid a deposit on it, he’s carried a box of dishes up its stairs in his head a hundred times. Your man had a truck and no address.” He turned the pencil over in his fingers. “So either he was going to decide at the last minute, which doesn’t sound like a man who kept copies of everything. Or somebody else was finding him the place. And he was waiting to be told.”

“Somebody he trusted.”

“Somebody he trusted enough to let them choose where he would live,” he said, “when he was more frightened than he had ever been.” He looked toward the window. “Which is a great deal of trust, Ms. Barnett. It’s more than most people give anyone.”

I wrote it down. I wrote, *Somebody finding him a place?* and, under it, *Same person at the door?* and then I looked at what I had written and did not like it at all.



At ten past eleven I set the recorders on the little table between us, my phone and the small digital one that had been with me for eleven years, and pressed the buttons and said the date into them, and the time, and *Session nineteen*.

Then I looked at him and waited. It was his turn.

“April 1912,” he said. “I was twelve.”

I laughed. I did not mean to. It came out of me before I could stop it, a short surprised sound, and I saw it go across the room and land on him, and I was sorry at once.

He didn’t laugh.

“I’m sorry,” I said. “I didn’t...”

“No. It’s all right.” He had not taken offense. He looked, if anything, a little amused at himself. “It’s a strange thing to hear. It was a strange thing to be.”

“I assumed,” I said, and stopped, and tried again. “I suppose I’d assumed you’d still be Kit. He’d have been, what. Sixty-seven?”

“He would.” He looked down at the pad. “Kit didn’t see the new century. He had a good deal more life than he expected, after 1865, and a good deal less than he wanted. That’s another Thursday.” He turned the pencil around in his fingers, once. “There were others in between, and they’re other Thursdays too. In the spring of 1912 I was very small. I was a boy on a ship, in a uniform with too many buttons, and I had been one for about three weeks when the part I want to tell you about began.”

“A boy.”

“A bellboy. On the Carpathia.” He said the name carefully, as if it were something he had kept wrapped up a long time and was not sure would still be whole. “A Cunard ship. Not a famous one, not a fast one. Steady. She went back and forth between New York and the Mediterranean with whoever wanted to go, and that spring it was mostly American ladies going to see Italy, and families going home to Hungary. I carried their bags. I ran their messages. I said *sir* and *madam* about four hundred times a day.”

“At twelve.”

“At twelve. Boys went to sea younger than that, not so long before.” He looked at me. “You’re wondering what it’s like.”

I was. I had not been going to ask. I had been going to keep to the things that could be checked, as I always did, and leave the rest for him.

“Yes,” I said.

“It’s like being a grown man locked inside a cupboard,” he said, “who can see out through the keyhole and is not allowed to speak above a whisper. Everything you know is still in there with you. Nobody on the outside wants any of it. A boy who tells a ship’s officer what he ought to do gets a clip round the ear and an extra watch, and he deserves both.” He smiled a little. “The first few weeks of that life, I was very angry. Then I remembered something I had learned a long time before, and had to learn again every time it happened.”

“What?”

“When you’re small, you don’t push. You can’t. There’s nothing to push with.” He set the pencil down on the pad. “So you make the best of what is in front of you. You find out what a small boy can do that a grown man can’t. And it turns out, Ms. Barnett, that it’s a great deal more than you would think.”

“Such as?”

“Such as nobody ever looks at him.” He picked the pencil up again, and began, without looking down, to draw. “A grown man walks into a room, and every person in it decides what he’s there for. A boy with a tray walks into the same room, and nobody decides anything. He’s furniture. He can stand by the door for ten minutes and hear everything said in that room, and if anyone no-

tices him at all, they ask him for more hot water.” The pencil moved. “I heard more on that ship, in four days, than I heard in a year at the National Hotel.”



I was going to ask him about the four days. I had the question ready. I had looked up the dates on Sunday night, and I knew the Carpathia had picked up the survivors on a Monday morning and come into New York on the Thursday night, and I was going to ask him where he had been on the Sunday, before any of it.

But I was looking at the notepad.

I had seen him draw on it every Thursday for nineteen weeks. The first day, I had even looked properly. I remembered thinking it was the kind of thing people do on the phone. One shape, over and over, gone over so many times that the lead shone. I had noticed it, and noted it, and then it had become part of him, like the cardigan buttoned wrong and the tea gone cold. I had stopped seeing it. You stop seeing anything you see every week.

A five-pointed star, drawn in one long line, without the pencil ever leaving the paper. And in each of the five points, a tiny letter, crowded in. Greek, I had thought, that first day. Or something like it.

I had seen that star somewhere else.

I had seen it ten days ago, in the reading room of the Madison Building, under a lamp, in the left margin of a letter a hundred and sixty years old. Small, beside the last line, drawn in the same brown ink as everything else, as if the pen had moved there by itself while the writer was thinking. A star, the kind you draw without lifting the pen, crowded with some foreign letters. I had looked at it and thought it was vaguely familiar, the way a lot of things are, and I had not given it a second thought. I had been too busy reading the letter.

I am one of those you spoke of.

The folder was in my bag, on the floor by my chair. Six feet from his knee. Again.

“Ms. Barnett?”

I looked up. He was watching me, the pencil still, his head a little on one side.

“Sorry,” I said. “Go on. Where were you, the Sunday night?”

He looked at me a moment longer. Then he looked at the window, at the rain, and began.

I did not hear the first thing he said. I had to get it off the tape that night, at the kitchen table, after Freda had gone to bed, with the photocopy laid out flat in front of me under the light and the drawing I had made of his star from memory beside it. I had drawn it four times before I was happy with it. I had never drawn it before. My hand went around the five points in one line, the way his did, the way the letter’s did, as if it had been waiting to.

It was the same star.

I sat and looked at the two of them for a long time, and then I put on the headphones and pressed play, and listened to him begin, and to myself not saying anything at all.

The Bellboy

• RECORDING · MARCH 1912

The first thing I knew was that I was holding a tray, and the floor was moving.

Not much. A long slow lean to one side, and a long slow lean back, the kind you stop noticing after a day at sea and never stop noticing in your knees. There was a cup and saucer on the tray, and a little silver pot, and a plate with two biscuits on it, and all of it was sliding very gently toward my chest. My hands were already tilting the tray to stop it. They knew how. I didn't.

I have told you my rule for the first hour of a life. Say nothing. Move as little as you can. Watch.

It's a hard rule to keep with a full pot of tea.

I was in a corridor. White painted walls, a long red carpet, brass rails, doors with numbers on them, electric lights in little glass shades that swung a quarter inch every time the floor leaned. The air smelled of coal smoke and polish and the sea, and very faintly of cabbage from somewhere below. A ship, then. A big one. The hum of her engines came up through the soles of my feet, through the whole of my body, like a cat purring against your chest.

And my body was very small.

You notice it at once. Everything is too high. The door handles were at the height of my ribs. The brass rail along the wall was at my shoulder. My wrists stuck out of a pair of navy sleeves with a row of brass buttons up the front of the jacket, more buttons than any jacket has needed in the history of the

world, and there was a tight little cap on my head held on by a strap under the chin. I could feel that my knees were bony, and my feet hurt in a pair of boots a size too small, and somewhere in the front of my mouth there was a tooth that wobbled when I pressed my tongue to it.

A boy. A child. I had not been one in a very long time.

“Boy!”

A door down the corridor had opened, and a woman was leaning out of it. American, in a pink wrapper, with her hair in a net and a face that had been waiting.

“Is that my tea? I rang for it twenty minutes ago.”

“Yes, madam,” said my mouth, in a high clear voice I had never heard before, flat and quick, with every vowel squeezed. Liverpool. The body knows its own accent. “Sorry, madam. Busy in the pantry, madam.”

I carried the tray down the corridor without spilling anything, which was the body’s doing and not mine, and she took it from me at the door and looked at me, and I looked at the carpet, because the body seemed to think that was the right place to look.

“You’re the one who’s always whistling,” she said.

“Yes, madam.”

“Well, don’t,” she said, and shut the door.



It took me most of that first day to find out who I was. It always does. You don’t ask. You listen, and you let other people tell you, and they always do, if you wait.

My name was Albert Pike. Nobody called me that. I was Bertie, to the other boys, and *boy* to the passengers, and *Pike* to the second steward, a heavy, tired man called Lyle who ran the bell boys like a farmer runs dogs. I was twelve years old. I had been at sea for a year. I came from Bootle, outside Liverpool, where my mother lived with my three younger sisters in two rooms off the Stanley Road, and every month most of my wages went home to her. I knew that because there was a letter from her in my locker, in pencil, thanking me for the last one and telling me Agnes had the croup again.

I knew the ship was the Carpathia, because it was written on everything, on the towels and the life rings and the menus and the little brass plate by the purser's office. She was a Cunarder. Not one of the great ones. She had one tall red funnel with a black top, and she rolled, and she was slow, and the passengers who had sailed on the Mauretania told you so. She went back and forth between New York and the Mediterranean, carrying whoever wanted to go: tourists going east to see Italy, and families going home, and families leaving home for good.

We were coming west, then, toward New York, and still a good way out. I worked that out from the menu cards.

I learned the rest from Stan Malley. Stan was fourteen, the oldest of the bell boys, with a broken front tooth and a talent for knowing which passengers tipped. He slept in the bunk over mine, in a cabin down on E deck with four other boys and no porthole, and he talked to the underside of the deck above him every night until he fell asleep in the middle of a word.

"You're quiet," he said to me, the second night. "You been quiet since yesterday."

"Got a headache."

"You never get headaches."

"Got one now."

"You want to watch Lyle," said Stan. "He's got his eye on you since the business with the soap." And he told me, before I had to ask, all about the business with the soap, which had happened before I arrived, and which I had apparently enjoyed very much.



That is the strangest part of it, Ms. Barnett, every time. Not the waking. The finding out what kind of person you've been.

The body keeps what it knows how to do. I've told you that. Bertie Pike's body knew every ladder and passage on that ship. It could go from the boat deck down to the third-class dining saloon and back without touching a rail, at a speed that made the stewards swear. It knew how to carry six cups on a tray in a swell. It knew how to take a coin from a passenger's hand without

seeming to, and say *thank you, sir* in a way that made the next coin larger. It could whistle through the gap in its teeth, loud enough to make a lady in a pink wrapper complain.

What it did not keep was anything Bertie had thought. Whether he was happy. Whether he missed his mother. Whether he was the kind of boy who took the extra biscuit or the kind who gave his to Stan. I had to work all of that out from the outside, from how the others treated him, from the soap, from the letter in the locker. And then I had to go on being him, as near as I could, so that nobody noticed he had gone.

I have done that a great many times. It never gets easier when the body is a child. A grown man who changes overnight is thought to be ill, or in love, or in trouble. A boy who changes overnight is thought to be up to something. Lyle watched me for a week.

I gave him nothing to see. I carried the trays and ran the messages and took the coins and said *sir* and *madam*, and I did not whistle, which Stan noticed and Lyle noticed and neither of them understood. The truth was that I couldn't. Bertie whistled through the gap where a tooth had been. I had never had that gap before, and I could not work out how to use it.



The one thing I could not do was sleep.

The body was tired. It went to sleep the moment it lay down, every night, like a stone dropped down a well. But I did not go with it. I lay in the dark in the bunk under Stan's, with the engines going through the hull and the other boys breathing, and I was wide awake inside a sleeping child, the way you are wide awake in a strange house.

An old man's sleep, in a boy's body. It happens. It passes, after a few weeks, when the mind settles into the body and they agree on things. Until then, you get up.

So I got up. The third night, and most nights after. I put on my trousers and my jacket and went up through the ship in my socks, carrying my boots, because a boy in socks can go anywhere on a ship at two in the morning and a boy in boots is heard.

I learned her that way. Every corridor, every ladder, every door that stuck. The night steward in the first-class pantry, an old Welshman called Evans who could not sleep either, and who would give a boy a mug of cocoa if the boy would sit and let him talk about his chapel. The quartermaster on the bridge wing who pretended not to see me. The engine room, where I was not allowed, and where the stokers let me stand at the top of the ladder and watch them feed the fires with the sweat running into their eyes.

And the wireless cabin.

It was a little room on the boat deck, not much bigger than a cupboard, with a bunk at one side and a desk at the other, and on the desk a great deal of brass and wire and black boxes, and a key, and a pair of headphones. The Marconi Company had put it there, and the Marconi Company owned it, and the young man who sat in it all day and half the night was a Marconi man, not a Cunard one. His name was Harold Cottam. He was twenty-one years old. He was the only wireless operator on the ship.

He had the light on, the first time I went past, at a quarter to one in the morning. The door was hooked open for the air, and he was sitting at the desk with the headphones on, writing on a pad, and his tea had gone cold beside him with a skin on top.

He looked up and saw a bell boy in socks, holding his boots, looking in at his door.

"You're up late," he said.

"Can't sleep, sir."

"Nor can I, it seems." He took one side of the headphones off. "Don't call me sir. I'm not an officer. They don't know what to do with me." He looked at the cold tea and made a face. "I don't suppose you know where a man could get a hot drink at this hour?"

I did. I went down to Evans in the pantry, and Evans made two mugs of cocoa and told me about his chapel, and I carried them up to the boat deck without spilling a drop.

That was the first night. After that, most nights, if the light was on in the wireless cabin, I brought him cocoa. He would take off one side of the head-

phones and drink it, and I would stand in the door, and he would tell me what he was hearing.

It was a whole world, Ms. Barnett. I had never thought about it. All across that ocean, in the dark, the ships were talking to each other. Not in voices. In sparks, in dots and dashes, each operator with his own hand that the others knew the way you know a friend's knock. Messages for passengers. Weather. Ice. Prices on the stock exchange in New York for gentlemen in first class who could not bear not to know. Gossip, between the operators, late at night, when the traffic was slow. Who had a cold. Who was in trouble with his chief. Which ship had the best food.

He let me listen, once. He put the headphones over my cap. It was a thin dry crackle, like frying, far away, and through it, now and then, a tiny high whine that came and went in a pattern.

"That's Cape Cod," he said. "Talking to a German, I think. You can tell by the hand."

I could not tell anything. But I was in the room, and the room was warm, and the sea was black and enormous on the other side of the wall, and in that little cupboard of brass and wire a young man was listening to the whole of it.

I want you to understand that I didn't know anything, Ms. Barnett. I am not a prophet. I've told you so. I didn't know what ship had sailed from Southampton the day before we sailed from New York, or what was waiting for her, or that it would have anything to do with us. I was an old man who couldn't sleep, in the body of a boy, and I liked that room better than any other place on the ship. That's all it was.

That is what I keep coming back to. That's all it was.



We came into New York in the first days of April, and lay at the Cunard pier on the North River for some days, and took on coal and stores and passengers for the run back east.

I saw the city from the boat deck. I had seen it before, in another life, and it had grown since, upward, as it always does. Bertie Pike had seen it a dozen

times and found it ordinary, and his body didn't even turn to look. I stood at the rail with a broom I was supposed to be using and looked until Lyle shouted.

On Thursday, the eleventh of April, we sailed.

You have to picture that pier, that morning. Piles of trunks with labels on them for Gibraltar and Genoa and Naples and Trieste and Fiume. The first-class passengers coming up the gangway in good coats, Americans mostly, going to see the Old World, with guidebooks under their arms and their maids behind them. The families in third class, going home to Hungary and Croatia and the mountains behind Fiume, with everything they owned in bundles and baskets, and children asleep on top of the bundles. A band, somewhere, playing something cheerful and out of tune.

I carried bags for two hours without stopping.

There was a man in second class I remember from that morning, though there was no reason to then. A thin man, about forty, in a brown suit gone shiny at the elbows, carrying his own bag, which nobody in a brown suit ever does. A typewriter case, a small one, which he would not let me take from him.

"I'll manage it," he said, when I reached for it. "It's all I've got that's worth stealing."

He gave me a nickel anyway, at the door of his cabin, and asked my name. Passengers never ask your name. I told him.

"Bertie." He looked at me, properly, the way passengers never look at you either. "I'm Hatch. I write things, for the magazines, when they'll have me. Going to Naples to write about Vesuvius, if Vesuvius will cooperate." He smiled. "If you see anything worth writing about, Bertie, you come and tell me. I pay better than a nickel."

I said I would. I didn't think about him again for four days.

We cast off at noon, or near it. The tugs took us out into the river, and the city slid away behind us, and we turned south past the Statue and out through the Narrows into the open sea. I watched from the boat deck with a tray of beef tea for the ladies, until Lyle found me.

That night the light was on in the wireless cabin, and I brought up the cocoa.



He stopped there, and reached for his tea, and found it cold, and drank it anyway.

“Thursday,” he said. “We sailed on the Thursday. On the Sunday night, I couldn’t sleep again.”

The Wireless Room

• RECORDING · APRIL 14, 1912

Sunday was a long day. They always were, at sea.

There was a service in the first-class saloon in the morning, and the bell boys stood at the back in clean collars and held the hymn books for the ladies who had forgotten theirs. The captain came down for it. He was a new captain, that year, a slight, quick man called Rostron, with a way of turning his whole body toward whatever he was looking at. The stewards called him the Electric Spark, though never where he could hear. He gave orders faster than any officer I had ever served under, in any life, and he gave them quietly, and he did not give them twice.

I watched him through the hymns. I watched everyone. It was a habit I could not have broken if I had wanted to, and on that ship it was the only thing I had that was mine. A boy who cannot speak still has his eyes.

In the afternoon I carried beef tea and letters and rugs. Mr. Hatch, the man with the typewriter, had set himself up in a corner of the second-class smoking room with the case open on his knees, and he was typing with two fingers, very fast, and smoking, and frowning at the window. He looked up as I went by with the tray and said, "Anything worth writing about yet, Bertie?" and I said, "No, sir," and he said, "Me neither," and went back to his two fingers.

Lyle found me at four and made me polish the brass on the main stair, all of it, because a lady had complained that I looked at her. I don't know which lady. I looked at all of them. It took until dinner.

That night the body fell asleep at ten, like a stone down a well, and I lay awake inside it and listened to the engines and to Stan, above me, talking to the deck about a girl in Bootle he had never spoken to.

At a quarter to twelve I got up.



Evans was in the pantry with his feet up on a crate and his collar undone, reading his Welsh Bible by the light over the sink. He looked up when I came in carrying my boots, and sighed, and put the kettle on without being asked.

"He'll be in bed, that one," he said. "He's been on that machine since seven this morning. Even a Marconi man has to sleep."

"His light's on, Mr. Evans."

"His light's always on." He made the cocoa in two mugs and put a saucer over each to keep the heat in. "Go on, then. And you come straight back down and get in your bunk, or Lyle will have your hide and mine with it."

I went up through the ship.

You have to understand how quiet a ship is, at that hour, on a calm night. The passengers are asleep. The stewards are asleep, except the one or two on watch, and they are sitting down. The engines are the only thing awake, and after a while you stop hearing them, and the whole great ship seems to be holding its breath and gliding.

I came out onto the boat deck, and the cold took the breath out of me.

It had been cold all evening. Now it was something else. The kind of cold that has no wind in it, that just stands there. The sea was perfectly flat. I had never seen the Atlantic like that, in any life, before or since. Not a ripple. Black, and still, and polished, like a floor somebody had just finished waxing. There was no moon. And the stars came all the way down to the water on every side, so many of them, so bright, that I could not tell where the sky stopped and the sea began, and for a moment I stood at the top of the ladder with a mug of cocoa in each hand and did not know which way was up.

Then I went along to the wireless cabin.

The door was hooked open, and the light was on. He was sitting on the edge of his bunk with his jacket off and his collar off and one boot already

unlaced, bent over, working at the laces of the other. He still had the headphones on. The wire ran from his head across the little room to the desk, as if the machine had him on a leash.

"Bertie," he said, without looking up. "You're a saint. Put it on the desk."

I put it on the desk. I gave him the other mug, and he sat back against the wall of the cabin with his one boot off and the other half off and drank it, with his eyes closed.

"I'm going to bed," he said. "As soon as this is gone. I'm waiting on the Parisian. I sent her something this afternoon and she's to confirm it, and then I'm going to bed, and nobody is to wake me until we're in Gibraltar."

"Yes, sir."

"Don't call me sir." He opened his eyes. "Cape Cod's been at it all evening. Messages for the Titanic, piles of them. Private traffic. Rich men on board telling other rich men where to put their money." He tapped the headphones. "She's out of Cape Cod's reach, out where she is. They'll have to wait till she comes in range of Cape Race in the morning."

"Is she really as big as they say, sir? The Titanic?"

I want to be careful here, Ms. Barnett, because I have gone over this a great many times, and I want to tell it to you exactly as it was and no better.

I asked him that because I wanted to keep him talking.

That's all. I didn't know anything. I've told you. I was a boy who couldn't sleep, holding a mug of cocoa in a warm room on a cold night, and I didn't want to go back down to the bunk under Stan and lie awake in the dark. If he went to bed, I'd have to go too. So I asked him a question I knew he would like to answer, because all the wireless men were talking about her that month, about her set, the most powerful at sea, and her two operators, who were Marconi men like him and whom he knew by their hands. I asked it to buy myself ten more minutes in that room.

He laughed. He liked the question, as I knew he would.

"Bigger," he said. "She's the biggest thing ever put on water. Phillips and Bride are on her. Jack Phillips. He's the senior man. They've been working that set flat out since Southampton, poor devils, every millionaire on board wanting to send a telegram to his mother." He drank his cocoa and looked at

the desk, at the pile of forms from Cape Cod, all addressed to the same ship. "You know what, Bertie. I'll tell her. She can't hear Cape Cod, but she'll hear me. I'll tell them there's a pile waiting for them, and they can take it off Cape Race in the morning and save themselves the trouble of asking." He set the mug down and leaned across to the desk, his one boot still on, the laces trailing. "Do a fellow operator a good turn."

He put his hand on the key.



I couldn't read what he sent. Not then. It was only a stutter of sound to me, his wrist moving, the spark crackling in the box behind the wall. He sent it, and sat back, and reached for his cocoa.

And then his hand stopped.

It stopped just short of the mug. I saw it. I had been watching his face, because I always watched faces, and I saw it change. Not much, at first. The way a man's face changes when he hears his name called in a crowd and isn't yet sure it was his. His head tilted. His other hand came up and pressed the headphones tighter to his ears.

Then he grabbed the pencil.

He wrote very fast, on the pad, in capitals, and I stood in the door and watched the pencil, because I could read that. I could read it upside down, as it went.

COME AT ONCE. WE HAVE STRUCK A BERG. ITS A CQD OM.

And then a position, in numbers. Latitude and longitude.

He sat and looked at it. He did not move for perhaps two seconds, and I will tell you that in all the lives I have lived I have seen a great many people receive bad news, and I have never seen it land on anyone as completely as it landed on Harold Cottam that night, sitting on the edge of his bunk with one boot off.

Then his hand went to the key again, very fast.

"What are you sending?" I said. My voice came out of Bertie high and thin.

“Asking if they’re sure. Asking if I should tell my captain.” He was listening hard. He wrote again, three words.

YES COME QUICK.

He was on his feet before the pencil hit the desk. He tore the headphones off, and the sheet off the pad, and he went out of that door past me so fast that I felt the air of it on my face. He was running along the boat deck in his shirtsleeves, with one boot laced and one boot flapping, toward the bridge.

I went after him. I still had the cocoa in my hand. I don’t know why I didn’t put it down. I think the body was holding it.



The bridge was dark and enormous and full of cold. The officer of the watch was the first officer, Mr. Dean. He was standing by the wheelhouse with his hands behind his back, and he turned when he heard the running feet, and saw the Marconi man in his shirtsleeves with a paper in his hand, and a bell boy behind him with a mug.

Cottam pushed the paper at him. Dean read it under the shaded lamp, and I watched his face do what Cottam’s had done, only faster, because he was an officer and had been trained to let it.

He didn’t say anything. He went. He went straight down the ladder toward the captain’s quarters with Cottam at his heels, and I went after them both, and nobody stopped me, because nobody saw me. A boy on a ship at night is furniture.

Dean knocked once and opened the door.

The captain was asleep. He woke the way a man wakes who has been woken at sea before, all at once, up on one elbow in his bunk, and his first words were angry ones. He didn’t like his door opened without leave, and he said so, sharply, to both of them.

Then Cottam told him.

I was standing in the passage, behind them, in the dark. I saw the captain’s face in the light from the corridor. I saw the anger go out of it, all at once, like a lamp being turned down, and something else come into it, and settle, and stay.

“Are you sure?” he said.

“Yes, sir.”

“Absolutely certain?”

“Yes, sir.”

He was already getting up. He was in his nightshirt, a slight man with bare feet on a cold floor, and he was giving orders before his feet had found his slippers. Turn the ship. Steer north-west. He would work out the course himself and bring it to the bridge. Call the chief engineer. Call out another watch of stokers. He was pulling his trousers on while he spoke. He did not raise his voice once, and he did not say anything twice.

Then he turned around, buttoning his shirt, and saw me.

I don’t know what he saw. A bell boy in socks, with no cap, holding a mug of cocoa, in the passage outside his cabin at half past midnight, where no bell boy had any business to be. He looked at me for exactly as long as it took to decide I was useful.

“You,” he said. “What’s your name?”

“Pike, sir.”

“Pike. Do you know where the chief steward sleeps?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Go and wake him. Tell him the captain wants him in the chart room at once. At once. Then wake the purser and tell him the same. Then come back here.” He looked at the mug in my hand. “And put that down somewhere.”

I put it down on the floor of the passage, very carefully, and ran.



I ran down the stairs I had polished that afternoon, and along the corridor on B deck, in my socks, faster than I had run in that body or perhaps any body, and as I ran I felt the ship begin to lean.

She was turning. Under my feet, slowly, all thirteen thousand tons of her, she was leaning over into the turn, the way a big ship does when the helm is put hard across, and the long red carpet tilted under me, and the electric lights in their little glass shades swung out on their chains and stayed there, all of them, all down the corridor, leaning together toward the north.

I have thought about those ten minutes for a hundred and fourteen years, Ms. Barnett.

I'll tell you what I know, and what I don't. I know Harold Cottam was going to bed. He told me so. I know he was waiting on the Parisian, and that he had the headphones on while he took his boots off, and that he was the one who decided to call the Titanic, out of kindness, to save two tired men some work. Those are his. Nobody gave them to him.

What I don't know is whether he would still have been sitting there, with his headphones on, if a bell boy had not come up the ladder with a mug of cocoa and asked him whether the Titanic was really as big as they said. Whether he would have drunk his cocoa a little faster without me, and finished his laces, and put the headphones on the hook, and lain down, five minutes before the call came. Or whether he would have sat there anyway, exactly as long, waiting on the Parisian, and called her anyway, and I was only a boy in the room.

I don't know. I have never known. I never will.

I had done a great many things in a great many lives on purpose, and some of them had worked and most of them had not. That night I did nothing on purpose at all. I carried a cup of cocoa up a ladder because I couldn't sleep.

And I have never been sure, in all the years since, whether it was the most important thing I have ever done, or nothing.

Did You Know?

He stopped at one, as he always did, and said that was enough for the morning, and went to heat the soup.

I sat with the recorders still running for a minute after he had gone into the kitchen. I did that sometimes. I used to say it was to catch anything said in the doorway, which people often did, the important thing saved for when they thought you had stopped listening. Really it was to give myself a minute before I had to talk.

On the arm of his chair, the notepad lay face up. The star was on it, gone over so many times the lead shone.

I turned the recorders off.



The soup was split pea, and the bread was from the bakery, the second of his two last loaves, which he had decided not to freeze after all.

“I’d only eat it in June and be sad,” he said. “Better to eat it now and be sad in March, when it’s appropriate.”

We ate at the kitchen table, with the rain going on outside, and for a while neither of us said anything. He looked tired. He had looked tired the week before, too, and I had put it down to the card. Now I was not sure what to put it down to. He ate slowly, and broke his bread into small pieces, and did not finish them.

“Can I ask you something off the tape?” I said.

“You can ask me anything off the tape.”

“Did you know?”

He did not pretend not to understand. He put his spoon down.

“That night? No.”

“Not the ship. Not the iceberg. I understand you couldn’t have known that.” I turned my glass on the table. “I mean, did you know you’d done something. Afterward. When it was over, and they’d picked them all up. Did you ever think, that was me, I did that.”

“No,” he said.

“Never?”

“I thought, I don’t know whether that was me.” He looked at the window. “It’s not the same thing. It’s worse, in some ways. If I’d known I had done it, I could have been proud of it, or got tired of being proud of it, and put it away. If I’d known I hadn’t, I could have forgotten it. Instead I’ve carried it around for a hundred years like a stone in my shoe.”

“You could have told it differently. This morning.” I said it carefully. “You could have said you kept him at the set. That you saved them. I’d have written it down.”

“Yes.”

“Why didn’t you?”

“Because I don’t know that I did,” he said. “And you asked me to tell it the way it was.” He picked up his spoon again. “Besides. Harold Cottam heard that call. Arthur Rostron turned the ship. Every man in that engine room shoveled coal until his hands bled, to get her there. They were the ones who did it. All I did was carry a cup.”

“Evans made the cocoa,” I said.

He laughed, the real laugh, the one that surprised him.

“So he did,” he said. “I’d forgotten that. Put it in. Evans made the cocoa.”



He did not go back to 1912 after lunch. He said he would rather tell the next part fresh, on a morning, from the beginning of it, and I did not argue, because he looked as if he needed the afternoon more than I needed the tape.

He asked about Freda before I left. He did, most weeks, at the door. I told him she was typing the transcripts now, for fifteen dollars an hour, and that she was faster than I was, and that she had told me he sounded on the last tape like a man whose house had been broken into.

He stood on the porch with the umbrella furled, and thought about that.

"She's right," he said. "That's a good ear." He looked at me. "She'll hear what you leave out, you know. When you type, you tidy. You take out the ums, and the places where I stop and start again. She won't, not at first, because she doesn't know which parts you'd want gone. Read what she types. You'll learn things about me you missed sitting in the chair."

"Is that a warning?"

"It's a compliment," he said. "To her."



I passed the Frederick exit at a quarter past three, in the rain, and did not take it.

I had found the son's address on Sunday night, after the receipt, after Petrakis. It had taken about twenty minutes. There was only one Dunleavy household in the county with an Eileen in it, a split-level on a cul-de-sac on the east side of town, owned by a Kevin Dunleavy and his wife. There was a picture of the house on the county site. A basketball hoop over the garage. A ramp, newer than the house, built over the front steps.

I had not called. I did not know what I would say. *Hello, Mrs. Dunleavy, you won't remember me, but six years ago a man who lived above you went out one Wednesday and never came back, and I wondered if you happened to write down who knocked on his door.* I had made calls like that a thousand times, once. I had been good at them. I was not sure, anymore, that I was the person who made them.

I drove past, and watched the exit go by in the mirror, and decided it was because I needed to be home for Freda.



That night, after Freda had gone to her room, I did what I always did. I checked.

It did not take long. The Senate had held hearings on the Titanic within days of the Carpathia getting into New York, and every word of them had been printed, and every word of the printed record was online, searchable, on a site run by people who cared about it more than anyone has ever cared about anything. Rostron had been the very first witness, on the very first morning. The nineteenth of April, 1912. The day after he brought them in.

I read his testimony from the beginning. He had a plain way of talking, short sentences, no fuss, and you could hear in it the man Tom had described, turning his whole body toward whatever he looked at. He told them about the course he set, and the stokers, and the ice. And then, partway through, a senator asked him about the message, and how it was that he had happened to receive it, and he said this.

I will tell you this, that the wireless operator was in his cabin, at the time, not on official business at all, but just simply listening as he was undressing. He was unlacing his boots at the time. He had this apparatus on his ear, and the message came. That was the whole thing. In 10 minutes, maybe he would have been in bed, and we would not have heard the messages.

I read it twice. Then I sat back in the kitchen chair and looked at the screen for a long time.

I have thought about those ten minutes for a hundred and fourteen years.

There it was, the boots, the headphones, the ten minutes. All of it, in black and white, in a public record, under oath. Every detail he had given me that morning that I could check, I could check right here, in one sitting, at my own kitchen table.

Which was exactly the problem. I knew it was, and I made myself look at it squarely, as I would have made a junior reporter look at it. A man who had read this testimony would know about the boots. He would know about the ten minutes. He could build a beautiful story around them, with a bell boy and a mug of cocoa and a Welshman with a Bible, and every piece I could check would check, because he had taken it from the very place I would go to check it.

That was how a clever liar worked. I had written about clever liars. I had been called one.

And it was also exactly what a man who had been there would say.

I had been going back and forth like that for twenty weeks. I wrote it down, as I wrote everything down: *Rostron, Senate, day 1. Boots, headphones, 10 min. All public. Proves nothing either way.* Then under it, because I was honest with myself on paper even when I was not anywhere else: *He didn't claim it. He could have. He said it was Evans's cocoa.*



Freda came out at eleven for a glass of water. She had her headphones around her neck, the new white ones, and her laptop under her arm, and she put it down on the table across from me and opened it.

"I finished this morning's," she said. "You can check it. I left in the ums."

"He said you would."

"He said what?"

"That you'd leave things in. That I should read what you type, because I'd learn things I missed." I took the laptop. "He said you had a good ear."

Freda looked at the table. She did a thing with her mouth, a small pressed thing, that she had done since she was very small whenever someone praised her and she did not want them to see it land.

"He doesn't know," she said. "If he did it. The cocoa thing."

"No."

"That's worse. Right?" She filled her glass at the sink and stood with her back to me, drinking it. "Not knowing if you made a difference. To someone. Like, you'd rather know either way."

"He said the same thing. Almost word for word."

She turned around. "Do you think people can tell? If they made a difference to someone. Or do you just never find out?"

I looked at her. She was standing very straight, with the glass in her hand, and the question was too careful, and I did not know what it was about.

"Sometimes you find out," I said. "Usually much later. Usually when you'd stopped expecting to."

Freda nodded, as if that were an answer to something, and put the glass in the sink, and said good night, and went. The door to her room closed. It didn't slam. I sat with her transcript open in front of me, all his ums and stops and starts left in, just as he had said, and read it through to the end, and learned that he had said *I don't know* nine times in a single morning, which I had not noticed sitting in the chair.



The money came on Saturday.

It had always come on a Monday. For twenty weeks, Monday, like the electric bill. On Saturday morning, at nine o'clock, my phone buzzed on the kitchen counter, and it was the bank, and it was the payment for Session 19, the same amount as the last few, with the same short line in the note.

With our client's thanks.

I had sent the transcript on Friday at noon. Somebody, somewhere, had read it on Friday afternoon, every word, and had not been able to wait for Monday.

I stood at the counter with the phone in my hand. Then I took my notebook out of my bag, and turned to a clean page, and drew the star from memory, in one line, the way his hand did it and the letter's did. Five points. A small letter crowded into each.

Under it I wrote: *Same star. On his pad. On the letter. Does he know?*

And then, after a long while: *Not yet.*

I meant that I would not show him yet. I am still not sure, now, which of us I meant it about.

Full Speed

• RECORDING · APRIL 15, 1912, A LITTLE AFTER HALF PAST TWELVE

The chief steward slept in a cabin on C deck, aft, and he slept like a dead man. I knocked, and then I hammered, and then I opened the door and shook him by the shoulder, which a bell boy does not do to a chief steward in any life, and said the captain wanted him in the chart room at once, sir, at once.

He sat up and looked at me with his hair on end.

“What’s the time?”

“Half past twelve, sir. Something’s happened, sir. The Marconi man ran to the bridge.”

He didn’t ask me anything else. I saw him feel the lean of the ship under him, the long steady tilt of the turn, and understand it, the way a man who has been at sea for thirty years understands the floor. He was out of his bunk before I had got back to the door.

I woke the purser the same way. Then I went back up to the captain’s passage, as I had been told, and stood against the wall by the mug of cocoa I had left on the floor, and waited to be useful.



I want to tell you what Rostron did in the next hour, Ms. Barnett, because I watched most of it, and because I have watched a great many men in a great many emergencies, and I have never seen anything like it.

He did not hurry. That was the first thing. The ship was hurrying, every inch of her, but he did not. He stood in the chart room in his uniform with his cap on, and the officers came to him one at a time, and he gave each of them a list. He gave the lists quietly, and he did not say anything twice, and he did not leave anything out. I stood in the doorway and ran wherever I was sent, and every time I came back there was another officer at the table and another list.

The doctors. There were three on board, the ship's own surgeon and two who happened to be sailing with us, an Italian and a Hungarian. One saloon each. The English doctor in the first-class dining room, the Italian in the second, the Hungarian in the third, each with blankets and brandy and hot water and whatever he needed, so that anyone brought up out of the cold would find a doctor who spoke their language, or near it.

The purser, the assistant purser and the chief steward at the gangways, to take the names of everyone who came aboard. Every name. He said that twice, actually. It was the only thing I ever heard him say twice. *Every name.*

Every spare berth on the ship made up. Officers to give up their cabins. Hot coffee, hot soup, hot drinks of every kind, ready, in quantity, all night. The gangway doors in the side of the ship opened, and ladders and lines rigged over the side. Chair slings at every gangway, for anyone who could not climb. Canvas bags, the kind they used for ashes, for lifting up children who were too small to hold on.

Oil ready in the forward lavatories, to pour down the drains and calm the sea if the sea was rough. The boats swung out, in case we needed our own. And rockets, once we were near, every quarter of an hour, and the company's signals with them, so that anyone out there in the dark would know a ship was coming, and know whose.

And the passengers. Our own passengers, seven hundred of them, asleep. They were to be kept in their cabins, and kept quiet, and kept out of the way. Stewards in every corridor. No alarm. No running. If a passenger asked what was happening, the passenger was to be told, politely, to go back to bed.

I remember thinking, as I stood in that doorway, that he had thought of everything, and that he had thought of it all in about ten minutes, in his

nightshirt, before he even knew how bad it would be. I have planned battles with men who took a week to think of less.

And when he had finished giving the orders, and the officers had gone, he did a thing I didn't expect. He stood for a moment alone at the chart table, with his hand raised to the peak of his cap, and his eyes open, and his lips moving.

He was praying. I don't think he knew anyone saw. I have seen men pray before a battle, and before a hanging, and on their deathbeds, and I don't think I have ever seen it done so plainly, by a man who so plainly had no time for it, and did it anyway.

Then he put his hand down and went up to the bridge.



They mustered the stewards in the first-class dining saloon at one o'clock. Everybody, the bedroom stewards and the saloon stewards and the pantry men and the bell boys, forty or fifty of us, half dressed, with our hair on end, in a room full of white tablecloths that had been laid for breakfast. Evans was there, with his collar still undone. Stan was there, beside me, white as the tablecloths.

The chief steward stood on a chair and told us.

He told us plainly. The Titanic had struck ice and was sinking. We were going to her. We would be there in about four hours, if we could get there at all. Every man in that room would be wanted, and nobody would sleep tonight, and whatever we saw when we got there, we would do our work and keep our mouths shut and not frighten anybody.

Nobody said anything. Then somebody at the back said, "The Titanic," in the voice of a man saying the name of a church that has fallen down.

"Yes," said the chief steward. "The Titanic. Now get moving."



They put me on blankets first. I carried blankets from the linen stores to the gangways and the saloons until my arms shook, armful after armful, a boy

with a pile of gray wool up to his eyes running along corridors that were still tilted over into the turn, because she was still leaning, still pushing, still going north-west as fast as she could go.

It got cold very fast. That was the heat. Rostron had shut off the steam to every radiator on the ship, every cabin, every saloon, and sent every pound of it down to the engines. Within half an hour you could see your breath in the corridors. Within an hour there was frost on the inside of the portholes.

Then Lyle put me and Stan in the second-class corridor on C deck, one at each end, to keep the passengers in.

It was strange work. The passengers woke one at a time, from the cold and from the shaking, because the whole ship had begun to shake, a deep hard shudder that came up through the floor and the walls and the bed frames and the teeth. A door would open, and a man in a dressing gown would look out, and I would say, "Captain's compliments, sir, nothing to be alarmed about, please stay in your cabin," and he would look at me, and at the frost on the porthole at the end of the corridor, and go back in, and shut the door, and not believe a word of it.

Mr. Hatch came out at about two.

He was fully dressed, in the brown suit, with a muffler around his neck and his hat in his hand and a notebook sticking out of his pocket. He came down the corridor toward me, and I stepped in front of him, and he stopped.

"Captain's compliments, sir," I said. "Nothing to be alarmed about. Please stay in your cabin."

He looked down at me for a moment. He had a long, clever, tired face, and I saw him look at my face, and then at my hands, which were red and raw from the blankets, and then at the frost on the porthole behind me.

"Bertie," he said. "She turned, a little after half past twelve. I felt her go over in my bunk. She's been going flat out ever since, faster than she's ever gone, or the whole ship wouldn't be rattling like a tin of nails. And somebody's turned the heat off to do it, in the middle of the night, in the North Atlantic, with seven hundred paying passengers asleep." He put his hat on. "There's nothing to be alarmed about, is there?"

"No, sir."

“You’re a terrible liar, Bertie.” He smiled. It was not an unkind smile. “That’s all right. Honest boys always are.”

And he stepped around me, quite gently, and went up the stairs.

I could have stopped him. I could have shouted for Lyle. I stood in the corridor and watched his brown suit go up the stairs and out of sight, and I did nothing, and I told myself it was because a bell boy cannot lay hands on a passenger.

That was true. It was also true that I knew exactly what he was. I had been him, more than once, in other lives. A man who has to see. A man who will go and stand in the cold all night, in a thin suit, with a notebook, because something is happening and he cannot bear to be the one asleep. I’ve told you. It’s the worst thing about me.

I let him go because I would have gone.



At about half past two Lyle sent me down to the engine room with a can of coffee.

I have tried, since, to tell people what that was like, and I can’t. The stokehold of a ship in 1912 was a kind of hell anyway, a long low room of furnaces and coal dust and heat, with men stripped to the waist feeding the fires by hand. That night it was something else. Every stoker on the ship was down there, the watch that should have been sleeping as well as the watch on duty. The furnace doors were open and shutting and open, open and shutting, so fast it was like a light flickering. The men were shoveling as if the coal had done them a personal injury, with the sweat running down their faces through the black, and nobody spoke, because there was no breath to speak with. The noise was a wall.

And the ship was shaking. Down there you could feel all of it, every turn of the screws, the whole of her straining, as if she knew. The chief engineer was standing by the gauges watching the needles, and I saw his face, and I understood that they were past where they should have been, and that he was letting them stay there.

I gave the coffee to the nearest man. He drank it without stopping, and gave me back the can, and went on shoveling.

She had been built to make fourteen knots. People who were there have argued for a hundred years about what she made that night, and I won't argue with them. I'll only tell you I was in her stokehold, and she had never gone like that before, and I don't believe she ever did again.



When I came up again it was getting on for twenty to three, and I went out on deck, because nobody had told me not to.

The cold had got worse. The sea was still perfectly flat, still polished, still holding the stars. And there were men all along the rail. Extra lookouts, in the bows, in the crow's nest, on both wings of the bridge. Officers. Seamen. And passengers, too, by then, some of them, the ones who had not stayed in their cabins, in their coats over their nightclothes, standing very quietly along the rail and looking north.

Mr. Hatch was there. He was standing by himself at the forward end of the promenade, writing.

Then, low on the water far ahead of us, there was a light. A green one. It burned for a moment, and went out.

I heard the bridge go quiet. Then I heard Rostron's voice, and a moment later, from the bridge wing above me, our first rocket went up. It went up hissing, very high, and burst white, and lit the whole sea, and the faces along the rail. Then the company's signals, in colors, after it.

After that, every quarter of an hour, another.

A few minutes later somebody shouted from the bows.

I ran to the rail. Off to starboard, quite close, closer than I would have believed, something was going past us in the dark. It was white. It was very big. It was so much bigger than the ship that for a moment I thought it was land. It slid past us, enormous and silent, with the starlight on it, and the sea did not even break against its foot, because there was no sea, only that black polished floor. It went by. And the ship did not slow down.

Then another. Then, a few minutes later, another. Rostron took her through them at full speed, turning, and turning back, and turning again, and the officers on the bridge called the bergs as they came, and he never once slowed her down.



The engines stopped just after four.

You don't know what a silence is, Ms. Barnett, until a ship's engines stop after four hours of that. The shaking stopped. The noise stopped. The ship slid on through the water, slower, and slower, and the deck was suddenly so quiet that I could hear the man beside me breathing, and the water whispering along her side.

It was still dark. But the dark had begun to thin out in the east, a little, the way it does when you have been looking at it long enough.

And there was a boat.

It was very small, down on that enormous flat sea, off our port bow. A lifeboat, low in the water, with people in it, and oars going raggedly, out of time, and a man standing in the stern. Someone in her lit another green flare as we came up, and for a moment I could see the faces in it, white and green, all of them turned up toward us.

They brought her alongside to the gangway door on the port side. I was there. I don't know how. Everybody who could get there was there, crowded inside that open door, with the blankets and the coffee and the chair sling and the canvas bags. The ladder went down. They began to come up.

They came up one at a time, slowly, the ones who could climb up the ladder and the ones who could not in the sling, and the children in the canvas bags. They were women, mostly, in evening dresses under men's coats, in nightgowns under fur, with their hair down and their hands so cold they could not hold the rail. Not one of them said anything. I gave out blankets. I could not have told you, then, a single face.

Among them was an officer. A young one, in a Titanic officer's uniform, soaked and shaking. Somebody put a blanket around him, and he did not seem to notice, and they took him straight up to the bridge.

I went up after him with a can of coffee for the bridge, because I had been told to, and because I would have found a reason to go anyway. The captain was standing by the wheelhouse, very straight, and the young officer stood in front of him with the blanket around his shoulders, and the captain asked him the only question there was.

“Where is the Titanic?”

The young officer looked at him a moment, as if he did not understand the question, or did not want to.

“Gone,” he said. “She sank at two-twenty.”



He did not say anything else for a while.

I didn't either. The recorders went on recording the woodstove, and the rain, and the two of us not talking, and I let them.

“Do you want to stop?” I said.

“No.” He picked up his tea and found it cold and drank it anyway. “If I stop here, I'll have to start again from here. I'd rather not.” He set the cup down. “They came up all morning.”

The Boats

• RECORDING · APRIL 15, 1912, DAWN

The light came up slowly, as it does at sea, from nothing, out of the water itself.

And when it came, we saw where we were.

There was ice everywhere. I had known there was ice. I had watched the bergs go past us in the dark, one after another, white shapes in the starlight. But I had not understood. When the sun came up, the whole sea to the north and west of us was full of it, bergs of every size, some low and flat like islands and some standing up out of the water in peaks and towers, two hundred feet high, with the dawn on them turning them pink and gold. Between them, the water was crowded with smaller ice, a great field of it, broken and grinding, stretching away to the edge of the world. It was the most beautiful thing I had ever seen. I hated it with my whole heart.

And between us and the ice, scattered across miles of flat water, the boats.

Little white boats, low in the water, a long way apart. Some rowing toward us. Some not moving at all. As the light grew you could count them, and then you could see the people in them, packed in, very still, and here and there one man standing up in the stern working a steering oar.

That was all. Boats, and ice, and the sea, and a few deck chairs, and some cork, floating. Almost nothing else. A ship as big as a town had been there five hours before, with two thousand people on her. You would not have known.



They came up all morning, one boat after another, for four hours.

I was at the port gangway the whole time, except when I was sent running. I gave out blankets. I carried coffee. I took children out of the canvas bags as they came up over the sill, and gave them to whoever reached for them, and sometimes nobody reached, and I carried them in myself and found them a chair and a blanket and somebody to sit with.

Most of them didn't speak. That's the thing I remember best, and the thing nobody believes. You would think there would have been screaming, or weeping, or crowds of people shouting names. There wasn't. Not at first. They came up the ladders, or in the slings, and they stood on the deck in the cold sunlight in whatever they had been wearing at midnight, evening dresses under men's overcoats, nightgowns under furs, a man in his pajamas and a dinner jacket, a girl in one shoe. And they looked about them. Not at us. At the deck. At the ship. As if they were trying to work out where they were, and whether it was real, and whether it would hold.

Then they went to the rail.

That was where they waited, all morning, the women, all along the rail, in a long row, looking down at each boat as it came in. Looking at the faces in it. Every time a boat came alongside, the whole row leaned over together and looked, and then, one at a time, they straightened up again. It was like watching a field of wheat in a wind.

Most of the boats were women and children. Some of them had a few men. There were very few men, anywhere. You learned, by the second or third boat, not to look at the women's faces when they straightened up.



I'll tell you about one boat. Only one.

It came in somewhere in the middle of the morning, when the sun was well up and the wind had begun to come up with it, and the sea that had been flat all night was starting to roughen, so the boats bumped and swung

against our side as they came in. This one was fuller than most. There were men in her. More than in most of the others. I noticed that, and then I noticed I had noticed it, and put it away.

And there was a woman in the bow with two children.

She was young, perhaps twenty-five, very straight, with a dark coat buttoned to the throat and no hat, and her hair coming down. A little girl of about six sat against her, wrapped in the woman's own shawl, and she held a smaller boy on her lap, asleep, or nearly. When the boat came alongside, the seaman at the gangway reached down to take the boy from her, and she didn't let him. She held up one hand, quite calmly, palm out, the way you stop a carriage, and said something I couldn't hear. Then she put the boy into the canvas bag herself. She tied the neck of it herself, and tested the knot, and watched him all the way up until he was in somebody's arms on deck. Then she did the same with the girl. Then she came up the ladder.

She came up it well. Better than most of the men. And when she stepped through the gangway door, onto our deck, she did not do what all the others had done. She did not stand and look about her, at the deck, at the ship, as if it might not be real.

She looked at the people.

I saw her do it. I was standing by the stack of blankets, a yard away, and I watched her eyes go along the gangway. The purser at his table with his list. The two seamen at the door. The doctor. The stewards with coffee. Me. One after another, each of us, quick and complete, the way you read a page. Then the doors. Then the stairs. Then back to the children.

She did not look back at the sea. Not once.

I gave her a blanket. She took it, and said thank you, in an English voice, a good one, quiet. And for a moment she looked straight at me, a bell boy holding out a blanket, and I saw her see that I had been watching her. Then she put the blanket around the little girl and went to sit with them by the wall, and did not look at me again.

There was a woman with them, too. She came up after, in the sling, because she couldn't climb. Their mother, I learned later. She sat where they put her and didn't move, and didn't speak, and when the little girl climbed

into her lap she held her without seeming to know who it was. The young woman in the dark coat went and knelt by her and talked to her, low, steadily, for a long time. The mother didn't answer.

The father had not been in the boat.



"What was her name?" I said.

He looked at me. He had been looking at the window, at the rain, while he told it, and now he turned and looked at me with a kind of patience I had not seen in him before.

"I'll tell you what I called her," he said. "Later. When it matters."

"That isn't what I asked."

"No." He set his cup down. "Ms. Barnett, I'm going to ask you to let me do something, and I know you won't like it. There are people in this part of the story who were real, and are on lists, and have families. Grandchildren. Great-grandchildren, some of them still alive, with their grandmother's photograph on the wall. Some of what happened in that boat, and on that ship, nobody has ever said aloud. If I give you their names, you'll check them. I know you will. That's why I asked for you." He looked at the notepad on his knee. "And then they'll be in a book."

"That's my job."

"I know it is. That's why I'm asking." He was very calm. "I won't give you the names of anyone in that boat. Not the woman with the children. Not the others. Not the number of the boat. Everyone else, you can have. Rostron, Cottam, Evans, Hatch. Check them all. But not the boat."

"Then how am I supposed to know any of it's true?"

"You aren't," he said. "Not that part. You'll have to decide whether to believe me." He smiled, a little, not happily. "I know. It's a great deal to ask of you, of all people."

I sat with that. Outside, a truck went by on the far road, and the window rattled in its frame.

"Every other Thursday," I said, "you've given me something I could check."

"Yes."

“Why not this?”

He was quiet for a long moment.

“Because I was twelve,” he said, “and I couldn’t do anything about it. And I’ve had a very long time to decide what I owe those people now.” He picked up the pencil. “Not their names. That much I can still do.”

I wrote it down. I wrote, *Won’t name the boat. Won’t name anyone in it.* And then, because I was honest on paper: *First time he’s refused me anything.*



• RECORDING · APRIL 15, 1912, MORNING

The last boat came in at half past eight.

She was the worst. She was so full you could not see the wood of her sides, only people, packed shoulder to shoulder and standing in the bottom, seventy of them, more, in a boat built for sixty-five and riding so low that every swell came in over the gunwale. The wind was really blowing by then, and the sea was up, and she came toward us very slowly, rolling, with an officer standing in the stern steering her. We all stood at the rail and watched her come and did not breathe.

She made it. The officer was the last man up. A tall, hard-looking man, soaked to the waist, who came up the ladder like a man climbing out of a grave, and stood on our deck, and turned, and looked back out at the ice for a long moment before he let them lead him away. I learned afterward he was the senior officer saved. The most senior one left alive.

That was the end of it. Seven hundred and five people. Every boat accounted for, and some of them empty, and all the rest of them gone.

A little after that, another ship came up out of the north, through the ice. A steamer, smaller than us. She came slowly and stopped a way off, and her wireless and ours talked, and on our bridge the officers looked across at her with faces I did not understand then.

She was the Californian. She had been there all night, near enough to see the Titanic’s rockets. Her wireless man had gone to bed.

I didn’t know any of that, that morning. I only saw the officers’ faces.



The captain had the ship turn slowly around the place where the Titanic had gone down, once, while a clergyman who was one of our passengers held a service in the first-class saloon. A short one. Prayers for the dead, and thanks for the living, both at once, in the same breath, because there was no time to do them separately.

The saloon was full. Our passengers and theirs, side by side, the people who had slept through the night and the people who had sat in the boats. I stood at the back, against the wall, with the other boys, as we had the morning before, as if it were Sunday.

Most of the survivors didn't sing. They stood with the hymn books open and their mouths shut. Some of them wept, now, for the first time, quite silently. Some of them stared at the floor.

The young woman with the children was there, by the door, with the little boy asleep against her shoulder. She was not singing either. She was not praying, and she was not weeping, and she was not looking at the floor.

She was watching the room. Every face in it, one after another, the same as at the gangway. Quick and complete.

I knew that look. I knew it the way you know your own handwriting on an envelope you don't remember sending. It was the way I looked at a room.

It was nothing, I decided. A sharp young woman who had just lived through the worst night of her life, counting the doors because she would never again sit in a room without knowing where the doors were. Plenty of people came off those boats like that. I had seen a dozen of them that morning.

I told myself that, and I believed it, and I put her away.

That was the second time in my long life I had done that, Ms. Barnett. I had done it once before, in a hotel dining room in Washington, to a waiter in a white jacket.



When the service was over, Rostron took the ship out of the ice, south and then west, and we turned for New York.

Mr. Hatch found me on the boat deck at a quarter to ten. He looked terrible. He had been out on deck since two in the morning, in the thin brown suit, and his face was gray with cold and his hands shook, and the notebook in his hand was so full of writing it had swollen to twice its size.

"Bertie," he said. "Do you know what's on this ship?"

"Survivors, sir."

"Seven hundred of them." He held up the notebook. "Seven hundred people who were there. Who saw it. Every newspaper in the world would give its eyeteeth for one of them, and we've got seven hundred, and four days before anybody else can get near them." He laughed. It was not a good laugh. It was the laugh of a man who has been awake too long, and has seen too much, and has just understood that it is also the best thing that ever happened to him. "I came to write about a volcano."

"Yes, sir."

"I'm going to talk to every one of them," he said. "Every single one who'll have me. I'm going to write it all down. What they saw. What they did." He put the notebook in his pocket, and buttoned the pocket, and patted it, once. "Somebody has to. You watch, Bertie. In New York they'll all have a story, and half of them will be lies, and nobody will ever know the difference. Unless somebody wrote it down first. Right here. While it was still true."

He went off along the deck, toward the first-class entrance, where a group of survivors was sitting in the sun in blankets, and I watched him go.

He was right, of course. That was the trouble with him. He was nearly always right.

The List

I called Kevin Dunleavy on Friday morning, after the school run, and he did not want to talk to me.

He was polite about it. He drove a delivery truck, he said, for a beverage company, and he was in the cab between stops with the engine running, and he did not know who I was or what I wanted with his mother, and his mother was eighty-one years old with a bad hip and did not need people calling her about things that happened six years ago.

“I understand,” I said. “I’m sorry to have bothered you.”

“What was it about, anyway?”

I told him. A man who had lived upstairs from his mother on Calloway Street, who went out one Wednesday and didn’t come back. That I had been the reporter on a story he had helped with. That I thought his mother might have heard something that morning, through the ceiling.

There was a silence on the line, with an engine in it.

“Upstairs,” he said. “The quiet guy. With the cat.”

“Yes.”

“Hang on,” he said. And then, away from the phone, but not far enough: “Ma. *Ma*. It’s about the guy upstairs. On Calloway. The quiet one.”

There was a pause. Then a different voice, older, sharper, coming from somewhere on the far side of a kitchen, louder than the engine.

“Give me that phone.”



Freda wanted to come.

I had not expected it. I told her on Friday night, over dinner, that I was driving out to Frederick in the morning to see the woman from the second floor, and I expected her to say *okay* and go back to her phone. Instead she put the phone face down on the table and said, “Can I come?”

“Why?”

“I’m the transcriber.” She said it as if it were a job title, which I suppose it was. “I should meet the sources.”

“She’s not a source. She’s an old lady who used to complain about the noise.”

“That’s literally what a source is,” said Freda. “You told me that. When I was like nine.”

So she came. She sat in the passenger seat with her feet on the dashboard, which I had stopped telling her not to do, and her headphones around her neck, and a bag of pretzels in her lap, and when we got to the bottom of our street and found 16th Street closed for a fun run, she didn’t even look up.

“Go up Georgia,” she said. “Cut across at Missouri. Then you can get back on.”

I went up Georgia. We cut across at Missouri, and got back on.

“Since when do you know Georgia Avenue?”

“Since always.” She ate a pretzel. “Maddie’s sister drives that way.”

Maddie’s sister, I thought, had become a very generous girl this spring. I didn’t say it. I drove.



The house was the one from the county website, a split-level at the end of a cul-de-sac on the east side of Frederick, with the basketball hoop over the garage and the newer wooden ramp built up over the front steps. Kevin Dunleavy opened the door before we had knocked. He was a big, tired man in his fifties with a delivery company’s polo shirt and his father’s bus driver’s face, I imagined, patient and a little worn.

“She’s been up since six,” he said, in a low voice. “She’s been waiting for you since six. I want you to know that.”

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry." He stood back to let us in. "She hasn't been this happy since the Orioles fired the manager."

Mrs. Eileen Dunleavy was in the living room in a wheelchair by the window, with a crocheted blanket over her knees and her white hair set, and a cardigan buttoned correctly, all the way to the top. She was very small. She had a face like a walnut and eyes like a bird's, and they went over me from my shoes to my hair before I was halfway across the carpet.

"You're the reporter," she said.

"Yes, ma'am."

"You're shorter than your picture." She looked at Freda. "Who's this?"

"My daughter. Freda."

"Hm." The bird's eyes went over Freda the same way, shoes to hair. "You've got your mother's mouth. You look like you've got your own mind, too. Good. Sit there." She pointed at the couch. "Kevin, get the girl a soda. Get the girl a soda and get Darren out of his room and make him say hello to somebody for once in his life."

Kevin went. Mrs. Dunleavy turned back to me.

"I read it," she said. "Your story. In the paper. That Sunday."

I didn't say anything. I hadn't expected that.

"I read all of it," she said. "I knew it was true the minute I read it. I knew it was him, too, even though you didn't put his name in. Carrow House. The documents. Of course it was him." She folded her small hands on the blanket. "He was a careful man. I could hear him being careful. Every night, ten o'clock, chair back, desk lamp off, two steps, bedroom door. Never once slammed a door in four years. Never had a party. Never had a girl up, never had a boy up. Never had anybody up." She looked at me sharply. "Until that Wednesday."



I had brought my notebook. I had brought the recorder, too, and I asked her if she minded, and she said she had been waiting six years for somebody to record her, and she was not going to be shy about it now.

So I asked her what I had come to ask. And she told me what Tom had said she would.

"I wrote it down," she said. "Of course I wrote it down. I wrote everything down. That man Petrakis stopped answering his phone years before, and after that what was I supposed to do? I wrote it down. Every bang, every pipe, every dog. With the time." She nodded toward the hall. "Kevin's got them in the garage. Kevin! The tub. The blue one."

Kevin brought the tub. It was a plastic storage bin, the kind you buy for sweaters, and it was full to the top with composition notebooks. The black and white marbled kind, the kind Freda used in third grade. There must have been sixty of them. Every one had a date range on the cover in neat ballpoint capitals.

"Six years," said Mrs. Dunleavy, "before that. And two after. Then I broke my hip and came here, and Kevin's house is quiet as a church, God help me." She pointed. "That one. Third from the left."

I found it. The dates on the cover took in that spring, and that summer. I turned the pages slowly, very slowly. They were full, every line of every page, in the same small, tidy, furious hand. *7:10 AM. Dry cleaner machine started. 20 MIN EARLY. 11:45 PM. 4th floor. Television. Loud. Game show. 2:15 PM. Dog. Alley. Barking 9 min. Day after day after day. A building's whole life, through one woman's ceiling.*

And then I came to the Wednesday.

I knew it before I read the date. The handwriting was different. Not messier. Smaller. Pressed down harder into the paper, as if she had known, while she was writing it, that it was something she would need.

WED.

9:38 AM. Knock, upstairs (3rd fl). 3 knocks. Then 2 more.

9:39. Cat crying. He's shut her in.

9:40. His door. Man's voice, NOT HIS. Laughing. Door shut.

9:40 to 10:10. Talking. Couldn't hear words. Other one laughing a lot.

10:12. His door. TWO on stairs going DOWN. Slow. Heavy. Something banging the wall all the way down. New paint!!

10:14. Back door. Car in alley. Engine running. Exhaust coming in my kitchen window AGAIN.

10:21. Two back UP. Quick.

10:33. Two DOWN again. Slow. Heavy. Banging.

10:41. Car door. Car door. Car gone.

Called P. No answer. As usual.

And then, on the next line, in the same hard small writing, as if she had gone back to it at the end of the day:

He did not come back up.



I read it three times. Then I looked up at her, and she was watching me with her bird's eyes, and her small hands folded on the blanket.

"He didn't come back up," I said.

"No."

"Not that day."

"Not that day. Not ever." She said it very plainly. "I'd have heard him. I heard everybody come up those stairs for thirty years. He had a step like nobody else's. Very light. Like he was apologizing to the stairs." She looked at the notebook in my hands. "He went down those stairs at twenty to eleven on that Wednesday morning, with whoever that was, carrying whatever that was, and he got into that car, and that was the last time."

"Did you tell the police?"

She laughed. It was not a nice laugh.

"The police came on the Friday. Petrakis let them in. One young officer, with a face like a boiled ham. I was standing right in my doorway on the second floor when they went up. Standing right there." She jerked her chin at the notebook. "Nobody asked me. He asked Petrakis. Petrakis told him about the rent, and the carpet. He wrote it all down. Then he went upstairs and looked around, and came down, and went away, and nobody ever asked me a single thing."

"You could have told them."

"I called the number on his card," she said. "Twice. They said they'd pass it on." She looked out of the window at the cul-de-sac. "Nobody called me back. Nobody ever calls me back."



Freda had been sitting on the couch through all of this with a can of soda in her hand, very still. Darren, the grandson, had come out of his room at his father's insistence, a long boy of about sixteen with headphones on, and said *hi* to the carpet, and sat on the other end of the couch looking at his phone. At some point the two of them had started talking, very quietly, about something on his screen. Now I saw that Freda had stopped, and was looking at the notebook in my lap.

"Mrs. Dunleavy," she said. "Did you ever see him? The other man?"

Mrs. Dunleavy turned and looked at her, and something in her face changed, and softened, a very little.

"No," she said. "I wish I had, sweetheart. My kitchen window looked on the alley, but by the time I got to it with this hip, the car was going. Big. Dark. That's all I saw." She paused. "But I heard him. All that half an hour. Through the ceiling. And going down the stairs, every step." She shook her head slowly. "He had hard heels on. Leather. You don't hear leather heels much anymore. Click, click, click, like a lady. And he laughed."

"What kind of laugh?"

Mrs. Dunleavy thought about it. She took her time.

"A big one," she said. "Too big. The kind of laugh a man has when he's used to people laughing with him." She looked back at me. "Your man upstairs didn't laugh. Not once, in four years. That's why I wrote it down. That's what was wrong with it. Somebody was in that apartment having a wonderful time."



Kevin let me photograph every page of that notebook, and then, when his mother insisted, let me take the notebook itself, on a promise to bring it back, which I wrote down and signed for her on a page of my own. She watched me do it with great satisfaction.

At the door, she held my hand in both of hers for a moment. Her hands were very cold and very strong.

"I knew he didn't run," she said. "I knew. A man who apologizes to the stairs doesn't run off and leave his cat." She let go. "You find out where that car went, Miss Barnett. And then you come back and tell me. You come back. You're the first person who ever did."



Freda didn't say anything until we were on the highway.

Then she said, "She was great."

"She was."

"She was so mad. Like, for six years. And she kept every single page." She was looking out of her window at the hills going by. "You're really good at this. You know that? I didn't know you were that good at it. You just sat there and let her talk."

"That's most of it. Letting people talk."

"That's what he does," said Freda. "Mr. Hale. That's exactly what he does to you."

I drove for a while.

"Mom," said Freda. "When it happened. The story, and all of it. When you lost your job." She was still looking out of the window. "Did Dad ever, like. Help? Or call, or anything?"

I kept my eyes on the road. It was a long, straight stretch, with nothing on it.

"Your father was in Phoenix," I said. "He sent you a card for your birthday that year. It came in March."

Her birthday was in January. Freda knew that. She didn't say anything. She didn't put her headphones on, either. She sat with her feet on the dashboard and looked out of the window at Maryland until we were home, and when we got out of the car she said she had homework, and went to her room.

The door didn't slam.

I sat at the kitchen table with Mrs. Dunleavy's notebook open in front of me and copied out that one page by hand, every line, the way I used to copy out a source's quotes on the night before a story ran, so that they would be in my own hand and I would know I had them right. Then, under it, I wrote:

He let them in. He shut Pearl away. They talked half an hour, and the other one laughed.

Two trips. Two boxes, the first time. What was the second?

He went down with them. He didn't come back up.

And then the question that I was going to be asking, I already knew, for a very long time.

Where did the car go?

Monday

• RECORDING · APRIL 15, 1912, AFTERNOON

By noon on that Monday there were more than fourteen hundred passengers on a ship that had sailed with half that many, and nobody was comfortable, and nobody complained.

You have to imagine it. Every bunk was full, and every sofa. The officers had given up their cabins. Our own first-class passengers had given up theirs, many of them, and moved in two and three together, and the survivors who were not ill or hurt lay on the floors of the saloons and the smoking rooms and the library, wrapped in blankets, in rows, like wounded after a battle. Which is what they were. Women slept sitting up in chairs with children across their laps. In the third-class dining room, the Hungarian doctor went up and down the rows in his shirtsleeves, and the families from our steerage, who were going home to the mountains with everything they owned in a bundle, opened the bundles and gave away what was in them.

That was the thing I hadn't expected. Our own passengers.

They'd been told to stay in their cabins and keep out of the way, and the moment the boats came in, almost every one of them disobeyed. The American ladies going to see Italy took off their own coats and put them around strangers. They gave up their nightgowns and their stockings and their hairbrushes. By the afternoon there were a dozen of them sitting in the second-class saloon with scissors and needles, cutting up the ship's blankets and sewing them into little coats and trousers for the children who had come

up out of the boats in their nightclothes. They sewed all afternoon, and talked very little, and when they had finished one coat they started another.

I carried thread. I carried scissors. I carried everything. I don't believe I stopped once between dawn and dark.



The captain had made up his mind by then about where to go.

He could have gone on to the Mediterranean, I suppose, and carried seven hundred people who had nothing, not even shoes, across the Atlantic and back. He could have gone to Halifax, which was nearer. He went back to New York. It was the right choice, the only one, and he made it as he made everything, all at once and without fuss. I heard about it from Stan, who heard it from a quartermaster, who had heard the captain say that the survivors would need their own country, and their own people, and their own papers, and all of that was in New York.

So we turned our back on the Mediterranean, and on our own passengers' holidays, and on the Hungarian families going home, and steamed west. Nobody aboard complained about that, either. Not one person, that I ever heard.



The wireless never stopped.

I went up to the cabin twice that afternoon with tea, and both times Cottam was at the key, in the same shirt he had been wearing at midnight, with the same one boot unlaced, because he had never had time to lace it. He had not slept. He did not look as if he knew what sleep was. He was sending names.

That was the captain's order. Names first. Every survivor, every name, one by one, to the shore stations and to the ships within reach, so that somewhere in New York, or in London, or in a village in Ireland or Sweden or Lebanon, somebody could stop waiting. He was sending them as fast as his hand would go, and his hand was very tired, and there were seven hundred of them, and

the purser's lists had been made in a hurry at a cold gangway door by men whose fingers were numb, and half the names were spelled wrong.

And on the desk beside him, there was another pile. A growing one.

"What are those?" I said, the second time I came.

He didn't look up from the key. "Newspapers. Every newspaper in America. And a good many in England." He sent something, fast. "They want the story. They want to know what happened. Who's alive. Who's dead. Whether it's true about the millionaires. What it was like. They'll pay anything. One of them's offered me more than I make in a year."

"What are you going to do?"

"Nothing." He reached for the tea without looking at it. "Captain's orders. Names first, and official business, and nothing to the press. Nothing at all." He drank. "He's right. If I start answering newspapers, I'll never get the names out. And it's the names that matter. It's the names people are waiting for." He put the cup down. "Let them wait. Let them all wait."

I looked at the pile. It was very tall. I could read the top one from where I stood. It was from a newspaper in New York, and it asked, politely, at great length, for a statement from any survivor, at any price.

I thought of Mr. Hatch, in his brown suit, going from blanket to blanket with his notebook.

I thought, then, for the first time, that what Mr. Hatch was doing on that ship might be worth a very great deal of money. And that he was not the only man aboard who would know it.



At four o'clock they buried the dead.

There were four. They had come up out of the boats that morning, and there had been nothing the doctors could do. One of them had been a passenger, a gentleman, pulled out of the water still alive in the night and died in the boat before dawn. The other three were Titanic's own crew. Two of them had names. One of them, nobody knew. Nobody in his boat had known him, and there was nothing in his pockets to tell.

They sewed them into canvas, the way it's done at sea, with a weight at the feet. They laid them on planks at the rail on the after deck, under flags. The engines were stopped again, for the first time since dawn, and in the silence you could hear the wind and the water and the gulls that had found us somewhere in the afternoon.

The same clergyman read the service. A few of us stood there. Not many. Most of the survivors stayed inside. I don't blame them.

I stood at the back, as I always stood at the back, with my cap in my hands. I have stood at a great many burials, Ms. Barnett, in a great many lives. I have stood at them for people I loved and for people I had never met, and I have buried people with my own hands, more than once. That was the only one I ever stood at for a man whose name nobody knew.

When the clergyman reached the words, the seamen tilted the planks, and one by one the four of them slid out from under the flags and went down into the gray water, and were gone.

I said the man's name to myself. The nameless one. I didn't know it, so I gave him one. I won't tell you what it was. It wasn't his, and he's had no use for it, and that's between him and me.



The young woman in the dark coat was at the burial.

I didn't see her come. She was standing a little apart, at the rail, with her hands in her pockets, alone. No children. She must have left them sleeping with their mother. She stood very straight and watched the service from beginning to end, and when the planks tilted she didn't look away, as most of us did. She watched each of the four go down into the water, all the way, until there was nothing to watch.

Then she turned to go in, and saw me.

I was standing by the hatch, with my cap in my hands, and I had been watching her watch. She knew it. I saw her know it. She stopped, and looked at me for a moment, quite steadily, as you look at a dog you don't know, to decide if it bites.

"You're the boy from the gangway," she said.

“Yes, miss.”

“You gave me a blanket.”

“Yes, miss.”

She came a step closer. She had gray eyes, I remember, very clear, set a little too far apart, and a small white scar at the corner of her mouth, and she looked at me as if I were a page in a book she had not expected to find interesting.

“Do you always look at people like that?” she said.

“Like what, miss?”

“Like you’re counting them.”

I should have said *No, miss*, and looked at the deck, as Bertie Pike would have. That is what a bell boy says to a lady who speaks to him. I knew that perfectly well.

I didn’t. I was tired, and I had been on my feet for sixteen hours, and I had just watched four men go into the sea, and I was a very old man, and I had not been spoken to as anything but furniture for three weeks.

“Somebody has to, miss,” I said. “The purser wants every name.”

Something moved in her face. Not a smile. Something underneath one, quick, and then gone.

“Yes,” she said. “Every name.” She looked at me a moment longer. Then she nodded, once, as if to herself, as if something had been filed. “Good afternoon,” she said, and went in.

I stood by the hatch for some time after she’d gone.

I have told you that I put her away, that morning, in the saloon, just as I had once put away a waiter in a white jacket. I want to be honest with you. I took her out again, by the hatch, for perhaps a minute. I turned her over. A young Englishwoman, educated, very composed, with gray eyes too far apart and a way of looking at a room. And then Lyle shouted for me from the companionway, and there was a lady in first class who wanted her trunk moved, and I put her away again, and went.

I have asked myself since, more times than I could count, what I would have done if Lyle had not shouted.



It was dark when I next saw Mr. Hatch.

He was in the second-class smoking room, in the corner by the window where he had set himself up on the Sunday afternoon with his typewriter. The typewriter was shut now. He had a cup of coffee in front of him that had gone cold, and his notebook open, and he was writing, fast, in pencil, in a hand so small and so cramped that I couldn't have read it if I had stood over him.

There were survivors asleep on the benches all around the walls. He was writing very quietly, so as not to wake them.

I brought him tea. He looked up, and saw who it was, and smiled, and his face was gray.

"Bertie," he said. "You're a saint."

"That's what the Marconi man says, sir."

"Then it must be true. He's a man of science." He took the tea and wrapped both hands around it. "Sit down a minute."

"I'm not allowed, sir."

"Nobody's looking. Everybody's asleep." He nodded at the bench. I sat on the very edge of it. He looked at me over the cup. "I've been talking to them all day," he said. "Since the boats. Forty-one people. Forty-one so far." He touched the notebook. "Do you know what they say, mostly?"

"No, sir."

"They say what they think they ought to say." He drank. "That everyone was very brave. That it was very calm. That the band played. That the men stood back and put the women in the boats and waved goodbye like gentlemen." He set the cup down. "And most of it's true, Bertie. That's the strange thing. Most of it's quite true. But they've all been on this ship eleven hours now, sitting together, telling each other, and every hour it gets a little more the same. By New York they'll all be telling one story. You'll see. The one everyone agrees on."

"Is that bad, sir?"

He looked at me for a long moment, and I saw him decide to tell me something, as a man tells a dog things, because the dog won't repeat them.

"It is when it isn't true," he said. "Not all the boats were the same, Bertie. Some of them went back. Most of them didn't. Some of them were half empty and could have gone back and didn't, because the people in them were afraid of being swamped. You can understand that. God knows I can understand that. But some of them..." He stopped. He turned his cup on the table, a quarter turn, and did not finish. "Some of them did things in the dark that the people in them would like very much to forget. And they're going to forget them, by Thursday. They're going to agree to forget them. Unless somebody wrote it down first."

"Did somebody tell you, sir? What happened? In one of the boats?"

He didn't answer that. He put his hand flat on the notebook, the way you keep a hand on a thing that might blow away.

"They'll want to know who had the oars," he said. "That's all. In New York, when the questions start. Somebody's going to ask who had the oars in every boat, and what they did with them." He picked up his pencil. "And I'm going to know."

Then he sent me away, quite gently, and went back to his writing.

I stood in the door of the smoking room for a moment with the empty tray, and looked back at him, a thin man in a brown suit, in the corner by the dark window, bent over a notebook, writing very small, among all those sleeping people.

I've thought about that picture a great deal, since. I thought about it two nights later, more than I wanted to.



He put his cup down.

"He had two more days," he said. "I didn't know that either."

Two Car Doors

The bakery had closed on Saturday, as promised, and on Thursday he made eggs.

“There’s nothing to put soup next to,” he said, at the door, by way of explanation. “I tried the bread from the supermarket in town. It’s very soft. It’s like eating a pillow somebody has been crying into.” He took my coat, and looked at the moth hole in the sleeve with something like affection, and hung it on the hook. “So, eggs. Have you eaten?”

I had not. I had left before seven, because I wanted to be early, and I had said it was for the traffic.

We ate at the kitchen table. Scrambled eggs, very soft, as the French do them, with chives from a pot on the windowsill and toast from the crying pillow. He had made too much, and watched me eat it with the expression of a man who does not get to feed people often enough.

Then I took Mrs. Dunleavy’s notebook out of my bag and put it on the table between the plates.

He didn’t touch it at first. He looked at it. A black and white composition book, the marbled kind, with a date range on the cover in small furious capitals, and a strip of masking tape down the spine where it had been mended.

“You found her,” he said.

“She found me. She took the phone off her son.” I told him about the split-level, and the ramp, and the plastic tub in the garage with sixty notebooks in it. “You were right. She’d written down everything. Every pipe and every dog, for eight years. She said nobody ever asked her.”

“No. They never do.” He put out one finger and touched the cover, very lightly, as you would touch something in a museum when the guard was not looking. “May I?”



He read the Wednesday page for a long time.

I had read it perhaps forty times by then. I had copied it out by hand. I had it nearly by heart. And still I watched him read it, and found that I was holding my breath.

He read it once straight through. Then he went back to the top and read it again, slowly, with his finger moving down the margin, a line at a time, as if it were a contract.

“She’s a good witness,” he said at last.

“She’s a furious witness.”

“That’s often the same thing. Look.” He turned the book so I could see, and put his finger on a line. “*Man’s voice, not his*. She doesn’t say who she thinks it was. She doesn’t guess. She writes down what she heard, and she stops. Most people can’t do that. They tell you what it meant, and you have to dig down through the meaning to find out what actually happened.” He moved the finger. “She only tells you what it meant once. Here, at the bottom. *He did not come back up*. And she’s earned that one.”

He sat back.

“Three knocks,” he said. “Then two.”

“I noticed that.”

“Of course you did. What did you make of it?”

“That it’s a knock you’d agree on,” I said. “Somebody you’d told how to knock. So you’d know it was them and open the door.” I had thought about it all week. “He was frightened, that week. I’d told him to stay home. He wouldn’t have opened his door to just anybody.”

“No. He shut the cat away and opened it to somebody he’d been expecting.” He moved his finger down. “And they talked for half an hour first. With a great deal of laughing, on one side. That’s not a man who’s come to collect something. That’s a man who’s come to persuade.”

“Persuade him of what?”

“To go with him,” he said. “With everything.” He looked at the next lines, and his face grew very still. “Two trips. Both heavy. The first time, she writes, something banging the wall all the way down. You told me there were two banker’s boxes in the closet by the door.”

“Yes.”

“Two men. One box each. One trip.” He tapped the line. “And the banging. A banker’s box is light enough to carry in front of you, if you’re used to carrying things. A man who bangs it into the wall on every step of a narrow stair, all the way down, is a man who doesn’t carry his own boxes, as a rule.” He looked up at me. “Then they came back up, quickly. Then down again, heavy, banging. What was the second trip, Ms. Barnett?”

I had been trying to answer that all week. I said what I had come up with, which was nothing: more papers, perhaps. A third box I’d never seen.

He shook his head, very slightly.

“You told me once what the police wrote down, in his apartment. The officer who only wrote down what was in front of him. You read it to me off the report.” He waited. “What did the officer write down that wasn’t there?”

It took me a moment. Then I had it, and I felt it go through me like cold water.

Desk. No computer observed.

“He had a computer,” I said. “An old one. A big beige thing, on the desk, with a scanner. He scanned everything. Every document, before he copied it. I saw it the one time I was there. I never even thought about it.” I put my hand flat on the table. “It wasn’t in the report because it wasn’t there. And I always thought, of course it wasn’t there, he took it with him. Like the boxes.”

“He did take it with him,” he said. “Just not the way you thought. He carried it down the stairs himself, with his friend, at half past ten on a Wednesday morning, and put it in the car.” He looked at the page again. “Everything. Every copy, every scan, every piece of paper that could prove a word of your story. He carried it all down to the alley with his own hands, and he left his cat behind a closed door, and his family’s photographs on the wall, because he meant to come home that night.”

“He thought they were helping him,” I said.

It came out very quietly. I had not meant to say it out loud.

“I think so,” he said. “I think somebody he trusted came and told him the evidence wasn’t safe in his apartment, not with Carrow’s lawyers and Carrow’s people, and they had a place it would be safe. And a place he would be safe, too, when he moved on Saturday, if he’d let them find it for him.” He was quiet for a moment. “*Customer to call with address.*”

I did not say anything for a while. The woodstove ticked. Outside, a crow walked along the fence by the field, and stopped, and looked at the house, and walked on.



“There’s one more thing,” he said.

I looked up.

“It’s a small thing. It may be nothing. It’s a reason to ask, that’s all.” He turned the book around to face him again and put his finger on the last lines. “Look at the car.”

I looked. I knew those lines as well as I knew my own name.

10:14. Back door. Car in alley. Engine running. Exhaust coming in my kitchen window AGAIN.

10:21. Two back UP. Quick.

10:33. Two DOWN again. Slow. Heavy. Banging.

10:41. Car door. Car door. Car gone.

“The engine was running when they came down the first time,” he said. “With the boxes. She smelled the exhaust from her kitchen. Then both of them went back upstairs, quickly, for the computer, and they were up there for twelve minutes. And all that time, the engine was still running.”

“People leave engines running.”

“They do. In an alley, in the middle of the morning, with nobody in the car, while they go up three flights of stairs and stay twelve minutes, and leave a car full of the only proof of a story the whole city is talking about, unlocked, with the engine running, in an alley.” He let that sit. “Some people. Perhaps.”

“Or somebody was sitting in it.”

“Or somebody was sitting in it.” He touched the last line. “And then, at the end. *Car door. Car door.* She heard two doors, Ms. Barnett. Not three. She was listening for doors. She’d been listening to that building for thirty years. If three people had got into that car she’d have written down three doors.”

“Two men got in,” I said slowly. “And the one who drove was already in it.”

“It’s a reason to ask,” he said again. “That’s all it is.”

I wrote it down. *Three knocks, two. Persuaded. 2 boxes, then the computer. Engine running 27 min. Somebody in the car? 2 doors.* And under it: *Three people. Not two.*

Then I looked at what I had written, and at Mrs. Dunleavy’s furious little capitals beside it, and I thought about a careful man who apologized to the stairs, going down them for the last time between a friend who laughed and a stranger he may never have seen.



“She said one more thing,” I said. “About the other man. The one who laughed. She said he had leather heels. Hard ones. She could hear every step on the stairs. Click, click, click, like a lady, she said. She said you don’t hear leather heels much anymore.”

He had been reaching for the coffee pot. His hand stopped.

It was only for a second. I would not have noticed it, before. I had spent twenty weeks learning to notice things about him, and I noticed it now. His hand stopped just short of the pot, and stayed, and then went on, and poured.

“Leather heels,” he said.

“Does that mean something?”

“It means he was dressed for an office,” he said, “on a Wednesday morning, and he wanted to be.” He put the pot down. He looked at the window, at the field, where the crow had gone. “It reminds me of something. That’s all. Something a long way off.”

He didn’t say what. I didn’t ask. I had learned, by then, that when he looked at the window like that, the answer was usually coming, and usually on tape.



He asked about Freda when we had cleared the plates. I told him she had come with me to Frederick, and had sat on the couch with the grandson and a can of soda, quiet as a mouse, for an hour.

“And then she asked the one question I didn’t,” I said. “Whether Mrs. Dunleavy had ever seen him. The other man.”

“Had she?”

“No. Only heard him.” I dried the last plate. “She was good. Freda. She just sat there and let it happen. Mrs. Dunleavy liked her. She said she had her own mind.” I put the plate away. “She even got us around the fun run on Sixteenth Street. Up Georgia and across on Missouri. I didn’t know she knew that part of town.”

He was folding the dish towel. He folded it in half, and in half again, and hung it on the oven door, and didn’t say anything at all.

Then he went through to the living room, and sat in his chair, and picked up the notepad.

“Tuesday,” he said, when the recorders were running. “We’ll start on the Tuesday. Most of what matters happened on the Tuesday, though none of us knew it.”

The Hands

• RECORDING · APRIL 16, 1912

By Tuesday the ship had found a shape for its grief, the way water finds a shape for a jar.

There was a routine to it. That was the strange thing. People need one, even then. Breakfast was served in sittings, ours and theirs together, and the women from the boats came to the tables in borrowed clothes and sat with their hands in their laps and ate nothing, and then came back at the next sitting and ate a little. The children ran in the corridors, because children will. The ladies in the second-class saloon went on sewing their blanket coats. The doctors went from cabin to cabin. And all day long, along the rail on the boat deck, there were women standing, one or two at a time, looking out at the sea behind us. Not looking for anything. There was nothing to look for. Only looking.

I worked. I think I could have gone on working for a week without sleeping, that week, and I nearly did. When you're a bell boy, the work comes to you. A lady wants a shawl from her cabin. A gentleman wants a message taken to the purser. The doctor wants hot water, the chief steward wants the boys to clear the library, a child has been lost on B deck and must be found. You run, and you run, and you carry, and nobody sees you, and you see everyone.

That was the day I learned who was in the boat.

I never asked. I want you to understand that. A bell boy who asks questions gets sent below. I only stood where I was put, by doors and in corners

and at the ends of tables with a coffee pot, and the survivors talked, as people do on the second day, when the first shock has worn off and the words begin to come. They talked to each other, low, over my head, as if I were a coat stand. *Which boat were you in? Oh, we were in the one with the officer who swore. We were in the one with the lady who rowed. We were in the one that went back.* By the afternoon I could have drawn you a chart of every boat on that ship and who had been in it, most of them. I had not set out to. It was what I did with my eyes when nobody needed them.

And the boat with the young woman in the dark coat, and the mother who didn't speak, and the two children: that one I found I had drawn more carefully than the others.



The wireless cabin had become a place I could hardly get into.

Cottam had not slept since Sunday. He was still at the key, gray in the face, sending names, and the pile of newspaper telegrams on the desk had fallen over and been stacked again in the bunk, because there was nowhere else to put it. And now there was a second operator in there with him. A boy not much older than Cottam, with his feet wrapped in bandages up to the ankles, sitting in a chair somebody had carried up, with a pad on his knee, writing out names for Cottam to send.

His name was Harold Bride. He was the Titanic's junior wireless man. He had been in the water, and on an overturned boat half the night, with someone standing on his feet, and the feet had been crushed and frozen, and he could not walk. They had carried him up to the wireless cabin because he had asked them to, because he knew the work and Cottam needed help, and he had been there ever since.

I brought them tea. Bride looked up when I came in and said, "Thanks, kid," and went back to his pad. I don't think he saw me. He didn't see anybody that week. He was looking at something a long way off, all the time, through the walls.

There was a telegram on the top of the press pile that afternoon that was not from a newspaper. Cottam saw me look at it, and turned it toward me so

I could read it, without a word.

It was from the President of the United States. It asked whether Major Archibald Butt was aboard.

“Is he?” I said.

Cottam shook his head. “Not on any list.” He turned it back face down on the pile. “Captain says names, and nothing but names, to the shore. If the major’s name isn’t in them, that’s the answer.” He put his hand on the key. “Names, Bertie. That’s all we can do.”

He went on sending. The President’s telegram stayed on the pile, face down, with all the others.

I have thought about that since. The President of the United States asked a question about his friend, and a boy of twenty-one with no sleep put it face down on a pile, because the names came first. And he was right. I have been on the wrong side of a great many orders, in a great many lives. That one was right.



There was a gentleman from the boat I want to tell you about.

I’ll call him Mr. Ainsley. It wasn’t his name. I told you I wouldn’t give you the names, and I won’t. But you need to be able to call him something, and so do I, and Ainsley will do.

He was about forty-five. Tall, well made, with a good jaw and a fine head of hair going gray at the sides, the kind of man who looks as if he ought to be on the board of something, and was, I learned later, on the boards of several things. He had been in first class on the Titanic. He was on the boat deck of the Carpathia by Tuesday morning, in his own clothes. That was the first thing I noticed about him. His own clothes. A good gray suit, a little creased, but dry and whole, and a proper collar, and his own shoes. Good black shoes, with hard leather heels, that you could hear on the deck boards from twenty feet away.

Most of the men who came off those boats came off them in whatever they’d been wearing at midnight. Evening clothes with a coat over them. Pajamas. One man came up the ladder in his dressing gown and a lifebelt and

a bowler hat. Mr. Ainsley had dressed. He had dressed, all the way to his shoes, and come up on deck and got into a boat. And there was only one kind of boat a man could have got into in his own good shoes, with time to tie the laces: one of the early ones, that went down half empty, when nobody yet believed the ship would sink.

He talked a great deal. He was a talker, the kind people gather around. By Tuesday afternoon he had a little group of his own in the first-class smoking room, other survivors, and a few of our own passengers too, and he told them about the night, the boat, the cold, and he told it well. He had a way of telling things so that you saw them. He had a big laugh, and he used it, even then, even that week, at the right moments, to let people breathe.

And he told them, more than once, that in his boat it had been very calm, and very orderly. That he had sat in the stern, at the tiller, and kept up the ladies' spirits. That they had done everything right. That nobody was turned away.

I took him a cup of coffee, at about four o'clock. He took it from the tray without looking at me, as gentlemen did, and said "Thank you, boy," and turned back to his audience.

And I saw his hands.

He had wrapped the right one in a handkerchief. The left was bare. Across the palm of it, at the base of every finger, there was a row of blisters, big ones, the kind you get from hours on something rough and hard, and all of them had burst, and the skin had come away raw and red underneath. The handkerchief on the right hand had a stain coming through it in the same places. In the same row.

I have pulled an oar, Ms. Barnett, in more than one life. I know the hands of a man who has rowed all night. You blister in that row, across the root of the fingers, both hands, because an oar takes both. A tiller you steer with one hand, and you shift it from one to the other when you're tired, and you may get a sore palm, but you don't get that. Not on both hands. Not in that row.

Mr. Ainsley had not been sitting in the stern keeping up the ladies' spirits. Mr. Ainsley had been on an oar, all night, as hard as he could pull.

There was nothing wrong with that. I want to say that plainly. A man who rows all night in an open boat to keep people alive has nothing to hide. He has something to be proud of. Most men would have shown you their hands.

Mr. Ainsley had wrapped one of his up, and was telling a room full of people that he'd sat at the tiller.

I put that away. Not where I'd put the young woman. Somewhere nearer.



At about five, I saw him go and talk to Mr. Hatch.

Hatch was in his corner of the second-class smoking room, by the window, with his notebook. He had been at it all day. Survivors came and sat with him, one at a time, and talked, and he listened and wrote, and bought them coffee, and they went away. I had carried a good deal of the coffee.

Mr. Ainsley came in from the deck, in his hard heels, and the room heard him come, and he went to Hatch's corner and sat down across from him, uninvited, and smiled. I was at the sideboard with a tray of cups. I couldn't hear them. They kept their voices low. But I could see them, and I watched.

Ainsley did most of the talking. He leaned forward with his elbows on his knees and his wrapped hand hanging loose, very friendly, very easy, and talked, and once he laughed, the big laugh, loud enough to make heads turn, and put his good hand on Hatch's shoulder for a moment. Hatch didn't laugh. He sat back in his chair with his own hand flat on the notebook and listened, and his face went very still, and then a little white, and at the end he shook his head, once. Only once.

Ainsley looked at him for a moment, still smiling. Then he stood up and went out, with his heels going across the boards.

I took Hatch his tea.

"Bertie," he said, when he saw me. He looked very tired, and something else. Something I couldn't read, at first. "Do you know what a story's worth?"

"No, sir."

“Five hundred dollars.” He laughed, not the big laugh, a small dry one. “I’ve just been offered five hundred dollars for a notebook. Cash, on the pier, on Thursday night. That’s more than I made last year.” He picked up the tea. His hand wasn’t quite steady. “And a good deal of very friendly advice about what happens to men who write things down that aren’t true.”

“Is it true, sir? What you wrote?”

He looked at me over the cup for a long moment.

“Every word,” he said. “I’ve got it from three people now, Bertie. Three. In the same boat. Two of them didn’t know the others had talked to me.” He put his hand flat on the notebook again, on his knee. “That’s when you know it’s true. When three people who haven’t spoken to each other tell you the same thing they all agreed to forget.”

He didn’t say what. And I didn’t ask, because I didn’t need to. I had seen the hands.



That night I couldn’t sleep, again. I went up through the ship in my socks with my boots in my hand, as I always did, and on the boat deck, in the lee of one of the boats, I found her.

The young woman in the dark coat. She was sitting in a deck chair wrapped in two blankets, and in her lap, wrapped in a third, was the little girl, the six-year-old, wide awake, staring up at the stars. The child had not slept since Sunday night, I learned later. Not really. She would close her eyes and see the water and open them again. So the young woman had brought her up into the air, where it was cold and dark and quiet, and was holding her.

And she was singing to her. Very softly. Not even singing. Humming.

I stopped dead in the shadow of the boat with my boots in my hand.

I knew that tune.

I’m going to be very careful how I tell you this, Ms. Barnett, because I’ve never told anyone, and I want to get it right. I knew that tune the way you know your own mother’s voice. Better. I had known it longer than I had known anything. I had hummed it to myself in more lives than I can count, in cells and on battlefields and in sickbeds and on long night watches, as some

people say a prayer. I hummed it on that ship. I had hummed it in the bunk under Stan the first night, very quietly, to find out whether Bertie Pike's voice could carry it. It was mine.

And I had never, in all those lives, in all that time, heard another living soul hum it.

The little girl said something. I couldn't hear what. The young woman stopped humming, and bent her head, and answered her.

"It's a very old song," she said. "Older than anything. My father found it in a book. Somebody carved it on a stone, a long time ago, so it wouldn't be lost." Her voice was quiet and level and very English. "It's about how life is short. So you mustn't spend it being sad. *While you live, shine*. That's how it starts."

"What does that mean?"

"It means be as bright as you can," the young woman said, "for as long as you're here." And she began to hum it again, from the beginning.

I stood in the shadow of the boat until my feet were numb.

Then I did the thing I have regretted more than almost anything I have done in all my lives. I explained it.

I told myself what she had told the child: that it had been found. That some Englishman had dug a stone out of the ground in Turkey thirty years before, with the song carved on it, notes and all, and printed it in a journal, and that any clever girl with a father who read the right journals could have learned it off the page. That it was a coincidence. A strange one. The kind you get, in a long enough life.

I believed it, because it was true, as far as it went. And because the other thing was impossible.

I went back down to my bunk, and lay under Stan, and didn't sleep at all.



He stopped. He was looking at the window, at nothing.

"What is it?" I said. "The song."

He was quiet for so long that I thought he wasn't going to answer. Then, very softly, not well, in an old man's thin voice, he hummed a few bars of it for

the tape. It was a simple tune. It rose and fell and turned back on itself, like something you would sing to a child. It was over almost before it began.

“An old song,” he said.

“That’s all?”

“That’s all, today.”

I found it that night. It wasn’t hard. The oldest complete piece of music in the world, the websites said, carved on a marble column for a man’s wife, somewhere around the first century, in a town that is now in Turkey. Dug up by a Scottish archaeologist in 1883, exactly as the young woman on the deck had said. There were recordings. I played one, very quietly, at the kitchen table, with Freda asleep down the hall, and it was the tune he had hummed.

While you live, shine. Have no grief at all. Life exists only a short while, and time demands its due.

The first century. It was the oldest music anyone had. I sat and looked at the date for a long time. Then I went back to the transcript, and the place where he had said he’d known it longer than he’d known anything, and I found I didn’t want to think about the arithmetic.

Freda typed that session the following Sunday. When she got to the humming, she stopped, and played it back, and played it again.

“What’s this?” she said.

“An old song.”

“I know that,” said Freda. “I’ve heard it. I’ve heard him do it. On the other tapes. In the background, when he’s drawing.” She took the headphones off. “He hums it all the time, Mom. Like, every session. You never noticed?”

I hadn’t.

The Foot of the Stairs

• RECORDING · APRIL 17, 1912

On Wednesday evening the fog came down.

We were getting near the American coast by then, off the shoals south of Nantucket, and the fog came up out of the sea in the late afternoon and closed over us like a lid. In an hour you couldn't see the bow from the bridge. In two you couldn't see the rail from the deck chairs. The captain brought her down to half speed, and then to dead slow, and the ship's whistle began.

Every minute. A long, low, terrible sound, out into the white, and then nothing, and then a minute later the same sound again. It went on all night. It went through the hull and the decks and the walls and the bunks and the people in them. I have heard a great many sounds in a great many lives that I would rather not hear again. That one is near the top. Seven hundred people who had heard a ship's whistle at sea three nights before, and what came after it, lay in their bunks and on the floors of the saloons and listened to it, once a minute, all night long.

Nobody slept much, on the Wednesday. Not them, and not us.



Mr. Hatch spent the afternoon typing.

He had moved from the smoking room to a table in the corner of the second-class library, where it was quieter, and he had the typewriter out of its case for the first time since we'd left New York, and he was typing with two fingers, very fast, from the notebook propped open beside the machine. The

notebook was twice the size it had been on Monday. He had been writing in it for three days.

I asked him once, when I brought him tea, what he was typing.

"A fair copy," he said, without stopping. "Some of it. The worst of my handwriting. In case a man in New York can't read it." He stopped then, and looked at the page in the machine, and at the notebook, and then at me. "I'll never finish. There's too much. I'll do the rest on the train."

"What train, sir?"

"Whichever one's going out of New York first on Friday morning," he said, "to wherever is furthest from Mr. Ainsley." He smiled. It was a tired smile, but a real one. "Don't look like that, Bertie. Men like Mr. Ainsley don't do anything. They hire lawyers. In a year I'll be in court, and I'll be broke, and I'll have the best story of my life with my name on it." He went back to his two fingers. "There are worse ways to be broke."

I looked at the typewriter case, open on the chair beside him. There were already pages in the lid, a little stack of them, typed and folded. Not many. Five or six.

I didn't know then that I would carry that case off the ship myself, and that it would cost me more than anything I had carried on it.



At half past ten that night I brought him his last cup of tea.

He was back in his corner in the smoking room by then. The library had been given over to survivors to sleep in. He was sitting by the black window with the fog pressed against the glass outside, with his coat on, and the notebook on his knee, and his pencil, and he wasn't writing. He was reading it, from the beginning, slowly, turning the pages, the way you read a letter you're about to send to somebody who matters.

The whistle went, outside. The glasses on the sideboard rattled.

"Bertie," he said.

"Sir."

"When this is printed." He closed the notebook, and slid it into the inside pocket of his coat, and buttoned the pocket, and patted it once, as I had seen

him do every time. "When it's printed, I'm going to put you in it. *A bell boy named Bertie, who brought tea.* How's that?"

"I'd rather you didn't, sir."

He laughed. "Why on earth not?"

"Lyle would have my hide, sir."

He laughed again, properly this time, and took the tea, and drank it, and made a face at it, because it had been standing.

"I'm going to walk once round the deck," he said, "in this pea soup, and get the cobwebs out, and then I'm going to bed. If anybody asks you, Bertie." He looked at me over the cup, and for a moment he wasn't smiling. "If anybody asks you, you never saw this notebook."

"No, sir."

"Good boy."

That was all. That was the last thing he ever said to me. *Good boy.* I took the cup back to the pantry and Evans washed it and I went down to my bunk.



I didn't sleep. The whistle wouldn't let me, and nor would I.

At a quarter to one I got up and went up through the ship in my socks.

You couldn't see anything on deck. I came out through the door onto the boat deck and stepped into white. Not white like snow. White like the inside of a cloud, wet and cold and close against your face, so thick the electric lights along the deckhouse were only yellow smears in it, a few feet apart, with nothing between them. Everything dripped. The rail dripped. The boats over my head dripped. The deck was black and shining and slick under my socks.

The whistle went. I felt it in my chest.

And when it stopped, in the silence after it, I heard footsteps.

Somewhere ahead of me, along the deck, in the fog. Going away. Quick, and even, and hard. Click, click, click, click, on the wet boards, getting fainter. Then a door. Then nothing.

I stood still. I knew that step. Anyone on that ship would have known it, by then.

Leather heels.



The after companionway was a steep stair that went down from the boat deck, inside, to the promenade deck below. Teak steps with brass on the edges, a brass handrail on each side, and a light at the top and a light at the bottom. It was how the second-class passengers went up and down to the boat deck. It was where I'd seen Mr. Hatch go up and down, every day, with his notebook.

The door at the top was standing open, and the light at the top was on, and the fog was drifting in over the sill.

There was a hat on the top step.

A gray felt hat, a cheap one, lying upside down on the top step, with its crown on the tread and the inside of it facing up at the light. I stopped in the doorway and looked at it. The fog was blowing in all around it, and the tread was wet, and the brass edge was wet. The inside of the hat was dry.

Then I looked down the stairs.

He was lying at the bottom. On his back, on the landing, with one leg still up on the lowest step and his arms out, and his head at an angle a head should not be at, against the wall. His eyes were open. He was looking up the stairs, straight at me.

I have seen a great many dead men, Ms. Barnett. I knew before I was halfway down.

I went down anyway. I went down very carefully, on the edges of the steps, close to the rail, not touching it, and I knelt beside him on the landing and put two fingers under his jaw, as I had done in other lives, and there was nothing. He was still warm. He had not been there long. Minutes.

I didn't touch anything else. I looked.

I want to tell you what I saw, in the order I saw it, because I have gone over it so many times since that it's worn smooth, and I want you to have it exactly.

His coat. The inside pocket, on the left. The one he buttoned every time, and patted. It was unbuttoned. It was hanging open, and it was empty. I

could see the lining. There was nothing in it.

His right hand, the one flung out toward the wall. The knuckles were skinned. All four of them, raw and fresh, with a little blood in the creases. You don't skin your knuckles falling down a flight of stairs on your back. You skin them hitting something.

His pencil. It was on the third step from the top, lying across the tread. Not at the bottom with him. At the top.

And on the fifth step, near the wall side, on the wet teak, there was a mark. Half a mark. The back of a shoe, where the heel had come down hard on the wet wood. A neat, sharp-edged, curved half-moon, the kind a hard leather heel makes, with one small square notch out of the curve of it, on the inside edge, where a nail had worked loose or a bit of the leather had chipped. Going up. Not down. Up.

I knelt there, beside him, with the whistle going, and I put it together, as you put together a thing you already know. A man at the top of the stairs, in the fog, at night, with his notebook buttoned in his pocket. Somebody with him. A hat knocked off on the top step before any of the fog had got into it. A fist thrown. A pencil dropped. A fall. And then somebody coming quickly down after him, kneeling where I was kneeling now, unbuttoning a dead man's pocket. And going back up, fast, on hard heels, one of them coming down on a wet step and leaving half a moon.

Click, click, click. A door.



There was a sound behind me. Below me. On the promenade deck, at the bottom of the stairs, a door opening.

I turned.

It was the young woman in the dark coat.

She had come up the corridor from the second-class cabins below, I learned later, because the little girl had woken with the whistle and cried, and she had come up to find somebody, anybody, to get the child some warm milk. She was in a nightdress with her coat over it, and her hair down her

back, and a pair of borrowed felt slippers on her feet, the soft kind they had given out to the women who came off the boats with no shoes.

She stopped in the doorway at the bottom of the stairs and saw him. Then she saw me.

She didn't scream. She didn't make any sound at all. She stood in the doorway with one hand on the frame and looked.

And I watched her look, Ms. Barnett. I watched her eyes. I have never forgotten it, and I never will.

They went to his face first, as anyone's would. Then, without any pause at all, they went to the coat. The open pocket. Then to his right hand, against the wall, and the knuckles. Then up the stairs, quickly, step by step, to the pencil on the third step, to the hat on the top step, upside down in the light. Then down again. To the fifth step.

To the half moon.

Every one. In order. In about the time it takes to say it.

Then she looked at me.

We stayed like that for I don't know how long. A boy of twelve kneeling by a dead man on a landing, and a young woman in a nightdress and a coat, standing in a doorway three feet from him, with the fog drifting down the stairs between us and the whistle going, once, and then the silence after it. And neither of us said anything at all, because there was nothing to say. We had both just done the same thing. We both knew it. We were both, for the first time in that life, looking at somebody who could see.

I can't tell you what it was like. I've tried. It was like being alone in a dark house for a very long time, and hearing somebody in the next room put down a cup.

"You've seen it," she said. Very quietly.

"Seen what, miss?"

"Don't," she said. "Not with me."

I didn't say anything.

She came in off the doorway, then, and knelt on the other side of him, on the landing, and put her fingers to his throat, the way I had. Her face didn't change. She took her hand away.

“Go and get the doctor,” she said. “And the officer on watch. I’ll stay with him.”

I looked at her. I looked at the felt slippers on her feet, soft, silent, the kind you couldn’t have heard on those boards if you’d been standing beside them. I looked up the stairs at the half moon on the fifth step.

I didn’t want to leave her there with it. I knew that. I knew it as clearly as I’ve ever known anything.

And I was twelve, and a dead man was lying on the landing, and a lady had told me to go for the doctor.

So I went.



When I came back with the doctor and the officer of the watch and two stewards, it was ten minutes later, perhaps a little more. She was still there, kneeling beside him, exactly where I had left her. She had closed his eyes.

The doctor knelt and looked and shook his head. The officer stood at the top of the stairs with a lantern and looked down, and swore under his breath, and then said he was sorry, miss.

“Stairs like glass in this,” he said. “Poor devil must have gone straight down them in the dark. The whole deck’s like a skating rink. I nearly went over myself an hour ago.”

“Yes,” said the doctor. “A fall. Look at the angle of the neck.” He sat back on his heels. “Does anybody know who he is?”

“His name’s Hatch,” I said. “Second class, sir. He’s a writer.”

The officer looked at me as if he’d only just noticed I was there. Which I suppose he had.

I looked past him, up the stairs, at the fifth step.

The half moon was gone.

There was a smear there instead. A long, soft, shapeless smear across the wet teak, as if somebody had slipped on it. Somebody in soft shoes.

I looked at the young woman. She was getting up off her knees, with one hand on the rail, and her coat had come open, and I saw that the hem of her

nightdress was wet and dark across the front, as if she'd gone down on a wet stair.

"I'm sorry," she said to the officer. Her voice was perfectly steady. "I slipped, coming down to him. I'm afraid I've made a mess of your stairs."

"Not at all, miss," said the officer. "Easily done. That's just what I'm saying. Easily done, in this."

He wrote it in his book, standing there under the lantern. I watched him write it. I could read it upside down.

Fell on after companionway in fog. Death accidental.

And the young woman pulled her coat around her, and nodded to the doctor, and went back down the corridor toward the second-class cabins, to get the little girl her milk. She didn't look at me as she went.

She didn't need to.



He stopped.

I realized I had been holding my pen without writing anything for some time. I put it down.

"Did she take it?" I said. "The notebook."

"That's what I thought," he said. "For about a day."

"And the mark on the step. She wiped it out. On purpose."

"Yes."

"Why?"

He didn't answer that. He looked at the window. Outside, the rain had stopped, and the field was standing in water, and the sky was low and white and close, almost like fog.

"The officer wrote down what was in front of him," I said. I heard my own voice, a little strange. "*Death accidental*. And went to bed."

"Yes," he said. "There's always one of those."

I thought of a young policeman with a face like a boiled ham, standing in an apartment on Calloway Street, writing *Desk* in his book and going away. And then I thought of something else, and it went through me, and I looked at him.

"Leather heels," I said.

He met my eyes.

“I told you,” he said. “It reminded me of something a long way off.”

“That’s why your hand stopped. On the coffee pot.”

“Yes,” he said. “That’s why.”

The Little Girl's Name

The card came on Monday night, by courier, at a quarter to nine.

It was the same young man in the same reflective jacket, with the same motorcycle idling at the curb and the same tablet for me to sign with my finger. He said, "Barnett?" and I said yes, and he gave me the envelope, heavy cream paper, *Aldine, Mercer and Voss*, and was gone before I had the door shut.

Freda was at the kitchen table. She had stopped typing when the doorbell went, and she had taken her headphones off, and she was watching me come back down the hall with the envelope just as she had watched me in the winter, when the last one came.

"Is it him?"

"It's the firm."

"It's him," said Freda. "Open it."

There was one card inside. No letter, no typed note. One line, in ink, in the old schooled hand that leaned too far to the right.

It was worse than the last one. I saw that before I had read a word. The tremor in the long strokes had got into all of them now, the short ones too, so that every letter wavered a little, like something seen through water. In two places the pen had stopped, and started again, and left a blot. Whoever had written it had held the pen very hard, and it had taken him a long time.

Please ask him the little girl's name.

I read it out. Freda held out her hand, and I gave it to her, and she looked at it under the kitchen light for a long time.

"His hand's worse," she said.

“Yes.”

“Like, a lot worse.” She turned the card over, as if there might be something on the back. There wasn’t. “What little girl?”

“In the boat. The one the governess was holding. On the deck, at night, when she hummed.” I sat down across from her. “It’s in Thursday’s tape. You typed it.”

“I know who she is. I mean, why her?” Freda put the card down on the table between us, very carefully, as if it might break. “Of everybody on the whole ship, he wants to know her name. Not the bad guy’s. Not the governess’s. A little kid’s.”

“He’s told me he won’t give any names from the boat.”

“I know. I typed that too.” Freda looked at the card. “So it’s like a test. Right? To see if he’ll do it.”

“Maybe.”

“Or to see if he knows it,” said Freda.

I didn’t say anything to that. I didn’t have anything to say. I picked up the card and put it in my notebook, beside the first letter and the Carpathia card, three of them now in a row, the steady hand and the shaking one and this one, which was something worse than shaking.



On Tuesday I went looking for Mr. Hatch.

I had been putting it off. I knew why. Every name Tom had given me so far that I could check, I had checked, and every one had come back true. Rostron, Cottam, Bride, the Californian, the four buried at four o’clock. But those were famous names, in a famous story, with a hundred books about them. A clever man could have read the books. Hatch was different. Hatch was a nobody. A thin man in a brown suit with a typewriter, going to Naples to write about a volcano. If Hatch had been on the Carpathia, and had died on the Carpathia, there might be nothing anywhere in the world to say so. And if there was nothing, I would never know whether that was because Hatch had never existed, or because nobody had cared.

So I didn’t want to look, and I looked.

The Library of Congress has put millions of pages of old American newspapers online, every page photographed, every word run through a machine so you can search it, badly. I sat at the kitchen table after the school run with a cup of coffee going cold and searched April 1912 for *Hatch*, and got four hundred results, most of them about chickens.

I narrowed it down. *Hatch* and *Carpathia*. Nothing. *Hatch* and *fell*. Nothing useful. I tried the papers one at a time, the New York ones, for the days after the *Carpathia* came in, the nineteenth and the twentieth and the twenty-first, when every page of every paper was about the Titanic and nothing else, and the machine had read the small print so badly it was nearly useless. I read the pages myself. Column by column. It took most of the day.

I found it at a quarter past three, in the New-York Tribune for Saturday, April 20, 1912, on page seven, at the bottom of a long column of short items headed *INCIDENTS OF THE RESCUE SHIP'S VOYAGE*. Between a paragraph about a dog that had not been saved and a paragraph about a collection taken up among the *Carpathia*'s passengers for her crew.

Three lines.

Among the Carpathia's own passengers, a magazine writer named Lowell Hatch, bound for Naples, was killed on Wednesday night by a fall on a companionway, the decks being made slippery by the fog. His body was brought into port.

That was all.

I sat at the kitchen table and read it, and read it again, and then I got up and walked around the kitchen, and came back, and read it again. *A magazine writer. Bound for Naples. Wednesday night. A fall on a companionway. The fog.*

Every word of it was what he'd told me. And there was not one word in it he couldn't have known if he had been there, and not one word he could have read anywhere else, because I had just spent six hours finding it and I was the best there was at finding things, once.

Or he had found it first. Years ago. On some long night of his own. And built a man around it.

I made myself write that down. I made myself look at it. Then I wrote under it: *Three lines. Brown suit, two fingers, "Good boy." Nobody builds that from three lines.*

And then: *I don't know that.*



I read him the card on Thursday morning, before the recorders, at the kitchen table, with the coffee.

He took it out of my hand and held it near the window, in the gray light, and looked at it for a long time. He looked at the handwriting more than at the words. I watched his eyes go along the long strokes, the blots, the places where the pen had stopped and started.

"He's not well," he said quietly.

"No."

"He's worse than in the winter. A good deal worse." He turned the card in his fingers. "And he's in a hurry now. He wasn't, before."

Then he read the words, and something in his face shut, very gently, like a door closed on a sleeping child.

"I told you," he said. "No names from the boat."

"I know. I told him that you'd said that. In the transcript."

"Then he knows." He put the card down on the table. He was quiet for a while. Then he reached past me for the notepad on the windowsill, the one he kept for shopping lists, and tore off the top sheet, and picked up a pencil, and turned his shoulder to me, a little, like a boy in a classroom covering his answers, and wrote something. One word, I thought. Perhaps two. He folded the paper in half, and in half again.

"Have you got an envelope?"

I had. I always had. He put the folded paper inside it, and licked the flap, and sealed it, and pressed it down with his thumb, all the way along. Then he handed it to me.

"Send him that," he said. "Sealed. Not in the transcript. Not typed. Just that."

I looked at the envelope in my hand. Then I looked at him.

"You won't tell me," I said. "But you'll tell him."

"Yes."

"Why?"

“Because I’m not telling him,” he said. “Not really.” He folded his hands on the table. “Ms. Barnett, if I’m wrong about why he’s asking, then it’s a little girl’s name, a hundred and fourteen years old, sealed in an envelope, and it goes to an old man who will read it once and put it in a drawer, and no harm in the world comes of it. And if I’m right about why he’s asking...” He stopped.

“Then what?”

“Then he knows it already,” he said. “Better than I do.”

He wouldn’t say anything else about it. I asked him three ways, as I used to ask a source who had decided to stop talking, and he answered every one of them with that same gentle shut-door look. In the end I put the envelope in my notebook, beside the card, and didn’t open it.

I want to be clear about that. I didn’t open it. Not then, not in the car, not at the kitchen table that night with a kettle on the stove and nobody watching. I sent it to Aldine, Mercer and Voss by registered mail on Friday morning, sealed, exactly as he’d given it to me, with a short note of my own: *From the gentleman. At his request, not opened.*

When I told Freda, she looked at me as if I had grown a second head.

“You didn’t open it?”

“No.”

“Mom. You open *everything*. You opened my report card from the eighth grade before I got home and you resealed it with a glue stick.”

“That was different.”

“How?”

“He asked me not to,” I said.

Freda looked at me for a long moment. Then she went back to her laptop, and put her headphones on, and said, to the screen, so quietly I almost didn’t hear it, “Who even are you.”



I told him about the Tribune, before I left.

I had not been going to. I had thought I would keep it, as I’d kept Pearl in the winter, to be the one who knew. But at the door, with my coat on, I found I wanted to see his face.

"I found Mr. Hatch," I said.

He had been holding the door. He stopped.

"In the New-York Tribune. April the twentieth. Page seven." I had it on my phone. I read it to him, all three lines, standing on his porch, with the field behind me still standing in water.

He listened to the end without moving. When I had finished, he looked out over my shoulder at the field for a moment.

"Three lines," he said.

"Yes."

"Bound for Naples. He'd have liked that they got Naples in." He was quiet. "That's more than most of them got, you know. Most of the ones who die like that. Three lines, with your name spelled right." He looked back at me. "Thank you for finding him, Ms. Barnett."

"It doesn't prove anything," I said. "You know that. You could have found it too."

"I could have," he said. "Yes."

"Did you?"

"No," he said. "I've never looked." And then, when I didn't say anything: "I didn't want to see how short it was."



On the step I turned back, because I had nearly forgotten.

"Next week is Freda's spring break," I said. "She asked if she could come. On Thursday. She's typed every one of these since the winter. She wants to meet you." I hesitated. "She says she's met you already, really. From the tapes. But she wants to see if you're the same."

Something came into his face that I hadn't seen there before. It took ten years off him, and then another five.

"I'd like that very much," he said. "Tell her I'll make the eggs."

Spring Break

Freda changed her clothes three times before we left.

I didn't say anything. I sat in the car in the driveway with the engine running and the heater on and waited, and when she came out the third time, in the jeans she'd started with and a sweater of mine that she had stopped asking to borrow sometime around Christmas, she got in and put her feet on the dashboard and said, "Don't."

"I didn't say anything."

"You were going to."

We drove north. The trees along the highway had gone a faint, uncertain green, the color of a thing that hasn't made up its mind yet, and past Frederick the fields were plowed and dark and wet, with gulls following the tractors. Freda didn't put her headphones on. She sat with her phone face down on her knee and watched it all go by.

"What do I call him?" she said, somewhere past the state line.

"Mr. Hale."

"He calls you Ms. Barnett. Still. After like five months." She thought about it. "That's so weird. That's like a guy in a movie about a butler."

"He's from another time."

"Mom," said Freda, "that's literally the whole question."



He was on the porch when we came up the gravel road. No umbrella, for once. It wasn't raining. He was standing at the top of the steps in his cardigan, but-

toned wrong by one, with his hands behind his back, and when the car stopped he came down the steps one at a time with his hand on the rail and stood at the bottom to wait for us, and I realized that he had been waiting at the window for a long time.

Freda got out of the car slowly. She stood by the door and looked at him, and he looked at her, and for a moment neither of them said anything.

Then he put out his hand.

“Miss Barnett,” he said.

“Freda,” said Freda. She shook it. “Nobody calls me Miss Barnett. Not even at school.”

“Freda, then.” He didn’t let go of her hand at once. He held it, and looked at her, and I saw his face do something I had only seen it do once before, on the porch the week before, when I asked him if she could come. “I’m Tom. I’ve heard a great deal about you.”

“I’ve heard a great deal about *you*,” said Freda. “Like, hours. I’ve typed about forty hours of you.”

“I’m so sorry.”

She laughed. It surprised her. It was the real laugh, the one she used to have when she was small, before she learned the careful one, and I had not heard it in a long time.



He made the eggs.

He made them the slow way, in a pan over a low flame, stirring all the time with a wooden spoon, and he made toast from the crying pillow, and he put a jar of marmalade on the table that I had never seen before and that I suspected he had bought that week in town for the occasion. Freda sat at the kitchen table with her chin on her hand and watched him do all of it as if she were watching a magic trick, trying to see where the card went.

“Mom says you do a thing,” she said.

“What thing?”

“Where you look at somebody and tell them stuff about themselves. Like the guy on TV. Where they were, what they had for lunch.” She tilted her head.

“Do it to me.”

He turned around from the stove with the spoon in his hand and looked at her. Freda sat up very straight and looked back, ready, as she used to stand at the plate in Little League.

He looked at her for what felt like a long time. Then he turned back to the pan.

“No,” he said.

“Why not?”

“Because your mother tells it better than I do it,” he said. “And because it’s rude.” He stirred the eggs. “And because you’d spend the rest of the morning wondering what I’d seen that I hadn’t said. People always do. It spoils the eggs.”

Freda looked at me. I shrugged. She looked back at him, at his back, at the cardigan buttoned wrong, and I saw her decide something about him, and file it, and I recognized the look, because it was mine.



She asked him about the song over breakfast.

“You hum it all the time,” she said. “On the tapes. Every one. When you’re drawing. Did you know?”

“Yes,” he said. “I’ve been told before.”

“What is it, really? Mom found it online. It’s like the oldest song in the world.”

“It’s an old song,” he said.

“You always say that.”

“Then it must be true.” He buttered a piece of toast and gave it to her, without asking, as you would for a child, and she took it without noticing, as a child does. “Would you like to hear it properly? Not on the tape.”

Freda nodded.

So he hummed it, there at the kitchen table, over the plates, in his thin old voice, all the way through. It took less than a minute. It went up, and turned, and came down, and turned back on itself, and ended almost where it began. Freda sat very still with the toast in her hand. And the second time through, so

quietly I almost didn't hear it, she hummed it with him. She had learned it off the tapes.

He stopped, and looked at her.

"You've got a good ear," he said. "Your mother told me."

Freda did the thing with her mouth, the small pressed thing, and looked at her plate.



My phone rang at a quarter past ten.

I almost didn't answer. It was a number I didn't know, a city exchange. But I had been waiting three months for a number I didn't know, so I took it out onto the porch and shut the door behind me.

It was a woman at the police department's records unit. She had the voice of somebody who had been reading out the same sentences all morning. My request for the complete file in the missing persons case had been processed, she said, and approved in part. Some material was withheld under the usual exemptions. The rest, including the responding officer's notes and the photographs taken at the scene, was ready to be collected in person, with identification, at the records office downtown, any weekday between nine and four.

"Photographs," I said.

"Fourteen photographs," said the woman. "And two pages of notes. You'll need to sign for them."

I said I would come on Monday. I stood on the porch for a while after she'd hung up, with the phone in my hand, looking at the field. Fourteen photographs. I had been in that apartment once, six years ago, and a cat had sat on my notebook. On Monday I was going to walk through it again.

It was cold on the porch, and I hadn't brought my coat out. Through the kitchen window beside me I could see the two of them at the table.

I didn't mean to watch. I want to say that. But I was a reporter for a long time, and a mother for longer, and the window was right there.

Freda was talking. She had her elbows on the table and her hands around her mug, and she was talking to him, quickly, looking down at the mug, and then up at him, and then down again. I couldn't hear anything through the

glass. He was sitting very still across from her, just as he sat when I talked about Carrow, with his hands folded on the table and his head a little on one side, listening. Not interrupting. Not doing anything at all but letting her talk.

Then she stopped. She put one hand up, quickly, and wiped under her eye with the heel of it, the way she had done since she was small when she didn't want anyone to see.

He said something. Not much. A sentence, perhaps two.

Freda looked at him for a long moment. Then she laughed, a small wet surprised laugh, and shook her head, and picked up her toast.

I went back in.



They both looked up when the door opened. I came across the kitchen, rubbing my arms against the cold, and as I came I heard the end of what he was saying, quietly, to her.

"...they don't get lighter, Freda. That's the thing nobody tells you. They get heavier, every day you carry them. And sooner or later, somebody else ends up carrying them for you."

Freda had her eyes on him. "Are you talking about me?"

"I'm talking about a notebook," he said. And then he looked up and saw me, and smiled, and said, "Was that your police file?"

"Yes. How did you know?"

"You went out with your shoulders up and came back with them down," he said. "And you said *photographs* on the porch loud enough to hear through a window." He got up to take my plate. "Good news?"

I told him. Fourteen photographs. Monday. He nodded slowly, and said that he'd like to hear about them, if I wanted to tell him, and put the plate in the sink.

"What did I miss?" I said, to the room.

Freda looked at her toast.

"We were talking about Bertie," said Tom. "His sisters, in Bootle. Freda wanted to know if he ever went home."

"Did he?"

“That’s another Thursday,” he said, and ran the water.

I looked at Freda. Freda looked at me, and then out of the window, at the field, and her face was perfectly calm and her eyes were a little red, and I knew my daughter, and I knew she was not going to tell me anything, and I let it go.

I let it go. I have thought about that since.



We went through to the living room at eleven. He sat in his chair and settled the notepad on his knee. I set out the recorders on the little table and said the date into them, and the time, and *Session twenty-five*, and then, because it was true and because it was going on the tape forever, *Freda Barnett present*.

Freda had not taken the chair I’d pulled up for her. She was sitting on the stairs, on the third step, among the books that climbed up them one to a step, with her knees drawn up and her arms around them. From there she could see him, and he could see her.

“Thursday,” he said. “The last day.”

He looked at Freda, on the stairs.

“I’m going to tell you how I lost,” he said. “It’s a long story. You might want to get comfortable.”

“I’m comfortable,” said Freda.

He nodded. He picked up the pencil, and without looking down he began to draw the star, around and around, and began.

The Boot Room

• RECORDING · APRIL 18, 1912, BEFORE DAWN

I didn't go back to my bunk that night. There didn't seem to be any point.

I sat on the floor of the bell boys' cabin with my back against Stan's bunk and my knees drawn up, in the dark, with the whistle going once a minute through the hull, and I did what I have always done when something has happened that I can't undo. I went over it. Not what I felt. I have never been much use at that. What I saw.

The hat, dry inside. The pencil on the third step. The knuckles. The open pocket. The half moon on the fifth step, with the little square notch out of its curve. The click of heels going away along the deck, and a door. And a young woman in felt slippers, kneeling on the other side of a dead man, looking at all of it in the same order I had.

And a smear on the fifth step, where the half moon had been.

I could have told the officer, of course. I want you to know I thought about it. I thought about it very carefully. I could have stood up on that landing in my socks and said, *Sir, there was a heel print on the fifth step and the lady wiped it out with her nightdress, and I heard a man in hard shoes walking away along the deck, and it was Mr. Ainsley, who offered Mr. Hatch five hundred dollars on Tuesday.*

And the officer would have looked at a bell boy with no cap on, at one in the morning, out of his bunk where he had no business to be, telling tales about a first-class gentleman who sat on the boards of several things. And

then at the young lady, who had just told him she slipped. And then at the step, which had nothing on it but a smear.

And he would have sent me below, and told Lyle, and that would have been the end of me. And of Hatch.

I've told you. When you're small, you don't push. You make the best of what's in front of you.

So I sat on the floor in the dark and asked myself what was in front of me. And at about four o'clock in the morning, I found it.

Shoes.



You'll have forgotten this, or you never knew it. In those days a gentleman traveling first class didn't clean his own shoes. Nobody would have expected him to. At night, before he went to bed, he put them outside his cabin door, in the passage, and in the morning they were back, polished, with his cabin number chalked on the sole. Somebody had come along the passage in the small hours and taken them away and cleaned them and brought them back. On the Carpathia that was the boots, an old steward called Fennimore, and on a busy crossing he had a bell boy to help him, and that week, with seven hundred extra people on board, he had two. I was one.

I'd been doing it for three weeks. I didn't think about it any more than you think about brushing your teeth.

Mr. Ainsley had been given a cabin on B deck, by one of our own first-class gentlemen who had moved in with his brother. I knew which one. I knew every cabin on that deck, by then, and who was in it.

And this is the thing I sat on the floor and turned over, Ms. Barnett, until I was sure. A man who has done what Mr. Ainsley did on that staircase wants, more than anything in the world, the next morning, to be a man who did nothing. He wants to be ordinary. He wants to do every single thing he would have done anyway. And a first-class gentleman, every night of his life, puts his shoes out.

If he didn't, Fennimore would notice. Fennimore noticed everything about shoes. He'd mention it to the bedroom steward, who'd mention it to

somebody else, and by breakfast half the stewards on the ship would know that the gentleman in B-52 had kept his shoes in, the night the writer fell.

A careful man would put them out. Wet as they were. And hope.

At half past four I went to the boot room.



It was a little steel cupboard of a place down on C deck, with a bench and a gas ring and a hundred pairs of shoes in rows on racks, and a smell of blacking that I can call up now if I close my eyes. Fennimore wasn't there yet. He came at five. I lit the lamp.

They were on the second rack, in the row Fennimore had collected from B deck at midnight. Black, good leather, a gentleman's shoes, still damp across the toes from the deck. And on the sole of the right one, in Fennimore's chalk, the number of his cabin.

I picked up the right shoe and turned it over under the lamp.

The heel was a hard one, stacked leather, the kind that clicks. And on the inside edge of it, at the curve, there was a notch. One small square notch, where a nail had worked loose and a bit of the leather had chipped away. Just there. Just that shape.

I stood under the lamp with that shoe in my hand for a long time.

I had him. I want you to understand that. In that cupboard, at twenty to five in the morning, I had him, as surely as I've ever had anyone. Hatch's pocket and Hatch's knuckles and Hatch's pencil, and a half moon on the fifth step with a notch in it, and the shoe that made it, in my hand.

And it was worth nothing. The half moon was gone. Wiped away. There was no one in the world who had seen it but me, and a young woman who had made very sure no one else would. And the shoe, by itself, was a gentleman's shoe with a chipped heel.

I didn't clean it. That was all I could think to do. Fennimore would clean the rest of the rack at five and send them up, and the right shoe of B-52 would go up with the others, and I didn't want a brush or a cloth to touch that heel. So I took a rag and did the toes of both, quickly, the way Fennimore liked, and the uppers, and put a shine on them you could see your

face in. And I left the heels alone. I put them back on the rack exactly where they'd been, with the chalk on the sole.

Then I put out the lamp, and went up, and at breakfast I saw Mr. Ainsley.



He was at the head of a table in the first-class dining saloon, at the first sitting, in his good gray suit and his shined shoes, with his little group around him. He was talking. He looked rested. He had a bruise on the left side of his jaw. A fresh one, going purple, just at the corner, where a man's fist lands if he's right-handed and swinging up.

He was telling them about it. I could hear him from the sideboard. He'd slipped on deck, he said, in that confounded fog, last night, coming back from a turn around the deck. Gone down like a sack of potatoes and hit his chin on the rail. He laughed about it. The big laugh. His group laughed too.

And then one of the ladies said, had he heard, about the poor man on the stairs? The writer? Killed, in the fog, last night. Fell all the way down. Wasn't it dreadful. And they'd all been saying, hadn't they, how slippery the decks were.

Mr. Ainsley put down his cup. He shook his head. He said it was a terrible thing, and he'd heard, and he was very sorry, and that only went to show. And then he said that he had spoken with the man himself, on Tuesday. Rather a sad case, he said. Hard up. Had been going about the ship trying to sell people's stories to the newspapers. He had told him, quite kindly, that it wasn't the thing. Not that week. Not with people grieving.

The ladies all agreed it wasn't the thing.

I poured the coffee and looked at the bruise on his jaw, and the hand that was holding his cup, the right one, still wrapped in a handkerchief. And I thought of four skinned knuckles on a dead man's hand, flung out against a wall.



The other thing came to me while I was pouring coffee. It's often that way. You stop looking for something and it walks up and sits down beside you.

The typewriter case.

Mr. Hatch had typed all Wednesday afternoon, in the library. A fair copy, he'd said. The worst of his handwriting. And when I took him his tea, I had seen the little stack of typed pages, folded, in the lid of the case. Five or six. And the case had been on the chair beside him.

Mr. Ainsley had his notebook. I was sure of that. A man like Ainsley doesn't throw a thing like that over the side. He keeps it. He wants to know whose names are in it. Who talked. Three people, Hatch had said. Three people in the same boat, who'd agreed to forget. In New York, Mr. Ainsley would want to see each of the three of them, very privately, and be very kind.

But Mr. Ainsley hadn't been in the library on Wednesday afternoon. He'd been in the smoking room, with his group, telling them about the tiller.

He didn't know about the pages.

I put down the coffee pot. I asked Lyle if I could go to the lavatory, and he said I had a bladder like a sparrow, and I went.



The library had been given over to survivors to sleep in. It was half dark, with the curtains drawn against the fog and the whistle going, and there were people asleep on the sofas and on mattresses on the floor and in the armchairs, under blankets, and a smell of wet wool and coal smoke. Nobody had touched Mr. Hatch's corner. Nobody had thought to. A dead man's things are the purser's business, and the purser, that morning, had seven hundred living people's business, and Hatch was a three-line paragraph.

The typewriter case was on the chair where I'd last seen it. Shut. Latched. I picked it up.

It was heavier than it looked. I remember thinking that. A small case, scuffed at the corners, with a leather handle that had been mended with string. *It's all I've got that's worth stealing*, he had said, on the gangway at New York, when I tried to take it from him.

I carried it out of the library past the sleeping people, and nobody woke. A bell boy carrying a case is the most ordinary thing in the world. I carried it down four decks to the bell boys' cabin and put it in my locker and shut the door.

Then I sat down on the floor in front of the locker, in my socks, and opened the case, and took the pages out of the lid, and read them.



He looked up then. At the stairs.

Freda was sitting very still on the third step, with her arms around her knees and her chin on them.

"I'm not going to tell you everything that was on those pages," he said. "I'll tell you what you need, and no more, and no names. I'm sorry. I know you'll want them."

"It's okay," said Freda. Her voice was small.

He nodded. He looked down at the notepad.

"It was an early boat," he said. "Lowered with a good deal of room left in it, the way the early ones were, when nobody believed yet. There were men in it. Mr. Ainsley at an oar. The mother, with the little boy. The young woman with the girl. Others." He drew around the star. "They pulled away from the ship as they'd been told, and lay off, and watched her go down. And then, when she'd gone, there were the people in the water."

He was quiet for a moment.

"You've read about it. Everyone has. The sound of it. There was room in that boat for twenty more. Some of them wanted to go back. And the young woman said no. She said it very clearly, Hatch wrote, so that everyone could hear. She said if they rowed back into that, there were a thousand people in the water and a boat with room for twenty, and the people in the water would come over the sides and turn the boat over, and then nobody would be saved at all. Not the children. Nobody. She said it as plainly as that." He stopped drawing. "And she was right. That's the thing. She was probably right. Boats that went back too soon, into the thick of it, had a terrible time. She did the arith-

metic, and she said it out loud, and nobody else in that boat was brave enough to.”

“And they didn’t go back,” I said.

“They lay off and waited. Rowed a little way, to be safe.” He looked at the window. “And a man swam to them. One man. A steward, from the Titanic, in his white jacket. He’d swum a long way, in that water, which nobody could do for long. He got to them. He got his hands on the side of the boat.”

Freda had gone very still.

“Mr. Ainsley stood up in the boat,” he said, “with his oar. And hit his hands. Twice. Until he let go.”

Nobody said anything. The woodstove ticked. Outside, a car went by on the far road.

“Then he sat down,” said Tom, “and took up his oar, and pulled. And he told everyone in that boat it hadn’t happened. That the man had been gone already. That nobody had seen anything, in the dark. And they all agreed. They sat in that boat until dawn, and they agreed. Hatch got it from three of them. The mother was one. She’d been holding the little boy, at the side, right there, and she’d seen the man’s face.” He put the pencil down. “That was what was in Hatch’s notebook. That was what Mr. Ainsley was going to walk off the ship with in his pocket. And that was what I had in a typewriter case in my locker, five pages of it, typed with two fingers, at a quarter past seven on Thursday morning.”



He stopped there. He reached for his tea.

Freda was looking at him from the stairs.

“He hit his hands,” she said. Very quietly.

“Yes.”

“And she said not to go back.”

“Yes.”

“So she’s...” Freda stopped. “Is she bad? Or is he? Or...”

“He hit a drowning man’s hands with an oar,” he said, “and then lied about it, and then killed a man on a staircase to keep the lie.” He said it quite gently.

“And she looked at a boat full of children and did a terrible sum and said the answer out loud. Those aren’t the same thing, Freda.”

“But nobody went back.”

“No.”

“And if they had, they all might have died.”

“Very likely.”

“So she was right,” said Freda, “and it was still awful.”

“Yes.”

Freda put her chin back down on her knees. She looked at the books on the step beside her for a long time.

“I don’t like that both of those are true,” she said.

“No,” said Tom. “Nobody does.” He picked up the pencil again. “That’s how you know they are.”

The Governess

• RECORDING · APRIL 18, 1912, MORNING

I had read the pages twice, sitting on the floor in front of my locker. I put them back in the lid of the case, and shut it, and latched it, and put it at the back of the locker behind my spare jacket, and shut the locker door. Then I sat there a while longer.

I knew what I had to do with them. That was the easy part. They had to go to somebody who could do something. Not a bell boy. Somebody with gold on his sleeve.

The hard part was how.

I couldn't walk into the purser's office with a dead man's typewriter case and say, *Sir, I took this from the library, and inside it there's an account of a first-class gentleman beating a drowning steward off a lifeboat with an oar, and I believe he killed the man who wrote it.* I'd have been in irons before I got to the second sentence. A bell boy who takes a dead passenger's property is a thief. That's all he is. Whatever's in the property.

No. It had to be found. By the right man, in the right way, so that he found it himself and believed what he'd found. That's the trick, Ms. Barnett. It's always been the trick, when you're small. You don't hand a grown man the answer. You put it where he'll trip over it, and then you stand back and let him be clever.

I was still working out where to put it when Lyle put his head round the door.

"Pike. There you are. There's a lady in second class asking for you."

“For me, sir?”

“By name. God knows why.” He looked at me as if I might have been stealing the spoons. “One of the survivors. D deck, forward. She says you were very kind to the children and she’d like a word, and some hot milk for the little one. Get the milk from Evans and go. And Pike.” He narrowed his eyes. “Whatever she gives you, you give half to me.”



It was an inside cabin, small, with two berths and a washstand and no port-hole. Somebody from our own second class had given it up for them. The mother was asleep in the lower berth, on her side, facing the wall, very still, with the doctor’s sleeping draught on the washstand beside her. The little boy was asleep in the upper berth with his thumb in his mouth. The girl, the six-year-old, was sitting on the floor in the corner wrapped in a blanket coat that one of our ladies had sewn, drawing on the back of a menu card with a pencil.

The young woman in the dark coat was sitting on the only chair, by the door, with her hands in her lap. She was dressed now, properly, in a gray skirt and a white blouse that were not hers, too short in the sleeves, and her hair was up. She looked tired. She looked as if she had not slept at all. She looked, also, as if she had been waiting for me, and had known exactly how long I would take.

“Thank you,” she said, and took the milk, and gave it to the little girl, and said something to her low, and the little girl went on drawing.

Then she turned the chair a little toward me, and looked at me, and didn’t say anything.

I stood by the door with my cap in my hands, and didn’t say anything either.

It went on for some time. The ship’s whistle went, outside, muffled, through the steel. The little girl’s pencil scratched.

“You were in the boot room this morning,” she said at last. “At about half past four.”

I didn’t answer.

"You smelled of blacking at breakfast," she said. "I was at the second sitting. You poured the coffee at the first-class tables and then you came through ours with the cream. Your hands smelled of blacking, and you had it in the creases of your knuckles, and on your cuff. You don't do the boots. You do the bags and the messages and the tea. The boots is an old man with a limp called Fennimore." She tilted her head. "You went to look at somebody's shoes."

"Yes, miss," I said.

There didn't seem to be any point saying anything else.

"Whose?"

"You know whose, miss."

"Yes," she said. "I do."



"You took the typewriter case from the library," she said. "At about seven. It was on the chair on Wednesday night, in his corner, when I came through with the children before bed. It wasn't there when I went past at eight this morning. Nobody had touched anything else of his. His pen was still on the table. Only the case." She looked at my hands again. "It's not with the purser. I asked the purser, at nine, very sadly, whether the poor man's things had been collected, because I'd like to send a note to his family. The purser said he hadn't had time. So you've got it."

"Yes, miss."

"Why?"

"Because he typed some of it out on Wednesday, miss," I said. "A fair copy. Five pages. They were in the lid. Mr. Ainsley took the notebook. He doesn't know about the pages."

She went very still.

I watched her take that in. I watched her see the five pages, folded, in the lid of a scuffed case with a mended handle, and see what was on them, and see that she had not known about them, and see what it meant that I had. It took her about as long as it takes to read this sentence. Then her face was calm again.

"You've read them," she said.

"Yes, miss."

"All of them."

"Yes, miss."

She looked at the lower berth, at the mother's back, turned to the wall.

"Then you know what's in them," she said, "and who."



I want to tell you about the next twenty minutes very carefully, Ms. Barnett, because I've never had another twenty minutes like them, in any life, before or since. I've had longer conversations. I've had cleverer ones, perhaps, with famous men. I've never had one like that.

She didn't argue with me. That was the first thing. She didn't pretend. She didn't tell me I was a child who didn't understand, or that I'd imagined it, or that a bell boy had no business in it. She talked to me as if I were exactly what I was, which nobody had done for three weeks, and I think nobody had done for longer than that, in that life or the one before.

"Mr. Ainsley killed him," I said. "On the stairs. You saw the step."

"Yes."

"You saw the heel. The half moon. You wiped it out."

"Yes."

"Why?"

She folded her hands in her lap.

"Because there was only one place that step went," she said. "Think about it. You're a clever boy. Cleverer than any boy I've met. Think it all the way through." She said it quite gently. "An officer sees that mark. He asks whose heel. He finds the shoe. Mr. Ainsley is questioned. Mr. Ainsley says he never went near the man. The officer asks why anyone would want to harm a poor writer. Somebody says, he was writing about the boats. The captain is told. The owners are told. In New York there will be an inquiry about the Titanic in any case, a great public one, with senators, and every survivor will be asked what happened in their boat, under oath." She looked at the berth. "And somebody will ask her."

"She told Mr. Hatch," I said.

"She told him once. At two in the morning, on Tuesday, in a corner of a smoking room, after a doctor had given her brandy. She told him because he was kind, and asked, and she hadn't slept, and she couldn't hold it anymore." She was still looking at the berth. "She'll never say it again. Not if she lives to be a hundred. Not unless somebody makes her. In a room full of newspapermen. Under oath. With her name in every paper in America the next morning. *The woman who sat in a boat with twenty empty places and watched.* And her children reading it, one day." She turned back to me. "Her husband went down with that ship, Bertie. Did you know? She kissed him at the rail, and he put her into the boat, and he stood back. She has nothing now. Not a husband. Not a house. Two children, and a governess who isn't paid. Your Mr. Hatch's justice would take what's left."

"He wasn't my Mr. Hatch."

"No," she said. "But you've made him yours. I saw it on the landing. You'd made him yours long before."

I didn't answer that.

"And you," I said. "You're in the pages too."

"Yes." She didn't look away. "I'm the one who said not to go back. I know. I said it, and I'd say it again tomorrow, and I would say it at any inquiry they liked. I don't mind that being known. I mind her."

"A man's dead, miss," I said. "A man who did nothing but write it down."

"Yes. And a steward is dead who did nothing but swim," she said. "And fifteen hundred others who did nothing at all. And not one of them will come back, whatever is done to Mr. Ainsley." She leaned forward a little. "I'm not defending him. Don't think that. I watched him stand up in that boat. I watched him at the service, afterward, singing the hymn. I know exactly what he is. I knew what he'd done on those stairs before I'd got to the bottom of them. But there's no way to hang him for it that doesn't go through her."

"So he walks down the gangway."

"Yes."

"And he does it again. Men like that do. Somewhere. To somebody."

"Perhaps," she said. "And then someone will stop him then. Someone who can." She looked at me, a long, level look, with her gray eyes too far apart. "You and I are a bell boy and a governess, on a ship full of grief, with eleven hours to New York. Neither of us can stop anybody. We can only decide who gets hurt next."



I've thought about what she said, since. Every word of it. I've had a long time to.

She was right about the inquiry. There was one, in New York, the next day, in the Waldorf-Astoria, with senators, and they called the survivors and asked them about their boats, and the newspapers printed every word. She was right about that, and about the mother, and about what it would have cost.

And she was wrong. A man killed another man on a staircase for writing down the truth, and walked away. I've never been able to make that right, whatever the arithmetic.

Both of those are true. I told Freda that, this morning. Nobody likes it. I didn't like it then.

"What do you want from me, miss?" I said.

"The pages," she said simply. "Give them to me."

"No, miss."

She smiled. It was the first time I'd seen her smile. It was small, and quick, and a little sad, and it reached her eyes, and for a moment she looked about twenty.

"No," she said. "I didn't think you would." She stood up. "Thank you for the milk, Bertie. And for the blanket, on Monday. You can go."

I went.



I went down four decks to the bell boys' cabin, faster than I should have, because something in the way she had smiled had got under my collar and was

sitting there.

Stan was there. He was sitting on his bunk, in the middle of the morning, when he should have been on B deck, and he had a shilling. He was turning it over and over in his fingers, and when he saw me in the door he put it in his pocket very quickly and stood up.

“Bertie,” he said. “Where’ve you been?”

I didn’t answer. I went to my locker. The door was shut. I opened it.

My spare jacket was where I had left it. The typewriter case was where I had left it, behind the jacket, latched.

I unlatched it and opened the lid.

The pages were gone.

I turned round. Stan was standing by his bunk with his hands in his pockets, and his face had gone red from the neck up.

“A lady came,” he said. “Down the companionway. They’re not supposed to, but she did. She was nice. She said you’d taken a toy of the little girl’s to mend, a wooden horse, and the little girl was crying for it, and she couldn’t wait, and would I mind.” He swallowed. “She gave me a shilling, Bertie. A whole shilling. I opened your locker and she looked in the case and there wasn’t any horse, and she said she must have been mistaken and you must have it somewhere else, and she was sorry to trouble me, and went.” He looked at me. “I didn’t see her take anything. Honest.”

“No,” I said. “You wouldn’t have.”

“Was it a horse? Did you have the kid’s horse?”

“No, Stan.”

“Oh,” said Stan. And then, after a moment, unhappily: “D’you want half the shilling?”



He stopped. He put the pencil down on the notepad.

Freda, on the stairs, had her hand over her mouth.

“She kept you talking,” she said, through her fingers. “On purpose. The whole time.”

“Twenty minutes,” he said. “About right and wrong, and a mother asleep in a berth, and what the two of us could and couldn’t do. And I enjoyed every minute of it. God help me. It was the first real conversation I’d had in three weeks, and she’d known I would enjoy it, and she’d known that while I was enjoying it I wouldn’t be thinking about my locker.” He shook his head slowly. “She asked for the pages so I’d say no. So I’d feel I’d won. She never expected me to give them to her. She’d already sent somebody else to get them.”

“That’s so...” Freda took her hand away from her mouth. “That’s so good, though. That’s evil. But it’s so good.”

“Yes,” said Tom. He was smiling, a little, at the window. It was not a happy smile, quite, but it was not an unhappy one either. “That’s exactly what I thought, at the time. Standing in that cabin, looking at an empty case. I thought, that’s evil, and it’s so good.”

“Did you hate her?”

He considered that, seriously, as he considered everything Freda asked him.

“No,” he said at last. “I think that was the trouble.”

Fourteen Photographs

The records office was in the basement of a building downtown that I had walked past a thousand times, back when I worked six blocks away, and never once gone into.

There was a counter with a scratched plastic window, and a ticket machine, and eleven chairs bolted together in a row, and a television on the wall showing a cooking show with the sound off. I took a ticket. I was number forty-one. They were serving number thirty-three. I sat in one of the bolted chairs with my bag on my knees and watched a man on the television fold egg whites into something, very slowly, for twenty minutes.

When they called forty-one, a woman behind the plastic took my license and my letter and looked at both for a long time, and went away, and came back with a manila envelope, the big kind, sealed with tape. She slid a form under the window for me to sign. I signed it. She slid the envelope after it.

"Fourteen photographs," she said, "and two pages of notes. Some material withheld under the exemptions on the attached sheet. You can appeal within thirty days."

"Thank you."

"You're the third person this year," she said, "who's come in for a file this old." She was already looking past me, at forty-two. "Most people don't bother. Most people just let it go."



I didn't open it there. I didn't open it in the elevator, or on the sidewalk, or in the car. I drove to a coffee place I used to go to, on the corner across from where the paper's building had been, which was a bank now, and I bought a coffee I didn't want, and sat at a table in the back by the window, and opened the envelope.

The notes first. Two pages, typed, in the flat language of a man who had a great many of these to do that week. I had read the two-page report so many times I could have recited it. These were the notes behind it, the officer's own, and they weren't much longer, and they weren't much better. *Landlord states tenant not seen since Wed approx. Tenant owes 2 wks rent. Movers booked Sat. Cat in BR, landlord removed.* Then, near the bottom of the second page, a line I had never seen.

Neighbor 2F (Dunleavy) called station x2 re: noise Wed a.m. Msg passed to R/O. Not interviewed. See landlord stmt.

I sat and looked at that line for a long time.

Not interviewed. She had called them twice. They had passed it on. And the responding officer, whose name was on the top of both pages, had read the message and written it down, very neatly, and gone to talk to the landlord about the carpet.

I thought of Mrs. Dunleavy in her wheelchair by the window, with her hands folded on the crocheted blanket. *Nobody ever calls me back.*

Then I opened the photographs.



They were color prints, glossy, four by six, each one with a number written on the back in marker and a date stamp in the corner. Fourteen of them. I laid them out on the table in order, in two rows of seven, and moved my coffee to the windowsill so I wouldn't spill it on them, and looked.

The first three were the building. The front, with the dry cleaner's sign and the steam coming out of a vent at the side. The front door. And the stairs, from the bottom, looking up. A narrow staircase with a wooden rail, and the walls painted a pale clean cream, fresh, glossy, the kind of paint that shows everything.

I picked up the third one and held it closer.

All the way up the left-hand wall of the staircase, at about the height of a man's waist, there was a line of marks. Scuffs, and dents, and in two places small gouges where the cream paint had come away and the old green showed through underneath. Every few steps. All the way up, as far as the photograph went.

Something banging the wall all the way down. New paint!!

I put it down very carefully, as if it might break.

Four through eight were the living room. It was smaller than I remembered, and more ordinary. A brown couch with a blanket folded on the arm. A rug. A small television on a stand. A bookshelf, full, the books shelved by size. And the wall over the couch, with the photographs on it.

There were seven. I counted. Seven frames in a careful arrangement, the kind a person measures and marks in pencil before they put in a single nail. An older woman in a sun hat, laughing, in a garden. That would be his mother. A young man in a cap and gown with the same woman beside him, not laughing, very proud. A lake with a dock. A dog. A church. A group of people at a long table, a wedding or a birthday, too small to see faces.

And one more, at the end. Larger than the others, in a better frame.

I picked up photograph number seven and held it right up to my face, there at the table in the back of the coffee place, and I didn't care who saw.

It was him. My source. Bookbinder. In a dark suit that didn't fit him, standing in front of a pair of tall brass doors I would have known anywhere in the world, under a banner I could almost read: *CARROW HOUSE*, and something else, smaller, *SPRING SALE*, and a year. He was smiling. Shyly, as he used to smile at me across the diner table when he'd brought me something good and didn't want to seem proud of it.

And beside him, with one arm around his shoulders, was another man.

Older. Sixty, perhaps, or a fit seventy. Tall, heavy-shouldered, with a fine head of white hair swept back, and a bow tie, and a beautifully cut gray suit. He had his head thrown back. He was laughing. Not smiling. Laughing, with his whole body, his mouth wide open, as if somebody just out of the frame had said the funniest thing he had ever heard. And his arm was around my source's

shoulders, hard, the way a proud father holds a son at a graduation. The way you hold someone who belongs to you.

I didn't know him. I sat with the photograph in my hand and went through every face I could remember from eight months of Carrow House, every name in every document, every lawyer, every executive in every annual report, and I didn't know him.

But I knew the laugh. I had never heard it. I knew it anyway, from a furious little line in a composition book.

A big one. Too big. The kind of laugh a man has when he's used to people laughing with him.



The rest I went through quickly, because I couldn't help it, and then slowly, because I made myself.

Nine was the desk. A plain wooden desk under the window, with a lamp and a mug of pens. And on the desk, in the middle, a big pale rectangle in the dust, perfectly clean, with a power strip on the floor beneath it and three cables hanging down off the back of the desk into nothing. You could see exactly where the computer had been, and the scanner beside it. The officer had stood in front of that and written, *No computer observed*.

Ten was the closet by the door, opened. Coats on hooks. Shoes on the floor. And at the back of the floor, two more rectangles in the dust, side by side, the size and shape of banker's boxes.

Eleven and twelve were the bedroom. A bed, unmade. A window. A water bowl on the floor by the door, empty, and a litter box in the corner, and the door itself, from inside, with long pale scratches down the paint at the bottom where something with claws had tried for two days to get out.

Thirteen was the kitchen. Dishes in the sink. A cereal box on the counter. A mug, by the kettle, with a teabag in it, ready, as if he'd put it out to have when he got back.

Fourteen was the bookshelf again, closer. I don't know why the officer took it. Perhaps he thought he ought to take one more. On the middle shelf, between two books, there was a small gray stuffed mouse with one ear chewed off.

I put them all back in the envelope, in order, and closed it, and sat with both hands flat on top of it, and looked out of the window at the bank where the paper used to be, until the coffee was cold.



I called Freda from the car. It was ten past four. She would be home by now.

It went to voicemail. I texted. *On my way. Want anything from the store?*

The answer came a minute later. *at maddies, back by 7. no thx*

I sat in the car with the engine off and the envelope on the passenger seat, and I looked at the text, and I thought about how long it had been since I'd seen Maddie's mother. Not since the lab. Not since she called me in the winter, very quiet, to apologize for something she couldn't name. I had meant to call her back. I never had. And Maddie's house was on the way home, almost. And I had a car, and a free hour, and a daughter at someone else's kitchen table eating someone else's food.

I called Maddie's mother.

She answered on the second ring, and she sounded surprised, and then pleased, and then, when I said I was nearby and thought I'd pick Freda up and save her the bus, she didn't say anything at all for a moment.

"Freda?" she said.

"Yes. She's there, isn't she? With Maddie?"

"Iola." Her voice had gone careful. "Maddie's at her dad's this week. In Baltimore. She's been there since Saturday." A pause. "And Freda hasn't been over here since... well. Not since the lab. Not once. I thought you knew. I thought, after everything, you'd rather she didn't."

I said something. I don't know what. I said thank you, I think, and that I must have got the day wrong, and that we should have coffee, and she said yes, we should, in the voice people use when they know they never will.

I hung up.

I sat in my car in the parking garage under the building where my career had ended, with fourteen photographs of a man who had gone out one morning and never come back on the seat beside me, and my daughter's text on the screen in my hand.

at maddies, back by 7.

And under it, in my memory, as clear as if I were reading it off the page:
Maddie's sister was getting rid of them. And Maddie's sister drives that way.

Maddie didn't have a sister. Maddie had two older brothers, and no sister at all. I had known that for eleven years. I had even made a little joke, in my own head, in the car on the way to Frederick, about how generous Maddie's sister had become. I had known it the whole time.

I had just never checked.

Pages in the Wake

• RECORDING · APRIL 18, 1912, AFTERNOON

I made one try. I want you to know that. Just one.

At two o'clock I went to find the officer who had stood at the top of the after companionway with a lantern and written *Death accidental* in his book. He was on the boat deck, by the bridge ladder, with his hands behind his back, looking at the fog, which had begun to thin. You could see the rail now, and the boats, and a little gray water beyond them.

I stood in front of him with my cap in my hands.

"Please, sir," I said. "Can I ask you something? About last night."

He looked down at me. I don't think he remembered me at all.

"What is it?"

"If a gentleman slipped at the top of those stairs, sir, and went down them," I said, "and you found a mark on the steps where his heel had gone. Would the mark be going up, sir, or down?"

He stared at me.

"Down, I should think," he said. "If he was going down." He frowned. "What sort of question is that?"

"Only, sir, I thought I saw one going up. On the fifth step. Before the lady slipped on it."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then something happened in his face that I had seen happen in a great many faces, in a great many lives, when a person of no account says something that would be a great deal of trouble if it were true. He decided it wasn't.

"You thought you saw," he said. "In the fog. At one in the morning. Where you had no business being." He bent down a little, so his face was level with mine. "Listen to me, boy. A man fell down a flight of stairs in the fog, and the doctor's seen him, and it's written in the log, and there's an end of it. We've got seven hundred people on this ship who've lost everything, and a captain who hasn't slept since Sunday, and we'll be in New York tonight with half the world waiting on the pier. The last thing anybody needs is a bell boy with an imagination." He straightened up. "Now cut along before I tell Mr. Lyle where you were last night."

I cut along.

That was my one try. I had known before I made it how it would end. I had known it on the floor of the bell boys' cabin at four in the morning. But I had to make it, Ms. Barnett. You understand. If I hadn't, I'd have had to wonder.



The fog lifted at about three.

It went quite suddenly, as fog does at sea, as if someone had pulled a sheet off a table. One minute the ship was wrapped in white, and the whistle going, and the next the white was tearing apart into rags and drifting off over the water, and there was a pale sun, low in the west, and blue sky in pieces, and a long, slow, gray-green swell. The whistle stopped. The engines came up. You could feel her lift and begin to move again.

People came out on deck. Survivors, and our own passengers, to stand in the sun. Nobody said much. They stood along the rails and looked west, where New York was, still below the edge of the world.

I went aft, because I was sent with a rug for a lady by the after rail, and on my way back I saw her.

She was at the very stern, alone. Right at the back of the ship, by the flagstaff, where the rail curved round and nobody went, because there was nothing to see there but the wake. She was in her dark coat again, with her hair up. Her back was to me.

She had something in her hands. White. Paper.

As I watched, she took one sheet from the top and held it out over the rail, at arm's length, and opened her fingers.

The wind took it. It went up, first, a little, turning over in the sun, white and then white again, like a bird that has been startled off a fence. Then it came down into the wake behind the ship, into the long churned road of green and white water the screws were making, and lay flat on it for a second, and was rolled under.

She took another sheet and did the same.

I stood by the deckhouse with the rug over my arm and watched her do it. Five times. I counted. I knew how many there were. Five pages, typed with two fingers in the second-class library on a Wednesday afternoon by a man in a brown suit, going up into the sun, one after another, and turning over, and falling into the wake, and lying there, white, and gone.

She didn't hurry. She did each one separately, carefully, the way you'd lay flowers on a grave one at a time.

When the last one had gone, she stood with her hands on the rail for a moment, looking down at the water where it had gone under.

Then she turned around, and saw me.



She didn't seem surprised. I think she had known I was there for some time.

She came along the rail toward me, unhurried, with her hands in the pockets of her coat, and stopped a little way off. The sun was behind her. I couldn't see her face well.

"Bertie," she said.

"Miss."

"I owe Stan another shilling," she said. "I think I underpaid him. He looked very unhappy about it when I left."

I didn't answer.

"The notebook's gone too," she said. "If you were wondering. In case you thought you might still find it. Mr. Ainsley went down to the stokehold at six this morning, before anyone was about, with a cigar he didn't light, and came up again without the notebook. I was on the stair." She looked past me, at

the funnel, where the smoke was going up. "There's nothing left. Not a page. Not anywhere."

"There's me," I said.

She looked at me then. A long look. I couldn't see her eyes, with the sun behind her, but I felt it.

"Yes," she said. "There's you."

"I saw the step. I saw his shoe. I saw his jaw at breakfast."

"Yes. And so did I. And neither of us will ever say so to anyone who matters, because no one who matters will ever listen to a bell boy and a governess against a gentleman with a bruise from slipping in the fog." She said it quite gently. "You know that. You've known it since four o'clock this morning. You went and asked that officer anyway, at two, by the bridge ladder. I saw you." She was quiet a moment. "That was brave. It was also quite useless. I'm sorry."

"You're not sorry."

"No," she agreed. "I'm not sorry I did it. I'm sorry it had to be done. That isn't the same thing." She took one hand out of her pocket and pushed a strand of hair off her face. "I don't expect you to forgive me, Bertie. I'm not sure I would, in your place."

I didn't say anything for a while. The wake ran away behind us, white and green, very straight, all the way back toward the east, toward the ice, and the place where the boats had been.

"Why did you hum it?" I said. "That song. To the little girl. On Tuesday night."

I don't know why I asked. It wasn't what I'd meant to say. It came out of me before I could stop it.

She went very still. For the first time since I had known her, I saw her not know what to say.

"It's an old song," she said at last.

"Yes, miss."

"My father..."

"Found it in a book," I said. "Yes, miss. You told her."

She looked at me for a long time. The wind moved her coat. Down below us, in the wake, there was nothing at all.

"How old are you, Bertie?" she said.

"Twelve, miss."

"No," she said quietly. "You're not."

And she turned, and walked away along the rail toward the door, and went in, and didn't look back.



He stopped. He put the pencil down.

Nobody said anything. Freda was sitting on the stairs with her arms tight around her knees, perfectly still.

"What did she mean?" said Freda. "You're not."

"I don't know," he said. "I've never known." He looked at the window. "Perhaps she meant that I didn't talk like a boy of twelve. I didn't, by then. I'd stopped trying, with her. Perhaps she meant only that."

"But you don't think so."

He didn't answer that.

"It was a long time ago, Freda," he said instead. "And there's still the rest of Thursday. The worst of it." He picked the pencil up again, and looked at it, and put it down. "I think I'd like a cup of tea first. If nobody minds."

Freda got up off the stairs and said she'd make it. He started to protest, and she said, "Sit," in exactly my voice, and went into the kitchen. He sat.

He looked at me across the little table, with the recorders running between us.

"She's a good girl," he said quietly.

"I know."

"No," he said. "I mean, she's a good girl, Ms. Barnett." He held my eyes a moment longer than he needed to. Then he looked at the notepad on his knee, and said nothing else until the tea came.



They came for me at five.

I was in the pantry with Evans, drying cups, because there was nothing else for me to do and I couldn't sit still. Lyle came in. He had the purser behind him, and behind the purser, in the doorway, in his good gray suit and his shined shoes, Mr. Ainsley.

"Pike," said Lyle. "Where's the writer's case?"

I put the cup down.

It had been very simple, as the worst things often are. At four the purser had finally found time to see to the dead man's effects. He had sent a steward to the library. The steward had found a pen on the table and nothing else. The purser had said that was odd, a writer with no papers, and Mr. Ainsley, who happened to be passing the purser's office, had very kindly mentioned that the poor fellow had a typewriter, and a notebook, a fat one, which he carried everywhere and which, Mr. Ainsley understood, he had been hoping to sell to the New York newspapers. Things like that were worth a great deal of money this week, Mr. Ainsley said. It might be worth asking who had been in the library.

And a lady sleeping in the library had seen a bell boy carry a case out of it at seven that morning. A small one, with a mended handle.

"In my locker, sir," I said.

They went and got it. Lyle carried it back up to the pantry himself and put it on the counter and opened it in front of all of us. A typewriter, and a ribbon tin, and a letter to a sister in Ohio, half finished, and nothing in the lid.

"And the notebook?" said the purser.

"I never had the notebook, sir."

"Then where is it?"

I looked past him at Mr. Ainsley in the doorway. He was looking back at me with an expression of great kindness and a little sorrow, like a man looking at a boy who has disappointed him.

"I don't know, sir," I said.

"Took the case and not the notebook," said Lyle. "That's a likely story. And what were you going to do with a typewriter, Pike? Write your memoirs?" He turned to the purser. "He's been out of his bunk every night this week, sir. I've had complaints. And there's papers on this ship offering a year's wages for any scrap of a survivor's story."

"I was keeping it safe," I said. "For his family. He had a sister."

It was the truth. Nobody in that pantry believed it, and I don't blame them. I wouldn't have.

The purser looked at me for a long moment. He was a fair man, I think. He was also a tired one.

"He'll be put ashore in New York," he said to Lyle. "Discharged. No character." He closed the case. "The company can decide about the notebook. I haven't time."

"Go easy on the boy, Purser," said Mr. Ainsley, from the doorway. His voice was warm. "It's been a hard week for everyone. Boys get ideas, at times like these." He smiled at me. "I'm sure he meant no harm."

And he turned and went away down the corridor, and I listened to his heels go, click, click, click, all the way to the end, until a door shut.

At six o'clock we passed the Sandy Hook lightship, and the passengers lined the rails to see the lights of America, and I was in the bell boys' cabin on E deck, with my things in a canvas bag on my bunk, and Stan sitting on the bunk above with his half of a shilling, not saying anything at all.

Petworth

I had her location on my phone. Every mother I knew did. We had set it up when she got the phone, at twelve, both of us, mine on hers and hers on mine, as you buy a fire extinguisher. In four years I had looked at it twice, both times when she was late from a school trip and the bus had broken down on the highway.

I looked at it now, in the parking garage, with the engine off.

It took a moment to load. A map of the city, gray and green, and a small round picture of my daughter's face, the one from her school ID, with the bad bangs she had cut herself in the ninth grade. It was not in the west part of town, where Maddie lived. It was not anywhere near school, or the library, or the coffee place by the metro where she sometimes sat with her friends.

It was up off Georgia Avenue. In Petworth. On a short street of rowhouses two blocks east of the avenue, between a church and a laundromat.

Go up Georgia. Cut across at Missouri.

I started the car.



It took twenty-five minutes, in the traffic. I didn't turn the radio on. I drove up Sixteenth and across and up Georgia, past the hardware store and the Ethiopian place and the new apartment buildings going up where the old ones had been, with the envelope of photographs still on the passenger seat, and the whole way I told myself I was going to be calm. That there would be a reason. A friend I didn't know. A tutor. A boy.

I knew. I think I had known since the parking garage. I think I had known since the headphones, if I was honest, and I'm honest on paper, and I was trying very hard not to think on paper.

The street was quiet, with trees just coming into leaf and cars parked tight along both curbs. The rowhouses were brick, two stories, with little iron fences and porches, some painted and some not. The dot on my phone was on the fourth one from the corner on the left. A house with a green door and a porch with two plastic chairs on it.

Freda was sitting in one of them.

She had her feet up on the porch rail, and her headphones around her neck, and a can of soda in her hand. She was laughing. The real laugh. I could see it from the car before I could hear it.

The man in the other chair was tall. Too tall for the chair. He sat with his long legs folded up and his elbows on his knees, as he always used to sit, as if the furniture of the world had been made for somebody smaller and he had stopped complaining about it. He was thinner than I remembered. There was gray at his temples now, and he had a short beard, gray at the chin, that he hadn't had. He was wearing a canvas work jacket with the name of the hardware store on Georgia Avenue stitched over the pocket.

He was listening to her. He wasn't talking. He was just listening, with his head a little on one side, the way you listen to somebody when you've been waiting a long time to be allowed to.

I had not seen Desmond Barnett in nine years.



I pulled into a space across the street, between a pickup and a minivan, and turned off the engine, and sat there.

I could have driven away. I want to be honest about that. For about a minute, I could have. I could have gone home and made dinner and waited until seven and let her come in and say *hi*, *I was at Maddie's*, and said *how's Maddie*, and kept it, as I had kept so many things, until I knew exactly what I wanted to do with it.

Then Freda turned her head, laughing at something, and looked across the street, and saw my car.

I watched it go out of her. All of it. The laugh, and the color, and the ease, gone out of her face in one second, like water out of a sink. She took her feet off the rail. She put the can down on the porch floor. She didn't get up.

Desmond saw her face, and turned, and followed her eyes, and saw me through the windshield.

He stood up.



I got out of the car. I crossed the street. I didn't hurry. I stopped at the bottom of the porch steps, on the sidewalk, outside the little iron gate, and didn't open it.

"Tola," he said.

"Get in the car, Freda."

"Mom..."

"Get in the car."

"Tola, please. This isn't her fault. I asked her..."

"I know you did," I said. I didn't look at him. I looked at my daughter. "I'm not talking to you, Desmond. I'm talking to my daughter. Freda. Get your things and get in the car."

Freda looked at him. She looked at me. She picked up her bag from beside the chair, very slowly, and put her headphones in it. The white ones.

"Those are nice," I said. "Maddie's sister has very good taste."

She went past me through the gate without looking at me, and across the street, and got into the passenger seat, and shut the door, and sat there looking straight ahead through the windshield.

Desmond came down one step. He stopped there, when I looked at him.

"She found me," he said quietly. "In September. I want you to know that. I didn't..."

"I don't want to know anything," I said. "Not today. Not standing on your sidewalk." I heard my own voice. It was perfectly level. I sounded, I thought,

like somebody's lawyer. "If you want to talk to me, Desmond, you can call me. You've had my number for nine years."

I turned around and walked back across the street.



Neither of us said anything for the first ten minutes. I drove down Georgia in the evening traffic with the photographs on the dashboard, where I'd moved them, and Freda in the passenger seat with her bag on her knees and her feet flat on the floor.

At a red light by the old theater she said, very quietly, to the window, "You'd have said no."

"You don't know that."

"Yes, I do." She turned around. Her face was red and wet and furious. "You'd have said no. You'd have said he was a drunk and he left and he sent a card in March and he'd do it again. You'd have said all of it. You'd have been *right*." She wiped her face with the heel of her hand. "And then I'd never have known him. Ever. Not even once."

"So you lied to me."

"Yes."

"For seven months."

"Since September," said Freda. "Yes."

September. Before the letter. Before Thursdays, and the old man, and 1865. I thought of a night in the fall, the electric bill in red on top of the pile, and Freda on the phone through the wall, laughing the low careful laugh she saved for friends, and the door in her that had stayed shut, and how I had told myself I would find out what was behind it.

The light changed. I drove.

"I check everything," I said. "Everything. It's the only thing I've ever been good at. I checked the lab. I checked the scale. I checked a dead man's cat and a dead man's movers and an old woman's notebooks. I checked the Library of Congress." I heard my voice crack, and stopped it. "And I never once checked you."

"I know," said Freda. "Because you trusted me." She was crying again, quietly, looking straight ahead. "I knew you did. And I used it. I know I did. I'm sorry. I'm not sorry I found him, but I'm sorry about that." She took a breath. "And it wasn't just me. Mr. Hale knew."

I nearly missed the turn.

"What?"

"At spring break. When you went out on the porch for the phone call." Freda wiped her nose on the back of her hand. "He knew. He didn't even do the thing. He just looked at me for like one minute, and I could tell he knew. So I told him. All of it." She swallowed. "He didn't tell me what to do. He just said I had to tell you. That it wasn't his to tell, but it was mine, and the longer I waited, the more it'd cost. Things you keep back don't get lighter, they get heavier, and somebody else ends up carrying them for you." Her voice wobbled. "He said it'd be me, carrying it. And then you, when you found out. And then him, a little, for knowing."

I thought of the kitchen window. Freda's elbows on the table, her hands around her mug, talking fast. Her hand coming up to her eye. A sentence from him, perhaps two. A small wet laugh.

I'm talking about a notebook.

And on the porch, holding my plate: *We were talking about Bertie. His sisters.*

And on Thursday, in the living room, with the recorders running between us, while Freda made the tea: *She's a good girl, Ms. Barnett.* And holding my eyes a moment longer than he needed to.

"He knew," I said. "For two weeks."

"Mom, he said it wasn't his to tell."

"I know what he said."

I drove the rest of the way home without saying anything else. When we got there, Freda went to her room and shut the door. It didn't slam. She shut it very quietly, which was worse.

I sat in the kitchen with the envelope of photographs in front of me, unopened again, and my phone face up beside it, and I didn't make dinner. At

nine o'clock the phone lit up with a number I didn't know, with a local exchange, and I watched it ring, and let it go.

At ten past nine it lit up again with a text, from the same number.

It's Dez. I'm sorry. I'll wait as long as you need. She's the best thing I ever had any part of, and I know whose doing that was. D.

D.

I turned the phone face down on the table, the way my daughter did, and sat there in the kitchen until the light under her door went out.

You Knew

I didn't wear the coat.

It was hanging on the back of the kitchen chair where it had hung every Thursday since March, and I walked past it on the way out of the door and took my old rain jacket off the hook instead, the thin blue one with the broken zipper, and I knew exactly what I was doing and did it anyway.

Freda had left for school without breakfast. We had said perhaps forty words to each other since Monday, most of them about whether there was milk. She had typed nothing. Last Thursday's tape, the governess and the pages in the wake, the one she had sat on the stairs for, was sitting untouched on her laptop. I had not asked her to do it. She had not offered.

It was a bright, hard, cold morning, the kind April throws in once to remind you it can. The fields past Frederick were green now, properly green, and the trees along the road had leaves you could see from a distance. I didn't look at any of it. I drove with both hands on the wheel and the radio off and went over, the whole way, what I was going to say.

I had it word for word by the state line. I had been a reporter. I knew how to go into a room.



He was at the window. He was always at the window.

He came out onto the porch as I pulled up, and stopped at the top of the steps instead of coming down, and I saw him look at my face through the wind-

shield, and then at the blue jacket, and I saw him understand both. He stood very still with one hand on the rail.

I got out of the car and shut the door and stood at the bottom of the steps.

"You knew," I said.

It wasn't what I had planned to say. I had planned something much longer.

"Yes," he said.

"For two weeks."

"Yes."

"She told you. At your kitchen table. While I was on the porch. And you sat there, and I came in, and you looked me in the eye and told me you were talking about Bertie's *sisters*."

"Yes."

"And last Thursday. *She's a good girl, Ms. Barnett.*" I heard my voice rising and let it. "You sat there with the recorders going and said that to my face, and you folded a dish towel, the week before, when I told you she knew her way round Georgia Avenue. You folded a dish towel. I watched you do it. You knew then, too, didn't you? Before she ever told you. You knew in March."

He didn't answer that at once.

"I thought it," he said. "In March. I didn't know."

"But you thought it."

"Yes."

"And you didn't say one word."

"No," he said. "It wasn't mine to say."



We had it out in the kitchen. I don't remember going in. I remember standing by the counter with my bag still on my shoulder, and him by the stove, with the kettle on behind him because he had put it on before I came, as he always did, and neither of us touching it.

"I'm her mother," I said.

"Yes."

"She's sixteen. She was lying to me. Every week. For seven months. Getting on buses to the other side of the city to sit on a porch with a man who walked

out on her when she was seven and sent her a birthday card two months late the year her mother lost everything. And you knew, and you let her.”

“I didn’t let her do anything, Ms. Barnett. She’d been doing it since September.”

“You let her go on.”

“I told her to tell you.”

“You should have told me *yourself*.”

He was quiet for a moment.

“If I had,” he said, “you’d have found out from me. Not from her. And she’d have known I told you. She’d have sat at my kitchen table and told me the thing she couldn’t tell anyone, and watched me pick up the telephone. And she’d never have told anyone anything again, Ms. Barnett. Not you. Not me. Not anyone, for a very long time.” He didn’t raise his voice. “It was hers. It wasn’t your story, and it wasn’t mine. It was hers. The only thing I could do with it was give it back to her and ask her to carry it to you before it got too heavy.”

“And if she hadn’t?”

“Then I’d have had to decide,” he said. “And I’d have been wrong, whichever I chose. I’ve had a great deal of practice at that.”

“You decided anyway. You decided something about my daughter without asking me.” I put my bag down on the counter, hard. “You don’t get to do that. You don’t get to know things about her that I don’t. You’ve known her for one morning.”

“Yes.”

“You’re a man who pretends to be other people for a living.”

I heard it go across the kitchen and land on him. I saw it land. His face didn’t change, very much. Something behind it did.

He didn’t say anything. He turned around and took the kettle off the stove, because it had started to whistle, and stood holding it for a moment, as if he had forgotten what it was for.

I didn’t take it back. I want to be honest about that. I stood there and didn’t take it back, and I was glad, for about a minute, that I’d said it.



“How is she?” he said at last, quietly, with his back to me.

“You don’t get to ask that.”

He set the kettle down.

“No,” he said. “I suppose I don’t.”

He made the tea anyway. He made it as he always did, the pot warmed first, the cover on, the two cups, and he carried the tray through to the living room and put it down on the little table, and sat down in his chair, and picked up the notepad. I followed him in, because I didn’t know what else to do, and because I was being paid three thousand dollars, and because I could not bear to drive away.

I set out the recorders. I pressed the buttons. I said the date into them, and the time, and *Session twenty-six*, and nothing else.

I didn’t ask him how his week had been. He didn’t ask about mine.

“Thursday night,” I said. “Pier 54. You stopped on the ship coming into the harbor. Tell me about the pier.”

He looked at me for a moment across the little table. He looked older, I thought, than he had looked a week ago. Older than he had looked all winter. There was a gray in his face under the weathering that I had not seen before, and his hands, on the notepad, were very still.

I noticed it. I didn’t care, that morning. I’m telling you that because it’s true.

“The pier,” he said.

He looked down at the notepad, and didn’t draw. He didn’t draw for the whole of that session. It was the only time, in all the Thursdays, that he didn’t. Freda told me that, later, when she typed it. She said the tape was the quietest one she had ever heard. No pencil. No humming. Only his voice, and the woodstove, and sometimes a long time when there was nothing at all.

“It was raining,” he said. “In New York. That’s the first thing.”

Pier 54

• RECORDING · APRIL 18, 1912, NIGHT

It was raining in New York. A cold, hard, driving rain, coming in off the harbor sideways, the kind that finds the gap between your collar and your neck however you stand.

I wasn't supposed to be on deck. A boy who has been discharged is nobody's business, and nobody's bell boy, and Lyle had told me to stay in the cabin with my bag and keep out from under people's feet until I was sent for in the morning. I stayed there until we passed the lightship. Then I went up. Nobody stopped me. Everybody on that ship who could stand was at a rail.

We came in through the Narrows in the dark, very slowly. And the harbor was full of boats.

Tugs, mostly. Dozens of them. Little steam tugs and launches and ferries, crowded right up against our sides, with their lamps lit and their whistles going, and every one of them packed with men in coats and hats, standing on the decks and the cabin roofs in the rain, shouting. Newspapermen. Every paper in New York had hired something that floated. They had megaphones, and they were shouting up at our rails through them, at anybody, at the passengers, at the crew, at the faces looking down.

Were you on the Titanic? Is Astor alive? Did you see her go down? Fifty dollars for your story! A hundred! Jump down to us! We'll take you off!

And in among the shouting there were flashes. White, sudden, blinding. Photographers on the tugs with flash powder, firing up at us in the rain, so

that every few seconds the whole side of the ship and every face along the rail jumped out of the dark, white and staring, and then fell back into it.

The captain wouldn't let one of them aboard. Not one. He had said so on the wireless, all day, and he meant it. The tugs came alongside, and the men on them shouted and waved money and tried to throw lines up, and our seamen stood at the rails and threw the lines back. We went on up the river through all of it, very slowly, with the tugs following us like gulls after a trawler.

I thought of Mr. Hatch. I couldn't help it. *In New York they'll all have a story.* There they were. Every newspaper in the world, in the rain, shouting for exactly what he'd had in his notebook. And he was lying under a sheet in a cabin on C deck, and his notebook was ash in the stokehold, and his five pages were at the bottom of the Atlantic, and nobody on any of those tugs would ever know his name.



We didn't go to our own pier first. We went past it, up the river, to the White Star pier, where the Titanic should have come in on Wednesday morning.

And there, in the rain, under the lights, with ten thousand people watching from the pier and the street behind it in silence, they lowered the Titanic's boats.

They'd been hanging on our davits and stowed on our decks since Monday morning, all the ones we had been able to take aboard. Now our seamen swung them out, one after another, and lowered them down into the black water, empty. And men from the pier rowed them away, one after another, into the dark under the White Star shed, and they were gone.

The survivors watched from the rails. Nobody said anything. It was the quietest I ever heard that ship, in all the time I was aboard her. Fourteen hundred people at the rails, and the rain, and the creak of the falls, and the oars.

I was standing by the after deckhouse. A little way along the rail from me, I saw the young woman in the dark coat. She had the little boy on her hip, asleep, under her coat, out of the rain. She was watching the boats go down.

She watched one boat more carefully than the others. I saw her. As it went down past us on its falls, and touched the water, and swung there empty, and the man from the pier took up the oars and began to pull it away into the dark, she watched it all the way, until it went under the shed, and was gone.

I knew which boat. So did she. I won't tell you the number, Ms. Barnett. I said I wouldn't.

She didn't look at me.



Then we went back down the river to Pier 54, the Cunard pier, our own, and the gangway went down, and they began to go ashore.

You have seen the pictures, perhaps. Everybody has. They don't show it. The pier was a great long shed, lit up inside like a railway station, and it was packed, wall to wall, with people. Thirty thousand, the papers said the next day, or forty, in the shed and outside it and all along the street, in the rain. Families. Friends. Reporters. Doctors, and nurses, and ambulances backed up to the street door, and priests, and the police holding the crowds back with ropes. And the silence. When the first of them came down the gangway, the noise in that shed just stopped, all of it, and thirty thousand people stood under the lights in the rain and didn't make a sound.

Then somebody saw somebody, and screamed a name, and it broke, and after that it was all noise.

First class came off first. That was how it was done.

And among the first of them, in his good gray suit and his good gray hat and his shined black shoes, with his wrapped hand in his pocket and the bruise on his jaw gone yellow at the edges, was Mr. Ainsley.

He came down the gangway into the light, and the flashes went off all around him, white, white, white, and from the crowd behind the ropes a woman cried out his name, and he turned, and lifted his good hand, and smiled. A woman in furs came through the ropes, with two girls behind her, young ladies, his daughters, and the police let them through, because of who he was, and they ran to him and he held them, all three, there at the bottom

of the gangway, under the lights, with the rain coming in under the roof of the shed. He held them a long time. I watched him do it. He held them well. He was a man who knew how to do that sort of thing so that people saw it, and he did it, and they saw it.

Then the reporters had him. They pushed in through the police with their notebooks, a dozen of them, shouting his name, and he let them. He stood with one arm round his wife and talked to them, in the flashes, in his warm, easy, carrying voice. I couldn't hear the words from the rail. I didn't need to. I read them the next morning, in four different papers.

How calm it had been. How orderly. How the men had stood back. How in his boat they had done everything they could, and kept up the ladies' spirits, and nobody had been turned away.

And at the end, one of the reporters said something, and he laughed. The big laugh. Right there at the bottom of the gangway, with his arm around his wife. And the reporters laughed with him.



He lived another thirty-one years.

I know because I read his obituary. He died in his own bed, in a big house, in 1943, with his daughters beside him. The obituary was half a column long, with a photograph. It listed his boards, and his clubs, and his charities, and his grandchildren. Near the end, it said that he had survived the sinking of the Titanic, and that in his lifeboat on that terrible night he had taken his turn at the tiller and kept up the courage of the women and children in his care.

I've read it a great many times, Ms. Barnett. I kept it. I've kept it in every life since. It's in a box upstairs.

Mr. Hatch's notice was three lines. I never looked for it. You found it for me.



They carried Mr. Hatch off at about eleven, after most of the living had gone. Two stewards, with a stretcher, under a sheet, down the crew gangway at the far end where the crowd had thinned. Nobody was waiting for him. There was a hearse from the company at the street door, and a man from the coroner's office with a clipboard who signed something, and that was all. His sister was in Ohio. She would hear by telegram, I supposed, in the morning, and not know who to ask about anything.

I stood at the rail and watched him go all the way to the street door. I don't think anybody else on that ship was watching.



She came down the gangway late. Most of second class had gone. She had the little boy on her hip still, asleep, and the girl by the hand, in her blanket coat, and the mother on the other side of her on the arm of a stewardess, walking very slowly, like an old woman, though she couldn't have been thirty-five. There was somebody waiting for them behind the ropes. An older couple, gray, the grandparents perhaps, who came forward with their arms out and their faces breaking. I saw the mother see them and stop on the gangway and put her hands over her face.

The young woman stopped too, a step behind, to let them have it.

And while she stood there, she turned her head and looked up. Along the side of the ship, along the rail, at all the faces still looking down. Quick and complete, as she always did. Until she found mine.

She looked at me for a long moment, up through the rain, from the gangway. I looked back.

Then she said something. I couldn't hear it. The shed was full of noise, and the rain was loud on the roof. I saw her lips move. I've thought about it since, for a very long time, and I've never been sure. I think it was a name. I think she was telling me her name.

Later, on the pier, on the Friday morning, when they put me ashore, a stewardess I didn't know came and found me where I was sitting on my bag by the street door, and gave me an envelope, and said a lady had left it with the purser for the bell boy Pike. There was nothing in it but two shillings,

wrapped in a half sheet of paper. On the paper, in a clear, quick, educated hand, it said, *For Stan, with apologies. E. P.*

Eleanor Penhallow. That's what I've called her ever since. That's what I said I'd tell you, when it mattered.

I looked for that name, afterward, for years. On every list. The Titanic's, and the Carpathia's, and the purser's, and the inquiry's, and the newspapers'. There was no Penhallow on any of them. She had given the purser a different name at the gangway on the Monday morning, and that one is on the lists, and I'm not going to tell you what it was.

I gave Stan his two shillings. He cried, a little. He gave me back one.



The last I saw of her, she was going away through the crowd toward the street door, with the little boy asleep on her shoulder and the girl holding her coat, behind the mother and the grandparents. The crowd closed round them. Just before it did, she turned her head, once, and looked back up at the ship. Not at me. At all of it.

I could see her lips moving. She wasn't speaking.

She was humming.

I couldn't hear it. I didn't need to. I knew what it was.

Neither of us waved.



He stopped.

He had not drawn once, all morning. The notepad was on his knee, and the pencil on the notepad, and his hands were folded on top of them both, quite still.

"That's the end of the Carpathia," he said.

I didn't say anything. I reached out and turned off the recorders.

"What happened to him?" I said. "To Bertie. After. A boy of twelve on a pier in New York, with no reference and a bag."

"He made the best of it," he said. "That's another Thursday."

I stood up. I picked up the recorders and put them in my bag. I didn't stay for lunch. He didn't offer it. He got up when I did, and went ahead of me to the door, and held it open, and stood on the porch in his cardigan in the cold bright noon while I went down the steps.

At the bottom I heard him say, "Ms. Barnett."

I stopped. I didn't turn around.

"Tell her..." he said, and stopped.

"No," I said.

I got into the car. When I backed it round in the gravel to go, he was still on the porch, with one hand on the rail, looking at me. I didn't wave.

In the mirror, at the end of the gravel road, he was still there.

The End of the Bed

Freda typed the pier on Sunday night.

I didn't ask her to. I had not asked her to do anything since Monday. On Saturday the laptop was still closed on the kitchen table where she'd left it, and on Sunday afternoon it was still closed, and I didn't touch it, and I didn't say anything. And at about eight o'clock on Sunday night I came into the kitchen for a glass of water and she was sitting there with the headphones on and the recorder file open on the screen, typing.

I got my water and went back to my room. I didn't say anything then, either.

I could hear her, through the wall, for a long time. Not the words. Only the keys, very fast, and then stopping, and then the little click of the trackpad when she went back to listen again. Then fast again. Then stopping. Then, for a while, nothing at all.

I was in bed with a book I wasn't reading when the door opened, a little before midnight.

She didn't knock. She hadn't knocked on my door since she was nine. She stood in the doorway in her pajamas and one of my old sweaters with her arms wrapped around herself, and her face was blotched, and she didn't come in.

"I finished it," she said.

"Okay."

"The pier." Her voice was thick. "The boy with the bag. Nobody came for him. Everybody else had somebody, behind the ropes, and he just sat on his bag by the door in the rain. Twelve. By himself. In New York."

"I know."

"And Mr. Ainsley had his whole family." She swallowed. "And everybody clapped."

"I know, honey."

She stood in the doorway a moment longer. Then she came in, and sat down on the end of my bed, at the very end, on top of the covers, with her back against the footboard and her knees drawn up, the way she used to sit when she was small and had a bad dream and didn't want to admit it was a bad dream.

"I'm going to tell you all of it," she said. "Okay? The parts you didn't find."



"It was me," she said. "First. Not him."

I didn't say anything.

"In September. Before the letter came. You were out, and I was looking for my birth certificate for the driving thing at school, and it was in your box in the closet, the one with all my stuff. The baby teeth and the drawings." She looked at her knees. "And the card was in there. The one from Phoenix. The one that came in March."

I had kept it. Of course I had. I keep everything.

"It had a return address," said Freda. "So I looked him up. That's all. I just looked him up, like you would. And he wasn't in Phoenix anymore. He was here. He'd been back in DC for like a year. He was on the website for the hardware store on Georgia, in one of those staff pictures, in the apron. *Dez, plumbing and electrical.*" She almost laughed. "He's really good at plumbing, apparently."

"He always was."

"So I called the store. And asked for him. And he came to the phone, and I said, *it's Freda*, and he didn't say anything for like ten seconds." She pulled the sleeves of the sweater down over her hands. "And then he hung up."

I sat up a little.

"He hung up on me, Mom. I was so mad. I sat on my bed and cried for an hour." She shook her head. "And then a week later he called back. From his own phone. And he said he was sorry, he'd panicked, he didn't think he had any

right to talk to me. He said he'd been sober two years and three months, and he'd started over, and he'd thought about calling me every day for two years, and every day he decided I was better off. And then I called him." She looked up at me. "And he said, *Okay. Then I guess I don't get to decide that anymore.*"

That was the phone call, in the fall. That was the low, careful laugh through the wall, the night the electric bill was red. That was the door in her that had stayed shut.

"And in October," said Freda, "the day he gave me his real number. I wrote it in the margin of my chem worksheet. Really carefully. Because I was scared I'd lose my phone and never find it again." She almost smiled. "You saw me do it. At the table. You looked right at me."

I had. I remembered it. She had read a text and her face had gone still and shut, and she had written something very carefully in the margin, and I had decided it was about Maddie, and the lab, and the kids who were being cruel to her. I had been right about the kids. I had been wrong about the margin.

"Why didn't you tell me," I said. "Then. In October. When you knew he was real."

"Because he asked me not to." She held up a hand before I could say anything. "Not like that. Not like *don't tell your mother*. He said..." She stopped, and got it right. "He said you'd been carrying everything by yourself for nine years. Me, and the house, and the money, and the story, and losing your job. All of it. He said he'd put most of it on you, by leaving. And he wasn't going to hand you one more thing to carry until he could carry his own. Until he had a real job that lasted, and his own place, and he'd been sober long enough that you'd believe it." She wiped her face with her sleeve. "He said when he could walk up to the door himself, he would. And I said okay. Because I wanted it. I wanted to have him for a while, by myself, before it got complicated."

"It was always going to be complicated."

"I know." She looked at her knees again. "I know that now."



"When I asked you," she said after a while, quietly. "In the kitchen. If people can tell when they've made a difference to somebody."

"I remember."

"He told me I did. Made a difference. To him." She pulled at a thread on the sweater. "He said when I called, he'd been thinking about drinking again. For the first time in like a year. Just that week. He'd had a bad week at work and he was standing outside a liquor store on Kennedy Street and he got the call from the store manager saying some girl named Freda had called asking for him." She laughed, a small wet sound. "He said he went back to work instead. And he hasn't been back to that store since."

I couldn't say anything for a moment.

"I didn't know if that was true," Freda said. "Or if he just said it. Like, to make me feel good. You can't check something like that."

"No," I said. "You can't."

"Mr. Hale said that's the worst kind. The kind you can't check." She looked at me. "He said that about the cocoa, too. Didn't he. That's the same thing. He never knew if he made a difference. And Dad says I did, and I'll never know either."

"Sometimes," I said, "you just have to decide whether to believe somebody."

Freda looked at me for a long time.

"You're doing that," she said. "With Mr. Hale. Aren't you. Every Thursday."

I didn't answer that. I didn't have to. She knew.



I told her about the money, then.

I hadn't planned to. It came out of me because she had told me everything, all of it, sitting on the end of my bed in my sweater at midnight, and I was sitting there with something I hadn't told her, and it had gotten heavy.

"The client," I said. "In November. The payments doubled. Then they doubled again. I never told you. And the twenty thousand in the winter. I never told you that was coming, or what it was for, because I didn't know. I still don't." I looked at my hands. "I didn't tell you because I didn't know what it meant, and I didn't want you to worry about it, and I wanted to keep it until I understood it."

Freda stared at me.

"Mom," she said. "That's literally what I said. About Dad. Word for word."

"I know."

"You were doing the exact same thing."

"I know," I said. "I heard it. While you were saying it."

She looked at me, and then she started to laugh. Not the careful laugh. Not the real one either, quite. Something in between, wet and helpless and a little hysterical, at midnight, on the end of the bed. After a moment I was laughing too. I don't know why. It wasn't funny. We sat there and laughed until she had to wipe her face again, and so did I.

"We're so bad at this," said Freda.

"We're terrible at it."

"We should be better. We're like, professionally good at finding out stuff."

"Other people's stuff," I said.



We worked out the terms, there on the bed, at half past midnight, like two lawyers. I insisted on that. She insisted on writing them down, on the back of a gas bill from my bedside table, in her neat small handwriting, because she said I'd try to change them in the morning.

She could see him. Not secretly. I would know where, and when, every time. I would meet him first, myself, by myself, somewhere public, in daylight, and we'd talk. Not about her. About him. If I didn't like what I heard, we'd talk about that too, all three of us. No more lies, in either direction. Not about him, and not about money, and not about anything.

"And not about Mr. Hale," said Freda.

"What about him?"

"You have to go back." She was writing it down. "Thursday. And not be mad."

"I'm allowed to be mad."

"You can be mad. You have to go back, though." She looked up from the gas bill. "He didn't tell you because I asked him not to. Kind of. I mean, I didn't ask, but he could tell. And he made me promise to tell you, and I didn't, for

two weeks, because I was scared. That's on me. Not him." She held out the pen. "Sign it."

I signed it. She signed it under me. She folded it in half and put it in the pocket of my sweater, which she was wearing, which meant I would never see it again.

She fell asleep there, a little while later, on the end of my bed, on top of the covers, curled up like a cat, the way she used to when she was six. I didn't wake her. I put the blanket from the chair over her and turned off the light and lay in the dark listening to her breathe.

In the morning, before she woke, I took my phone into the kitchen and found the text from the number with the local exchange, and wrote back.

Coffee. Saturday, ten. The place on the corner of Upshur. You're buying.

The answer came in less than a minute. I think he had been awake all night too.

Yes. Thank you. I'll be there at nine.

Aristeas

I wore the coat.

It was too warm for it, by then. The last week of April, and the trees along the highway were full and green, and the farm stands past Frederick had opened again, with hand-painted signs for asparagus and eggs. I wore it anyway, the green wool with the moth hole and the button I had finally sewn back on, on Wednesday night, at the kitchen table, while Freda typed beside me with the headphones around her neck instead of on, so she could talk.

He wasn't at the window.

That was the first thing. In twenty-seven Thursdays he had always been at the window, and on the porch before I had the engine off. I sat in the car for a moment with my hand on the key, looking at the house, and the curtain didn't move.

Then the door opened, and he came out.

He came out slowly. He came down the porch steps with both hands on the rail, not one, and stopped at the bottom to get his breath, and I saw that he had lost weight since the winter. More than I had let myself notice. The cardigan hung on him. His face had that gray under the weathering that I had seen last week and decided not to care about, and it was worse, and I cared.

He saw the coat. I saw him see it.

He didn't say anything. He stood at the bottom of his steps, in the sun, with one hand still on the rail, and waited for me.

I got out of the car and walked across the gravel and stopped in front of him.

"You should have told me," I said.

"Yes," he said.

"I know why you didn't."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he nodded, once, slowly, and something in his shoulders came down that I hadn't known was up.

"Thank you," he said.



We sat on the porch. He suggested it. He said the house was stuffy and the sun was out and he had been indoors too much that week, and I thought that he didn't want to climb the steps again so soon, and I didn't say so. He sat on the bench and I sat in one of the two chairs, and the kettle went on inside and he let it whistle, and neither of us got up.

"What I said," I said. "Last week. In the kitchen. About pretending to be other people for a living."

"It was true," he said.

"It was cruel."

"Yes. That's why it hurt. The cruel things that aren't true, you can put down." He was looking out at the field. It had been plowed since last week, long dark furrows all the way to the tree line. "I've been a great many people, Ms. Barnett. I've been them very carefully, so nobody would notice they'd gone. Bertie Pike's mother never knew. Kit's mother never knew. That's what I do. You weren't wrong."

"You let Freda know you."

"Freda's very hard to pretend in front of," he said. "So are you."

The kettle stopped whistling, inside, as it boiled itself quiet.

"How is she?" he said.

This time I answered. I told him. The end of the bed, and the pier, and the card from Phoenix in the box of baby teeth, and the hardware store on Georgia Avenue, and *it's Freda*, and ten seconds of nothing, and a man who hung up. I told him about the liquor store on Kennedy Street. I told him about the terms, on the back of a gas bill, signed by both of us, in the pocket of a sweater I would never see again.

I told him I was meeting Desmond on Saturday, for coffee, at ten. That Desmond had said he'd be there at nine.

He listened to all of it without interrupting. When I got to the gas bill, he laughed, the real one.

"She'll keep that," he said. "For years. You'll find it in a drawer when she's forty."

"I know."

"And you'll go on Saturday."

"I'll go." I looked at my hands. "I don't know what I'll say."

"You'll check," he said. "That's what you'll say. You'll ask him everything, very politely, and you'll write it all down afterward in the car, and then you'll go and find out whether it's true." He smiled at the field. "And some of it you won't be able to check. And you'll have to decide."

"Freda said that. About you."

"She's very like you," he said. "I don't think either of you know how much."



He gave me something, before we went in.

He reached into the pocket of the cardigan and took out a folded piece of paper, notebook paper, torn from a spiral, and held it out to me.

"This came on Tuesday," he said. "By post. It's addressed to me, but I think she'd want you to see it. Since there aren't any secrets now."

It was Freda's handwriting. The small neat handwriting from the back of the gas bill. Three lines.

Mr. Hale. Thank you for not telling. And for telling me to. I told her. All of it. You were right, it got lighter. F.

P.S. I typed the pier. I'm sorry nobody came for Bertie.

I read it twice. Then I folded it back up, along the creases she'd made, and gave it back to him. He put it in the pocket of his cardigan, and kept his hand over it for a moment, on the outside, the way Hatch used to keep his hand over the notebook.



We went in at eleven. He went up the porch steps slowly, with both hands, and I went behind him, not touching him, close enough. In the living room he sat down in his chair as if he had walked a long way, and picked up the notepad, and did not draw on it.

I set out the recorders. I didn't turn them on.

"Before you do," he said.

I looked up.

"Ms. Barnett," he said. "In all these Thursdays, you've never asked me my name."

"I know your name. You told me. The first day."

"I told you the name on the mailbox I keep meaning to paint." He was looking at the empty frame on the mantel. "That's the name this body came with. Tom Hale. It's a good name. He was a good man, I think, the one who had it first. I've tried to be careful with it." He was quiet a moment. "It isn't mine."

I waited.

"I had one, once," he said. "A long time ago. The first one. Before any of the others. I haven't said it aloud in..." He stopped, and seemed to count, and gave up. "In a very long time. I haven't told anybody what it was, in more lives than I could list for you. There didn't seem to be anybody to tell." He turned from the mantel and looked at me. "I'd like somebody to know it. I find I'd like that very much. While I..." He stopped again. "While there's time."

"You don't have to."

"I know I don't." He smiled, a little. "That's why I'd like to."

He said it.

It was a Greek name. Old. He said it slowly, carefully, in a way that was not quite English, with the weight in a different place than I would have put it, as if his mouth were remembering how. Four syllables. It sounded like something carved on a stone.

"Aristeas," he said.

I didn't write it down. I don't know why. I had written down everything he had said to me for seven months. I sat with my pen in my hand and didn't write it, and I think he saw that, and I think it was the right thing to have done.

"Aristeas," I said. Badly. I put the weight in the wrong place.

He laughed, softly.

“Close,” he said. “Nobody’s said it to me in a very long time. Nobody alive.” He looked down at the notepad, at the star, gone over so many times the lead shone. “The people who called me that called me Ari, mostly. When I was young. The first time I was young.”

“Can I call you that?”

He thought about it, seriously, the way he thought about everything Freda asked.

“Not on the tape,” he said. “Not in the transcript, and not in the book, if there is a book. Not to your client.” He paused. “But here. On the porch. When it’s just us.” He looked at me. “Yes. I think I’d like that.”

“Ari,” I said.

He closed his eyes for a moment, as if he were listening to something a long way off. Then he opened them, and picked up the pencil, and settled the notepad on his knee.

“Turn them on,” he said. “We’ve got a great deal to do, and I don’t know how many Thursdays.”

I didn’t ask him what he meant. I think I knew. I turned on the recorders, and said the date into them, and the time, and *Session twenty-seven*, and he looked out of the window at the plowed field, and began to draw.

The Letter

We ate lunch on the porch, too. Soup, from the dented pot, and bread from the supermarket in town that he said was improving, slowly, as a bad student improves when he is frightened of failing. He didn't eat much. He broke his bread into small pieces and moved them about the bowl, and I watched him do it and didn't say anything.

When we had finished, I went to the car and got the folder out of my bag.

I had carried it every Thursday since February. Ten Thursdays. It had sat on the floor by my chair, six feet from his knee, through the Carpathia and the boats and the fog and the pier, and every Thursday I had meant to take it out and every Thursday I had found a reason not to. The star, after I'd recognized it. Freda, after that. Being angry, after that.

On the back of a gas bill in my daughter's handwriting, at half past twelve on a Monday morning, it said *No more lies, in either direction*. I had signed it. I had not been thinking about Damon when I signed it. I was thinking about him now.

I came back up the porch steps and sat down and put the folder on the little table between us, on top of the soup bowls, and opened it.

"I found something," I said. "In February. Before the Carpathia card. I've been carrying it ever since. I meant to show you the day the card came, and I couldn't, and then I didn't." I turned the photocopy round so it faced him. "I'm sorry. I should have shown you weeks ago."

He looked at it. He didn't pick it up.

"What is it?"

“A letter,” I said. “From the Lincoln papers. At the Library of Congress. In one of Nicolay’s envelopes, the ones nobody’s asked for in twenty-two years.” I heard my voice go careful. “It’s dated April the thirteenth, 1865.”

He went very still.



He read it slowly. I watched him read it. I had read it so many times myself I knew where his eyes were by how long they stayed.

Mr. President. He stopped there, the first time, for a long moment, on the two words, on the hand. The long looping capitals. The most beautiful hand, he had told me in the winter, that he had ever seen on a bill of fare. I saw him know it. I saw his mouth move, very slightly, around a name he didn’t say.

Then he read on. *There is a man in this city who means to take your life.* The National Hotel. The speech on the lawn. *The last speech you would ever make.* Seward. The Kirkwood. The large young man who called himself Wood and Paine. The German who drank. The druggist’s clerk.

A young man of Charles County, lately a soldier of the rebellion, lame in the left leg, who is much at his table and knows the roads of Southern Maryland.

He stopped there for a long time.

“He named me,” he said quietly. “He named all of us. To the President. The day before.”

“Yes.”

“And it went on a pile.” He didn’t look up. *Anonymous. Warning. Filed.* Like mine.”

He read the rest. *We cannot spare you, Sir. Not now.* And the last line, by itself.

I have no name that would carry weight with you. I am one of those you spoke of.

He sat back.

His eyes had filled. He didn’t do anything about it. He sat on the bench on his porch in the April sun with the photocopy in front of him and let them, and looked out at the plowed field, and neither of us said anything for a long time.

“He tried,” he said at last. “The day before. He tried with everything he had, and he signed it with nothing, so it would only be about the President, and not about him.” He shook his head slowly. “I guessed, once. On Seventh Street, that summer, I guessed what he’d been writing. But I never knew. A hundred and sixty years, Ms. Barnett. I never knew what he’d said.”

“I’m sorry I kept it from you.”

“Don’t be,” he said. “You’ve just given it to me. That’s the only part that matters.” He wiped his face, finally, with the back of his hand, like a boy. “Thank you.”

Then he looked down at the page again, to read the last line one more time, I think.

And his eyes went to the margin.



I had been waiting for it. I had been waiting for it since February, if I’m honest. I watched it happen.

His eyes went down the last line, *I am one of those you spoke of*, and came to the end of it, and moved, because eyes do, a little to the left, into the margin. To the small thing drawn there in the same ink, beside the last line. A star, drawn without lifting the pen, crowded with foreign letters.

He stopped.

Not the way he stopped for the Carpathia. That was stillness. This was something else. His whole body stopped, like a clock stopping, and his face emptied, and his hand, which had been resting on the edge of the photocopy, stayed there, flat, pressing down, as if the page might lift off the table.

I didn’t count. I had counted, the first day, on the tape. I had counted at the Carpathia. I didn’t count now. I sat across the little table from him and waited, and I could hear the wind in the field, and a tractor, very far off, and my own heart.

Then, without looking down, he reached for the notepad on the bench beside him. He put it on the table, next to the photocopy. The top page was covered in his star, gone over so many times the lead shone.

He looked from one to the other.

The same five points. The same single line, never lifting. The same small letters crowded into the points, in the same order. One in pencil, gone over a thousand times by an old man's hand on a porch. One in brown ink, a hundred and sixty years old, in the margin of a letter to Abraham Lincoln, in the most beautiful hand on any bill of fare in Washington.

"Thank you for bringing this," he said.

That was all. His voice was perfectly level.



"It's your star," I said.

"Yes."

"I saw it in February. In the reading room. I thought it looked familiar, and I didn't know why, and I didn't think about it again. And then in March, the day you told me you were twelve, I looked at your notepad, and I knew." I made myself say the next thing. "Did Kit draw it? Did you? On his letter, somehow? Before it went?"

"No," he said. "I never saw this letter. I didn't know it existed until two minutes ago. You know that. You've just watched me find out."

I had. I knew it the way I knew my own hand.

"Then how is it on there?"

He looked at the two stars for a long time.

"I don't know," he said.

He said it as he had said it once before, in the winter, looking at a shaking card in the client's hand. The way a man says it who has not had to say it very often in a very long life, and doesn't like the taste.

"Who taught it to you?" I said. "The star."

"Somebody a very long time ago." He was still looking at the page. "The same person who taught me the song."

I sat with that. I thought of a young woman in a deck chair, on a cold night, wrapped in two blankets, humming to a child who couldn't sleep. *It's a very old song. Older than anything.*

"The governess hummed your song," I said slowly. "And Damon drew your star."

“Yes.”

“Two lives. Fifty years apart. Two different people.”

“Yes.”

“And they both had something of yours. Something nobody else has. Nobody alive.”

He didn’t answer.

“Ari,” I said. Quietly. It was the porch, and it was just us. “What does that mean?”

He looked up from the page, then. At me. And I saw that he didn’t know. That he was frightened, a little, that he didn’t know. And that underneath the fright there was something else, something I had never seen in his face in all the Thursdays, that I didn’t have a word for until I was halfway home.

Hope. It was hope.

“I don’t know,” he said again. “I don’t know, Ms. Barnett. I’ve spent a very long time thinking I was the only one.” He put one finger on the star in the margin, very lightly, as you’d touch something in a museum when the guard wasn’t looking. “May I keep this? The copy.”

“It’s yours. I made it for you. I just didn’t know I had.”

He folded it, very carefully, along the creases, and held it in both hands in his lap, and looked out at the field, and didn’t say anything else for a long time. I didn’t either. We sat on the porch in the sun and the wind came across the furrows, and somewhere a long way off the tractor turned at the end of a row and started back.



On the drive home I pulled into the gas station at the bottom of the hill, the one with the sign for night crawlers, and sat in the car with the engine running and took out my notebook.

Damon. 1865. The star.

E. P. 1912. The song.

Two people. Two lives. Fifty years. His marks.

And then, under it, because I was honest on paper even when I was not anywhere else:

He didn't know. He was frightened. He was glad.

I looked at that for a while. Then I wrote one more line, and underlined it, and put the notebook away and drove home.

Who else has he put away?

Spring Sale

He was there at nine. I know because I was there at a quarter to, and parked across the street, and watched him go in.

I want to tell you about that coffee, and I'm not going to, not all of it. It isn't mine to tell, any more than Freda's was Tom's. I'll tell you that he stood up when I came in, and didn't know what to do with his hands, and that he had bought me a coffee already and it had gone cold, and he went and bought another. That he looked at me across the table for a long time before he said anything, and then said, *You look exactly the same*, which was a lie, and *You look tired*, which wasn't.

I'll tell you I asked him everything. Very politely. With my notebook in my bag where he couldn't see it. Where he lived, and since when. Where he worked, and since when. How long sober, and how he knew, and who he called when it was bad. Phoenix, and what happened there. The card in March.

"I forgot her birthday," he said. He looked at the table. "I was drunk the whole of that January. I don't remember most of it. I found the card in a drawer in March, already bought, never sent, with her name on it. And I thought, if I send it now it's worse. And then I thought, if I don't send it at all, that's worse still." He turned his cup around. "I sent it. I wrote *sorry it's late*. That's all I wrote. Two words, on a card two months late, the year you lost everything." He looked up at me. "I knew about the story. I read it in Phoenix, online. I knew what was happening to you. I sent two words."

I didn't say anything to that. I didn't have to. He had said it all himself.

I wrote everything down in the car afterward, for forty minutes, in the parking space outside. Then I drove home and spent the rest of the weekend checking it. The hardware store. The apartment. The meeting on Tuesday nights at the church on Upshur. Most of it checked. Some of it I couldn't check, and never will.

Freda asked me on Sunday night what I'd decided.

"I haven't," I said.

"But you're going to see him again."

"Yes," I said. "I'm going to see him again."



On Monday I went back to the Library of Congress.

I hadn't been since February. The same reading room, the same lamps, the same librarian with her glasses on a chain, who looked at my reader card with its terrible photograph and then at me, and said, "You came back," as if she had been keeping track.

"I'm looking for auction catalogs," I said. "From a house here in the city. Carrow House. Spring sales, about seven years ago."

She didn't ask why. She went and looked, and came back, and said that the Library had collected auction catalogs for a very long time, from all the major houses and a good many minor ones, because the catalogs were often the only record of where a document had gone. Carrow House was in the collection. Every catalog they had ever printed, more or less, back to the 1950s. She could have the ones I wanted at the desk in an hour.

I waited the hour. I read the same page of a newspaper eleven times.

There were three, from the right year and the two around it. Heavy cream paper, as I remembered. Bound in gray card, with the brass doors embossed on the cover in gold. *CARROW HOUSE. SPRING SALE. Autograph Letters, Manuscripts and Historical Documents*. I had held a dozen of these, once, when I was working on the story, and I had read every lot description in every one of them, looking for forgeries. I had never once read the front matter. Who reads the front matter of an auction catalog?

The middle one had a foreword. Two pages, with a photograph at the top of the first.

It was him.

The same man as in photograph number seven, on the wall over the brown couch. White hair swept back. Bow tie. A beautifully cut gray suit. Not laughing, in this one. Smiling, with his chin up, at the camera, like a man who has been photographed a great many times and knows exactly what his face is doing. Under the picture, in small italic capitals:

GERALD WHITCOMBE, DIRECTOR OF CONSERVATION AND MANUSCRIPTS.

I read the foreword. I read it slowly, as Tom read Mrs. Dunleavy's page. It was about paper. About the care of old documents, and the patience it took, and the honor of handing a letter from one century into the next without harm. It was well written. It was charming. It was the voice of a man who was used to people listening.

And at the end of the second page, there was a paragraph of thanks. To the staff of the conservation studio, *without whom nothing in these pages would have come safely to sale*. And then one more line, by itself.

And to my apprentice of many years, it said, and gave his name.

My source's name. His real one. The one I had never written down, in any notebook, anywhere, in six years.

whose hands are already better than mine.

I sat in the reading room under the lamp, with the catalog open in front of me, and put my hand flat over that line, as Hatch used to keep his hand over his notebook. I didn't want anybody else to see it. There was nobody else at the table.

His apprentice. Of many years. The man who had taught him everything he knew about paper. Who had stood in front of the brass doors with his arm around his shoulders, hard, laughing, as you hold someone who belongs to you.

Somebody he trusted enough to let them choose where he would live.

I photographed the foreword, both pages, with no flash, as the sign on the wall asked. I didn't ask for a copy. I didn't need to hold this one.



It took me an hour that night to find out where Gerald Whitcombe was now.

He had retired from Carrow House the year after my story ran. There had been a little piece about it in the trade newsletter, with a photograph and a quote about forty years of happy work. He was seventy-nine. A widower. He lived in a stone house on forty acres outside Middleburg, in the hunt country in Virginia, an hour and a half west of my kitchen table. He was on the board of a historical society and a library foundation. He gave a talk, every spring, on the care of old paper.

And somebody had filmed one of the talks, three years ago, and put it online.

I watched it at the kitchen table with my headphones on. Forty minutes. He stood at a lectern in a bow tie, with slides behind him, and talked about the enemies of paper: light, damp, acid, and the human hand. He was very good. He was funny. The audience laughed in the right places.

At thirty-one minutes, somebody in the audience asked a question I couldn't hear. And Gerald Whitcombe put his head back and laughed.

I took the headphones off. I sat in the kitchen with the screen frozen on him, mid-laugh, his mouth wide open, his head back, exactly as he was in photograph number seven.

I knew that laugh. I had never heard it before tonight. And I knew it.



Freda came with me to Frederick on Saturday afternoon. She asked. I didn't have to think about it this time.

Kevin opened the door before we knocked again. Mrs. Dunleavy was by the window in her wheelchair with the crocheted blanket over her knees, in the same cardigan buttoned all the way to the top, and she watched us come up the ramp with her bird's eyes, and when we came in she said, "You came back," before we had our coats off.

"I said I would."

“People say all sorts of things.” She held out her hands. I gave her the composition book, the one with the masking tape on the spine, and she took it in both hands and held it in her lap and looked at it, and then looked at me. “Well? Did you find out where the car went?”

“Not yet,” I said. “But I think I’ve found out who was in it. One of them.”

I sat down on the couch next to her chair. Freda sat on the arm of it. I took out my phone.

“Mrs. Dunleavy,” I said. “You never saw him. You told me. You only heard him. Through the ceiling, for half an hour, and on the stairs.”

“Every step,” she said. “Click, click, click.”

“And the laugh.”

“And the laugh.” Her mouth went thin. “I’d know that laugh in my grave.”

“I’m going to play you something,” I said. “A man talking. For a minute or two. I’m not going to tell you anything about him. I just want you to listen.”

She looked at me for a long moment. Then she nodded, once, and folded her hands on top of the composition book, and closed her eyes.

I found the place. Thirty minutes and ten seconds. I turned the volume up all the way and held the phone near her ear.

Gerald Whitcombe’s voice came out of it, warm and easy and carrying, talking about the human hand, and how it was the greatest enemy of old paper and also its only friend. Mrs. Dunleavy sat perfectly still with her eyes closed. Freda had stopped breathing. Somewhere in the house, Darren’s music thumped faintly through a door.

At thirty-one minutes, the audience member asked a question. And Gerald Whitcombe laughed.

Mrs. Dunleavy’s eyes opened.

She didn’t say anything at first. She sat there with her hands on the notebook, very small in her wheelchair, and her face did something I had seen a great many faces do in my working life, the moment when a thing you have carried by yourself for years turns out to have been real, and you are not alone with it anymore.

“That’s him,” she said.

“Are you sure?”

"Six years," said Mrs. Dunleavy, "I've been hearing that laugh in my sleep." She looked at the phone. "That's him. That's the man who went down my stairs with that boy's whole life in a box and banged my new paint all the way to the bottom." Her voice cracked. She put one small cold hand over Freda's, on the arm of the chair, without seeming to notice she'd done it. "Who is he?"

I told her.

She said the name over to herself twice, quietly, as if she were writing it down in her head, with the date, and the time.



In the car, at the bottom of Kevin Dunleavy's cul-de-sac, I took my notebook out and wrote it down.

I had never written down a name in the Carrow House story. Not one, not in eight months, not in six years. I had kept my source's name out of every notebook I owned, and I had kept it out of this one too, even now, even after the catalog. I wrote this one anyway. He wasn't a source. He wasn't somebody I was protecting.

Gerald Whitcombe.

His teacher. Laughed. Leather heels. Two trips.

And under it, because there had been three of them, and Tom had made me see it, and I couldn't stop seeing it now:

Who was driving?

Freda read it upside down from the passenger seat. She'd been reading over my shoulder since she was four.

"Are you going to go see him?" she said. "The teacher?"

"Not yet."

"When?"

"When I know who was driving," I said, and started the car.

The Second Part

The money came on a Wednesday.

It had come on Mondays all winter, and on a Saturday once in March, and now it came on a Wednesday, at a little after eleven in the morning, while I was at the kitchen table writing four hundred words about a dentist's new whitening service. My phone buzzed on the table. It was the bank.

It was more than the twenty thousand in the winter. It was more than I had made in the two years before the letter came, put together. And it had not come from Aldine, Mercer and Voss. It had come by wire from a bank in a different city, one I had never been to either, a long way from the firm's, and the line in the note was one I had read once before, in February, on the night of the courier and the Carpathia card.

With our client's thanks, at the close of the second part.

I sat and looked at it for a long time. Then I texted Freda, at school, because we had terms, and the terms said money too.

Client paid. A lot. Tell you tonight. Not worried. Just telling you.

She wrote back in under a minute, from what I very much hoped was the hallway between classes.

ok. thank you for telling me. how much is a lot

Tonight.

thats a LOT a lot isnt it



The card came that night, by courier, at a quarter to nine.

The same young man in the same reflective jacket. He knew my name by then. He said, "Evening, Ms. Barnett," and held out the tablet for my finger, and the envelope, and said, "Have a good one," and was gone.

Freda was at the kitchen table. She didn't say *open it*. She waited, with her hands folded on top of the closed laptop, and watched me do it.

One card. No letter. Heavy cream paper, the same as every time.

I could barely read it.

The hand had gone. That's the only way I can say it. The shapes were still the old schooled shapes, the long loops, the lean to the right, but they wandered now. They drifted off the line and came back. The pen had stopped and started so many times that the words were made of pieces. It had been written very slowly by someone who could no longer hold a pen properly and had refused to let anyone else hold it for him.

It took me a long minute, under the kitchen light, to make it out.

Please ask him about New York. 1780.

Freda read it upside down. She didn't say anything for a while.

"He's really sick," she said at last. Quietly.

"Yes."

"Like, really sick."

"I think so."

She looked at the card. Then she looked at me.

"Mom," she said. "What happened in New York in 1780?"



I read it to him on the porch.

It was the first week of May, and warm, properly warm, the first day of it. He was sitting on the bench in his shirtsleeves when I drove up, with the cardigan folded beside him, and he didn't get up. He raised one hand from the rail, which was as good as coming down the steps, and I came up and sat in the chair.

I gave him the card first. Before the words. He took it and held it in the sun, and looked at the hand for a long time, as he had in the winter, the long strokes, the stops, the places where the pen had wandered off the line.

“He wrote this in bed,” he said quietly. “Propped up. With the card on a tray, or a book. You can see where it slipped.” He touched one place, where a letter dragged sideways. “And somebody offered to write it for him. And he wouldn’t let them.” He was quiet. “I know that look on a page. I’ve written like that myself, once or twice. Toward the end.”

He didn’t say the end of what.

Then he read the words.

I watched his face. I had watched it for every card. Eleven seconds, the first day. Forty, at the Carpathia. This time I didn’t count, and I didn’t need to, because what came into his face wasn’t stillness at all.

He smiled. Slowly. Not happily, quite. The smile of a man who has just been dealt a card he knew was in the deck, and had been waiting for, and wishes he hadn’t been.

“Ah,” he said.

“Were you there?”

“Yes.”

“New York. 1780.”

“Yes.” He set the card down on the bench beside him, very gently, face up. “It was a war, Ms. Barnett. The same one everyone learns in school. Only I was on the other side of it.”

“The British?”

“The losing one,” he said. “As it turned out.” He looked out over the field, which was green now, all of it, a low green fuzz over the furrows all the way to the trees. “I spent the best part of two years in that city hunting a spy. And I lost. And then there was a country, partly because I lost.” He was quiet a moment. “I’ve never decided how I feel about that. Two hundred and forty-six years, and I’ve never decided.”

“Is that what you’ll tell me? Next?”

“If you’ll come,” he said. “If you’d still like to.”



I told him about Gerald Whitcombe, then. I had been saving it.

I told him about the catalog, and the foreword, and the apprentice of many years whose hands were already better than his. I didn't say my source's name, even then, and he didn't ask. I told him about the stone house on forty acres in the hunt country, and the talk every spring on the enemies of paper, and the laugh at thirty-one minutes. I told him about Mrs. Dunleavy with her eyes closed and her hands folded on the composition book, and *That's him*, and her small cold hand on top of Freda's.

He listened to all of it without moving. At the end he was quiet for a long time.

"His teacher," he said.

"Yes."

"The man who taught him the trade. Who'd known him since he was a boy, very likely. Who he'd have trusted with anything." He shook his head, slowly. "Somebody you'd let choose where you lived, Ms. Barnett, when you were more frightened than you'd ever been."

"Yes."

"And you haven't gone to see him."

"No," I said. "Not yet."

He looked at me, and I saw him work out why, and smile, a little.

"Who was driving," he said.

"That's exactly what I said."

"I know," he said. "Freda told me. She wrote again." He touched the pocket of the folded cardigan beside him. "She writes a very good letter. Short. She doesn't waste words." He looked at me sideways. "She says her father fixed your kitchen tap."

I felt my face go hot.

"It's dripped for nine years," I said. "Since he left, actually. He knew exactly what was wrong with it. He had it fixed in twenty minutes. With a part he'd brought with him, in his pocket, because he remembered."

"And you checked it."

"Afterward. Yes. Twice."

"And?"

"It doesn't drip," I said.

He laughed. He laughed until he had to hold onto the rail, there on the bench in the first warm sun of May, and after a moment, I did too.



He didn't go in, that day. Neither did I. We did the whole session on the porch, the recorders on the little table between us, with the field going green in front of us and the birds back at the feeder, and he didn't tell me about New York. Not yet. He said he wanted to think about where to start. He said there were people in it he hadn't thought about properly in a very long time, and he wanted to do them justice.

So instead he told me about the boy on the pier. About Bertie. What happened to him after the bag and the street door and the rain, which he had said was another Thursday, and which turned out to be this one. I'm not going to put it here. It isn't part of this story. I'll tell you only that he made the best of it, as he said he would, and that it took him a very long time, and that somewhere in Bootle, in a box of family papers, there are letters to a mother in a careful boy's hand that never once mention the Carpathia.

At three he said that was enough. He stood up, slowly, with his hand on the rail, and picked up the cardigan, and the card from the bench, and held them both.

"Next Thursday, Ms. Barnett," he said.

"Next Thursday."

I went down the steps. At the bottom I turned around, because I had nearly forgotten.

"Should I bring the coat?" I said. "For New York."

He looked at me from the top of the steps, in his shirtsleeves, with the card in his hand, and the sun on him, and the empty frame on the mantel behind him through the open door, its glass polished clean, still waiting.

"No," he said. "You won't need the coat for this one."

He smiled.

"It was summer," he said. "And everybody was lying."



End of Book Two

Facts

The Carpathia sailed from New York on Thursday, April 11, 1912, bound for the Mediterranean and Fiume, with about 740 passengers: American tourists in first class and emigrants going home to Hungary and Croatia in third.

Her only wireless operator, Harold Cottam, was twenty-one. Just after midnight on April 15 he was in his cabin, getting ready for bed, still wearing his headphones while he waited on a reply from another ship. He had been listening to the Cape Cod station, which had messages for the Titanic, and he called the Titanic to offer to pass them on. The answer came back: "Come at once. We have struck a berg. It's a CQD, old man."

Captain Arthur Rostron told the Senate inquiry: "the wireless operator was in his cabin, at the time, not on official business at all, but just simply listening as he was undressing. He was unlacing his boots at the time. He had this apparatus on his ear, and the message came. That was the whole thing. In 10 minutes, maybe he would have been in bed, and we would not have heard the messages."

Rostron was angry at being woken, then turned the ship within minutes. He shut off the heat and hot water so all the steam went to the engines, posted extra lookouts, put a doctor in each of the three dining saloons, an Englishman, an Italian and a Hungarian, and had chair slings and canvas ash bags ready at the gangways to lift up the people who could not climb, and the children. His crew called him the Electric Spark. He was seen to raise his hand to his cap and pray while he gave orders, and later said, "I can only conclude another hand than mine was on the helm."

The Carpathia ran fifty-eight miles through the ice in the dark, faster than she had been built to go, firing rockets as she came. The first boat, No. 2, came alongside at about ten past four. Its officer, Joseph Boxhall, told Rostron the Titanic had gone down at 2:20. The last boat, No. 12, came in at about half past eight, overloaded, with Second Officer Charles Lightoller the last survivor up the ladder. The Californian, which had been near enough to see the Titanic's rockets and whose wireless operator had gone to bed, arrived after it was over.

The Carpathia's passengers gave up their cabins and their clothes, and sewed coats for the children out of the ship's blankets.

Four people who died in the boats or soon after were buried at sea at four o'clock that afternoon. One of them has never been identified.

Harold Bride, the Titanic's junior wireless operator, had his feet crushed and frozen. He was carried to the Carpathia's wireless cabin and helped Cottam send the names of the survivors. Rostron ordered names first and nothing to the press. Inquiries from newspapers went unanswered, and so did those from President Taft about his aide, Major Archibald Butt, who was lost.

The Carpathia met thick fog near the Nantucket shoals and groped through it for hours at slow speed, sounding her whistle. It lifted on Thursday afternoon, and at six she passed the Sandy Hook lightship.

She came up the river at about half past nine on the night of April 18, in a cold driving rain, through a crowd of tugs full of reporters shouting offers through megaphones. Rostron let none of them aboard. She went first to the White Star pier and lowered the Titanic's lifeboats, then to the Cunard pier, Pier 54, where tens of thousands of people were waiting.

The United States Senate opened its inquiry the next morning at the Waldorf-Astoria. Rostron was the first witness. Cottam sold his story to the New York Times for \$750.

The Seikilos song was carved on a marble column as a memorial, probably in the first century, at Tralles, near what is now Aydın in Turkey. William Ramsay found it in 1883. It is the oldest complete piece of music that survives, notes and words together. It begins: “While you live, shine.”

Bertie Pike, Stan, Lyle, Evans and Fennimore are invented. So are Lowell Hatch, his death, and his notice in the Tribune; Mr. Ainsley; the young woman Tom calls Eleanor Penhallow; and everything that happened in their boat. The real people in this book do only what the record says they did.